

TWO BAGS, NO PLAN

An Unreliable Account of Getting Gloriously Lost

By

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DEDICATION

*For every person who has ever left somewhere before they were
finished with it.*

And for anyone who has been waiting for themselves to be ready.

This book is for you.

With gratitude,

Dolat Khan

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Chapter One

The Last Sensible Morning

In Which Two Grown Men Decide, Against All Available Evidence, That They Know What They Are Doing

There is a particular kind of madness that overtakes otherwise sensible people in the weeks before a long trip. It begins quietly — a sticky note on the fridge, a browser tab left open — and then, before you quite know what has happened, you are standing in the middle of your bedroom at eleven-thirty on a Tuesday night, holding a travel-sized tube of toothpaste in one hand and a Spanish phrasebook in the other, wondering if you really need to pack both pairs of trousers.

Alex had been in this condition for approximately three weeks.

The bedroom of his small apartment on the fourth floor of a slightly crooked building in the city looked less like a room now and more like the aftermath of a moderate explosion in a luggage shop. There were clothes on the bed, clothes on the chair, clothes draped over the wardrobe door in the optimistic fashion of someone who believes that gravity is merely a suggestion. A

backpack — navy blue, fifty litres, purchased after two hours of agonised deliberation at an outdoor equipment shop — sat open in the corner like a hungry mouth, having so far consumed one rain jacket, a power bank, three books he would never read, and a pair of sandals that he had already decided were wrong but had not yet found the courage to remove.

On the desk, underneath a coffee cup that had gone cold, was The List.

The List had started its life as a modest half-page of essentials. It had since grown to four pages, been revised eleven times, and now included such critical entries as "investigate whether Moltravia uses the same plug sockets as Kalvenia" and "check if yoghurt is available in Drevska" — two questions that, taken together, painted a fairly accurate portrait of where Alex's head was at.

He sat down on the edge of the bed, which creaked in the way that beds do when they want you to know they've had enough, and looked at the backpack. The backpack, to its credit, said nothing.

"Right," Alex said aloud, to no one in particular. "Right."

This was his third "right" in the last twenty minutes. It was not going especially well.

* * *

The trip had been Sam's idea, which is the sort of thing that sounds like an explanation but is really an accusation dressed in polite clothing.

Sam — full name Samuel Osei Korantema, though he had never once in his thirty-one years of life gone by anything other than Sam — had arrived at Alex's door six weeks earlier on a Saturday afternoon, carrying a bottle of something cold and a look

on his face that Alex had learned, over seven years of friendship, to regard with a certain amount of suspicion.

"I've been thinking," Sam had said, settling himself into the armchair in the way that suggested he planned to stay for a while.

"About what."

"About how neither of us has gone anywhere in two years."

Alex had looked up from the book he was only half-reading. "I went to my cousin's wedding in March."

"That's not going anywhere, that's an obligation with a cake."

This was, Alex had to admit, a reasonable point. He had put the book down.

"I'm thinking," Sam had continued, leaning forward with the particular energy of a man who has already made a decision and is now in the process of persuading someone else that it was their idea too, "that we should take a proper trip. Not a weekend. Not a city break. A real trip. Three, maybe four weeks. Just go."

"Go where?"

"Somewhere we've never been. Somewhere interesting. Somewhere we'd have to actually think about."

"That's not a destination, Sam. That's a feeling."

"Exactly," Sam had said, as though this settled the matter entirely.

There had followed, over the next two hours, a conversation that moved through several distinct phases: initial resistance (Alex), enthusiastic escalation (Sam), reluctant curiosity (Alex), detailed logistics discussion (both of them), and finally a sort of warm, slightly reckless agreement that happens between old

friends late on Saturday afternoons when the light is nice and the sensible part of the brain has temporarily stepped out for air.

They decided, more or less simultaneously, on a route that would take them through three countries they had never visited, none of which they could pronounce with any confidence, and all of which had been recommended by a travel blog that Sam had found at two in the morning and which, upon reflection, may or may not have still been active.

Alex had felt, walking home that evening, something that he hadn't felt in rather a long time. Not excitement exactly — that would come later, and then leave again, and then come back, in the erratic fashion of a bus that doesn't quite stick to its timetable. What he felt was the pleasing, slightly terrifying sensation of having committed to something before he'd had time to think it all the way through.

It was, he thought, probably either a very good idea or a very stupid one.

In his experience, those two things were often the same thing wearing different hats.

* * *

Sam's preparation for the trip was, by contrast, almost aggressively minimal.

Where Alex had lists and sub-lists and a colour-coded packing spreadsheet that he had constructed during a particularly anxious Sunday afternoon and which he was not entirely proud of, Sam's approach could be summarised in three words: pack the bag.

This was not laziness. Alex had known Sam long enough to understand the difference between laziness and a genuine philosophical position, and Sam's position — arrived at through

years of travel and a natural resistance to anything that felt like homework — was that the things you forgot were rarely the things that mattered, and the things that went wrong were rarely the things you had planned for anyway.

"What if we need something we haven't packed?" Alex had asked, the week before departure.

"Then we'll find it," Sam had said.

"What if we can't find it?"

"Then we'll manage without it."

"What if we can't manage without it?"

Sam had looked at him with the patient expression of a man who has had this conversation before. "Alex. We're going on a trip, not to the moon. Every city we're going to has shops."

"Not all shops have the same things."

"Name one thing you're worried about not finding."

"Antacids."

Sam had stared at him for a long moment. "You're thirty-two years old."

"Exactly. I know my stomach."

In the end, Alex packed the antacids. He also packed a small sewing kit, a portable door alarm, a notebook he had already dedicated to "important observations," a second notebook for backup, and a small laminated card on which he had written down the emergency phone numbers for three countries, two embassies, and his mother.

Sam packed clothes, a phone charger, his camera, and a paperback. He also packed, with a thoroughness that Alex found

both impressive and slightly insulting, approximately forty percent more room in his bag than Alex had managed.

"How," Alex had said, staring at the space, "is that even possible."

"I left room," Sam said simply.

"For what?"

"For things I find along the way."

Alex had looked at his own bag, which was already groaning under the weight of its contents like a man who has had slightly too much at dinner and is trying to be polite about it. He said nothing. There was, he felt, nothing useful to say.

* * *

The morning of departure arrived in the way that mornings of departure always do — too early, slightly surreal, with the quality of light that makes everything look both more significant and more ordinary than it actually is.

Alex had been awake since five. This was not because his alarm had gone off at five — it hadn't, it was set for six-thirty — but because his brain, which had been quiet and cooperative all week, had chosen four fifty-three in the morning to suddenly remember every possible thing that could go wrong and present them in a rapid, unhelpful slideshow.

Had he cancelled the milk? He had. Had he set the thermostat? He had. Had he told his neighbour, Mrs Feldman on the second floor, to keep an eye on the post? He had, and she had said yes and then talked to him for twenty-five minutes about her nephew in Villaforte who had also travelled a lot and had ended up, she said, with a parasite, though she could not now remember which kind.

He lay in the dark and made peace, eventually, with the fact that he was not going to sleep again. He made tea. He checked the bag one final time. He stood at the window and watched the city do that particular thing it does in the early morning — quiet, purposeful, going about its business without him — and felt, quite suddenly and without warning, a version of the thing Sam had been talking about on that Saturday afternoon six weeks ago.

He was actually going.

He picked up his bag. He left.

* * *

The taxi to the airport was driven by a man named Ference, according to the app, who was playing something on the radio that Alex could not identify but which seemed to involve an accordion and a great deal of feeling. Ference did not speak for the first ten minutes of the journey, which Alex appreciated. When he did speak, it was to ask, without any particular preamble, whether Alex was travelling for work or pleasure.

"Pleasure," Alex said.

Ference considered this. "Where to?"

"Drevska, first. Then Kalvenia. Then maybe Moltravia, if we have time."

Ference's eyes appeared briefly in the mirror. "Moltravia," he repeated, with an intonation that was not quite surprise and not quite concern, but something hovering between the two.

"Is that — have you been?"

"My wife's cousin is from Moltravia," Ference said. "Nice people." He paused. "Very enthusiastic drivers."

"Ah," said Alex.

"You'll be fine," Ference added, in the way that people say things they want to be true.

They drove the rest of the way in companionable silence, the city giving way to the grey pre-dawn arteries of the motorway, and Alex watched it all go past the window and tried to remember the last time he had simply sat in a car and gone somewhere without knowing exactly what was waiting on the other end.

He couldn't, actually.

It turned out to be a rather nice feeling.

* * *

Stravnik International Airport at seven in the morning was doing its best impression of organised chaos, which is to say it was mostly chaos with some good signage.

Alex found Sam near the departures board, holding two coffees and looking, as he almost always looked, like a man who had arrived at the exact right moment by accident. He was wearing his backpack on one shoulder in the casual way that Alex had never quite managed — Alex's own backpack required two shoulders and what felt like a small ceremony of adjustment before it sat correctly — and he was grinning.

"You look," Sam said, handing over a coffee, "like a man who has not slept."

"I slept," Alex said.

"When?"

"Between four fifty-three and approximately four fifty-six."

Sam nodded slowly. "Solid."

They checked the board. Their flight to Drevska was on time, which Alex noted with a relief that was slightly disproportionate, and was departing from Gate 14, which was — according to the map on the board — on the far side of the terminal, past security, through what appeared to be an entire separate wing, and then some.

"Right," Alex said. "We should probably—"

"We have two hours," Sam said.

"I know, but security can take—"

"Alex."

"—longer than you expect, especially if—"

"Alex."

"—there's a queue and then the bag scan, and I have—"

"Alex," Sam said, with the calm of a man who has infinite patience and has simply decided to use it all at once. "Drink your coffee."

Alex drank his coffee.

* * *

Security at Stravnik International was staffed, on this particular morning, by a rotating cast of characters whose relationship with time appeared to operate on entirely different principles from the rest of the world.

There was the woman at the document check who examined Alex's passport with the intensity of someone reading a rare manuscript, turning it over twice, holding it up briefly as though checking it against the light, and then stamping it with the same energy she might use to stamp out a small fire. There was

the man at the conveyor belt who watched Alex try to figure out the tray system — shoes in one, liquids in another, laptop out, jacket off, bag through — with the serene expression of someone watching a very slow but ultimately harmless comedy.

The comedy reached its natural peak when Alex, having placed his backpack on the belt, was called back by an officer who indicated, with the professional gravity of a man delivering important news, that he would need to remove and examine the contents of the bag's front pocket.

The front pocket contained: one lip balm, one receipt from a coffee shop dated three weeks ago, a crumpled emergency contact card, six coins of uncertain denomination, and — this was the part — a blister pack of antacids.

The officer held up the antacids.

Alex looked at them. The officer looked at them. A beat passed.

"Antacids," Alex said.

The officer turned the blister pack over, read the back, and appeared to consider the matter from several angles before placing it, with a small nod, back on the tray.

"Have a good trip," he said.

"Thank you," said Alex, with the particular sincerity of a man who means it entirely.

Sam, who had cleared security four minutes earlier and was waiting on the other side with his arms folded and an expression of deep amusement, said nothing. He didn't need to. The expression said everything.

"Not a word," Alex said.

"I haven't said anything."

"I can tell you're thinking something."

"I'm thinking," Sam said pleasantly, "that we should find the gate."

* * *

Gate 14 was, as suspected, a considerable distance away. It was the kind of distance that makes you wonder why, given that airports are essentially buildings, they are always so much larger on the inside than they appear from the outside. They walked past a pharmacy, two coffee chains, a shop selling neck pillows and eye masks and all the other equipment of the long-distance traveller, and an inexplicable store that appeared to sell only chocolate and scarves.

"Why is there always a scarf shop," Alex said.

"People get cold," Sam said.

"In the airport?"

"On the plane."

"That's what the blanket is for."

"Not everyone gets a blanket."

Alex considered this. "That seems like a design flaw."

"The entire airport economy," Sam said, "is built on design flaws."

This was, Alex thought, probably true.

They found seats at the gate with forty minutes to spare. The gate area had filled with the particular mixture of humanity that airports collect in the early morning: a family with three children who were already in full operational mode despite the hour, an elderly couple reading books in the comfortable silence of

two people who have run out of things they need to say but haven't run out of things they enjoy, a group of young women with matching luggage tags who were laughing about something on someone's phone, and a man in a business suit who was on a call and had apparently decided that the gate area was an appropriate venue for what sounded like a moderately serious disagreement about quarterly projections.

Alex opened his notebook — the first one, the one designated for "important observations" — and wrote the date at the top of the first page. He paused. He wrote, beneath it: *Gate 14. Waiting. It is beginning.*

He looked at this for a moment and decided it was the right amount of portentous without being embarrassing.

Across from him, Sam had taken out his camera — a small, battered digital thing that he'd had for years and refused to replace despite its various quirks, including a tendency to take slightly overexposed photos in strong light that Sam maintained gave them "character" — and was quietly photographing the elderly couple reading their books.

The couple didn't notice. Or if they did, they didn't mind.

"Good shot?" Alex asked.

"Maybe. You can never tell until later."

"Is that a photography rule or a life rule?"

Sam thought about it. "Both, probably."

* * *

The boarding announcement, when it came, had the quality of a starting pistol — an immediate and slightly irrational surge of people towards the gate, despite the fact that the plane was not going anywhere without them and the seats were assigned and

there was, objectively, no advantage to being first on board other than the psychological satisfaction of being first on board, which is apparently sufficient for a substantial portion of the human population.

Alex and Sam waited until the initial rush had subsided, then joined the queue at a point where it had thinned to something manageable. The woman scanning boarding passes had the particular look of someone who has done this approximately fifteen thousand times and found it neither interesting nor uninteresting — it was simply a thing she did, with the automaticity of breathing.

"Enjoy your flight," she said, scanning Alex's pass.

"Thank you," Alex said. And then, because he'd been awake since five and the coffee had worn off and he was feeling slightly giddy with the particular lightness that comes just before you do something you can't undo: "We're going somewhere we've never been. First time."

The woman looked at him. Something shifted very slightly in her expression — not quite a smile, but adjacent to one. "Where to?"

"Drevska. Then on."

"I've heard it's beautiful in October."

"It's October," Alex said, with a feeling of warm coincidence.

"Well then," she said. "You're in luck."

He walked down the jetbridge feeling, rather unexpectedly, like he was.

The plane was a medium-sized affair — not the enormous double-decked giants that crossed oceans, but a solid, no-nonsense aircraft with two seats on one side of the aisle and three on the other, and overhead bins that were already becoming subjects of negotiation by the time Alex and Sam found their row.

They were seated together, which Alex had checked three times during the booking process and then once more the previous evening, because the idea of being separated on a first flight — of sitting next to a stranger instead of Sam while also trying to navigate the existential weightiness of actually going — had seemed like an unnecessary additional complication.

Sam took the window. Alex took the middle. The aisle seat was occupied, eventually, by a small round man carrying an impressively oversized bag that he managed to fit into the overhead bin through a combination of persistence and an apparent renegotiation of the laws of physics. He settled into his seat with a satisfied exhale and immediately fell asleep, which Alex found both admirable and slightly enviable.

The safety demonstration was performed by a flight attendant who had clearly decided that if she was going to do this, she was going to do it properly, gesturing at the exits with a clarity and conviction that suggested she believed, not unreasonably, that knowing where the exits were was actually important. Alex watched. He always watched. Sam, as always, read his book.

"What if something actually happens," Alex said, at the bit about flotation devices.

"Then I'll look at you," Sam said, "and you'll tell me what to do."

"That's—" Alex paused. "Okay, that's fair."

The engines built to a low, resonant hum. The plane began to move. Alex tucked his notebook into the seat pocket in front of

him, because it seemed right to have it to hand, and then looked out past Sam at the airport falling away — the terminal, the ground crew in their high-visibility jackets, the other planes standing in patient rows waiting for their own mornings.

The runway accelerated beneath them.

Then the ground dropped away, and there was just sky.

Alex sat back. He breathed. Somewhere over his left shoulder, the city where he had spent the last three years of his life — the apartment, the job, the pleasant and slightly uneventful routine of it all — was receding to something that looked, from up here, very small.

He picked up his notebook. Beneath *Gate 14. Waiting. It is beginning.* he wrote one more line, and then closed it.

He didn't need to write anything else just yet. There was, for the first time in a rather long time, simply the going.

—

What he had written, if you are wondering, was this:

Two bags. No plan. Here we go.

Chapter Two

In Which We Leave

In Which the Plane Does Not Crash, Though I Consider This a Near Thing on at Least Three Separate Occasions

The wheels left the ground at eight forty-seven in the morning, and for approximately four seconds, I felt genuinely, unreservedly happy.

Then the plane banked left, the city tilted in the window at an angle that seemed to me unnecessary and slightly aggressive, and my stomach lodged a formal complaint.

"You've gone green," Sam said, without looking up from his book.

"I haven't."

"You're the colour of old soup."

"I'm perfectly fine," I said, in the manner of a man who has decided that if he says something with enough conviction it will eventually become true.

This is a technique I have employed throughout my life with mixed results. On this occasion, it was not working especially well.

I should explain something about myself and planes. I do not dislike flying. I am not afraid of it, precisely. What I am is what I would call "aeronautically attentive" — which is to say that I am aware, at all times, of the fact that I am inside a metal object moving at five hundred miles per hour through the sky, and I find this awareness difficult to fully suppress regardless of how many times I am told that it is statistically safer than driving. I have always found the statistics argument somewhat beside the point. When a car goes wrong, it pulls over. When a plane goes wrong, the options are considerably more limited. I have never found a satisfactory counter-argument to this observation, and neither, in my experience, has anyone else, though many people have tried.

Sam, who has flown more times than he can remember and who treats the inside of an aircraft with roughly the same level of concern he brings to sitting in his own kitchen, read his book.

* * *

We broke through the cloud somewhere around four minutes after takeoff, and the sky above it was — I want to choose this word carefully — extraordinary. Not the flat, slightly disappointing blue that you get at ground level on a clear day, but something deeper and more deliberate, a blue that seemed to have been specifically selected for the purpose and was absolutely certain of itself. Below us, the clouds looked solid and white and arranged, like something a child might draw if asked to draw a sky. Above us, nothing. Just that blue, going on in every direction without any apparent intention of stopping.

I stared at it for quite a long time.

"There it is," Sam said, still reading.

"How did you know I was looking?"

"You always make that sound."

"What sound?"

"The one you just made."

I had not been aware of making a sound. I made a note to be more aware of the sounds I make.

What struck me — what always strikes me, though I suspect I forget it the moment I land and only remember it again the next time I am thirty thousand feet above the surface of the earth — is how entirely different the world looks from up here. Down there, somewhere beneath those clouds, were cities and motorways and supermarkets and offices where people were having meetings about things, and disputes about parking spaces, and all the ten thousand small urgencies that constitute a normal Tuesday morning. Up here, there was just the blue and the cloud and the knowledge that we were going somewhere none of it could follow.

This, I thought, was probably the point of travel. Not the destination. This. The leaving.

I wrote it down. I write everything down. Sam finds this habit mildly amusing and has never once commented on it, which I appreciate.

* * *

The flight to Drevska was four hours and twenty minutes, which is a length of time that reveals certain things about a person's character that they might prefer to keep private.

I will tell you what I did during those four hours and twenty minutes. I am not proud of all of it, but I believe in full disclosure.

I read eleven pages of the in-flight magazine, which was mostly advertisements for watches that cost more than my car, and one article about airport design that used the phrase "liminal space" so many times that I began to suspect the author was being paid by the word. I attempted to watch a film. The film I selected was, according to the description, a sophisticated heist thriller set in Vienna. This turned out, owing to a navigational error with the

touch-screen that I am unable to fully explain, to be a film about a dog who saves Christmas. The dog was called Biscuit. I watched six minutes of it before conscience intervened. I then put on a podcast about Drevska that I had downloaded three weeks earlier and which I had been meaning to listen to since. The presenter was engaging and knowledgeable and exactly twenty-two minutes into the episode said "as we'll explore in the next episode," at which point I discovered there was no next episode downloaded. I had downloaded one episode of a twelve-episode series. This is, I think, a reasonable metaphor for how I generally approach preparation.

Sam read his book. He turned a page every few minutes with the serenity of a monk engaged in something both purposeful and peaceful. Once he made a small sound that might have been a laugh. Once he dog-eared a page with a conviction that suggested the passage in question had done something to him. At no point did he check the time, look out the window, fidget, or do any of the things that I was doing essentially continuously.

"What's the book about?" I asked, at some point over the mountains.

"A man who walks across a country."

"What happens?"

"He walks. He notices things."

"And then?"

Sam looked at me with an expression of profound patience. "Then the book ends."

I turned back to the window. Below us, the cloud had thinned enough to reveal a suggestion of landscape — dark shapes that might have been forests, a pale line that might have been a river. The world down there going about its business, entirely

indifferent to the fact that I was passing over it at altitude in a state of mild existential enquiry.

* * *

I should say something about Sam, because he will be in this book a great deal and you deserve some introduction.

Samuel Osei Korantema — Sam to everyone, Samuel to no one, not even his mother, who had given him the name and then apparently decided not to use it — was thirty-one years old, two inches taller than me, and possessed of the particular quality of stillness that some people have and that I have always found both admirable and faintly suspicious. He worked as a graphic designer, which meant he spent his professional life thinking carefully about how things looked and whether they worked, and this habit had, over the seven years I had known him, extended itself to most other areas of his life as well. He thought before he spoke. He noticed things I missed. He packed efficiently and without drama. He was, in summary, a better traveller than I was, and quite possibly a better person, though I maintain certain reservations on that last point and reserve the right to revise my position as evidence accumulates.

We had met through a mutual friend at a birthday party where the music was too loud and neither of us particularly wanted to be there. We had ended up in the kitchen — the universal sanctuary of people who find parties slightly too much — and talked for two hours about nothing in particular, which is usually how the best friendships begin. He had seemed, from the start, like someone who had figured out something I hadn't yet managed to figure out. I had not yet determined what, exactly, it was. Seven years in, I was still working on it.

He had suggested this trip in the direct, unfussy way he suggested most things — not as a question, exactly, but not quite as a statement either. More like a fact that had not yet been agreed

upon. "We should go somewhere," he had said. "Properly. Three weeks. Before we talk ourselves out of it."

I had spent approximately four days talking myself out of it, and then agreed.

* * *

Lunch arrived.

I say "lunch" in the same generous spirit that an estate agent might describe a cupboard as a "bijou studio apartment." What appeared on my tray was a foil-covered rectangle that, when peeled back with the cautious optimism of a man opening a letter from the tax office, revealed something described on the menu card as "roasted chicken with Mediterranean vegetables and herbed couscous." The chicken appeared to have been roasted sometime last Tuesday and had spent the intervening days in a state of quiet resignation. The Mediterranean vegetables — three cubes of courgette, two pieces of red pepper, and what I believe was a solitary olive that had become separated from its family and had not taken it well — had the defeated look of things that had once had ambitions.

The couscous, to its credit, was fine. It asked nothing of me. I respected that.

"How's yours?" I asked Sam.

"Fine," he said.

"Just fine?"

He looked at me with the patient expression of a man who has learned, through long experience, that some questions answer themselves. "Alex," he said. "It's airplane food. It's not meant to be good. It's meant to get you from one country to another country without your blood sugar dropping to a level that causes incidents."

I considered pointing out that "incidents" was a rather dramatic framing for mild hunger. I decided against it. The couscous was genuinely fine. I ate it with the quiet gratitude you feel towards things that simply do what they are supposed to do without any fuss — reliable cars, accurate weather forecasts, couscous on airplanes. The orange juice, against all reasonable expectation, was excellent. Bright and cold and sharp, the kind of orange juice that tastes like it has just remembered what it is supposed to be. I drank it in two goes and felt, briefly and unreasonably, happy again.

Across the aisle, a large, round-faced man who had engineered his bag into the overhead bin through what had appeared to be a direct negotiation with the laws of physics was eating his meal with the focused contentment of someone who had long ago made peace with the gap between expectation and reality and found the peace, on balance, preferable to the alternative. He cleaned his tray with methodical efficiency. He sat back. He folded his hands. He appeared, genuinely and without any apparent effort, satisfied.

I envied him this. I wrote a note to myself: *Make peace with things. Fold hands. Try to mean it.*

I am not entirely sure what I meant by "mean it." But it felt like useful advice for the trip.

* * *

The turbulence arrived at two hours and fourteen minutes into the flight, without warning and without apology, in the way that turbulence always arrives.

The seatbelt sign illuminated with a chime that seemed, given the circumstances, tonally optimistic. The captain's voice followed — calm in the very specific and practiced way that pilots are always calm, which is reassuring in principle but which has always made me wonder, in my more anxious moments, whether

the calm is genuine or simply very well rehearsed. He told us we were passing through an area of moderate turbulence and would be through it shortly. He sounded entirely unconcerned. I decided to take this as a good sign and not, as my brain briefly suggested, as evidence of a constitutional inability to convey alarm.

I had kept my seatbelt fastened since takeoff. This was not, I want to be clear, the product of anxiety. It was simply a sensible precaution, like keeping an umbrella in your bag in a country known for rain, or packing antacids. It is called being prepared. I see no reason to apologise for it.

The plane lurched. Not dramatically — not the way planes lurch in films, with oxygen masks dropping and people screaming and an elderly nun clutching a rosary while a baby cries — but with the blunt, ungainly jolt of something very large encountering something it had not planned for. Like a lorry hitting a speed bump at fifty miles an hour. The aircraft shuddered, steadied, shuddered again.

"Okay?" Sam asked.

"Completely," I said. I was gripping the armrest with a focus that I would describe as meditative rather than anxious, though I accept that from the outside these two things may be difficult to distinguish.

The round-faced man across the aisle had not reacted at all. He was looking out his window with mild interest, as though the turbulence were a moderately engaging feature of the landscape. A child three rows back laughed every time the plane lurched, with the pure, uncomplicated delight of someone for whom the concept of danger has not yet fully developed. I found this charming and also, if I am honest, slightly mortifying.

The turbulence lasted, according to my watch, eleven minutes. It lasted, according to every other part of me, somewhere between forty-five minutes and the better part of a geological era.

When it stopped, the cabin exhaled in the collective, unspoken way that groups of strangers exhale together when something mildly unpleasant has passed. A small, shared relief. A brief warming sense of common experience.

"There," Sam said. He had not looked up from his book once.

"You weren't even slightly concerned?"

"No."

"Not even a little?"

He thought about it, which I appreciated. Sam always actually thought about questions rather than answering them immediately, which was one of his better qualities. "I was briefly aware of it," he said. "And then I decided it was fine. And then it was fine."

I stared at him. "That's it? That's your whole process?"

"Mostly."

I looked down at my notebook. During the turbulence, apparently without fully noticing I was doing it, I had written: *The plane does not know it is frightening. It is only frightening from the inside. This is probably true of most things.*

I was not entirely sure if this was a profound observation or an obvious one. I have found, over the years, that these two categories have more overlap than people tend to admit.

* * *

There is a particular man you find on almost every flight, and he was on this one.

He was sitting four rows ahead of us on the opposite side of the aisle, and he had been on his phone from the moment the

seatbelt sign went off, conducting what appeared to be an extended and moderately urgent conversation about something that required, at regular intervals, the phrase "no, listen, what I'm saying is." He spoke at the volume of someone who believes that the importance of a conversation is directly proportional to how many people in the surrounding area can hear it. He was wearing a suit that suggested he considered himself a serious person. He had a briefcase, which he had not opened and which seemed to be there primarily for effect.

Sam had noticed him too, I could tell from the very small and very controlled expression that crossed his face whenever the man said "no, listen" again, which was often.

"What's his story?" I asked, in a low voice.

Sam considered. "He's going to Drevska for a meeting that he could have done by phone. He knows it could have been done by phone. His boss knows it could have been done by phone. The meeting itself will last forty minutes and resolve nothing, after which he will have dinner at the hotel restaurant and tell his wife he's been incredibly busy."

I looked at the man. He said "no, listen, what I'm saying is" again.

"Probably right," I said.

"The briefcase is empty."

"You can't possibly know that."

Sam returned to his book. "It's empty," he said, with the serenity of a man who has never been wrong about a briefcase.

* * *

The descent into Drevska began with an announcement about local time and temperature. Seventeen degrees Celsius,

which I noted with relief. I had, in three weeks of preparatory research, convinced myself that Drevska was likely to be either much hotter or much colder than seventeen degrees, depending on which source I consulted. Seventeen degrees was, by any measure, a sensible temperature. It was the temperature of a country that had its act together.

The clouds came back. Then cleared. Then came back again, and then, in the last few minutes of descent, parted with a kind of theatrical abruptness to reveal — Drevska.

I should admit that I did not know what I had expected. Some version of the generic, I suppose — a grey European city, functional and unremarkable, the kind of place you pass through rather than arrive at. What I saw instead, through the rain-streaked oval of the window, was a city arranged around a river that caught the afternoon light and threw it back in long, rippling strips. There were hills behind it, green and close, the kind of hills that feel like they have been placed there specifically to make the city look better. The buildings in the old part were pale and close together, and there was, on a hill above the rest, something large and old and stone that might have been a castle or a cathedral or both. There was a bridge. Several bridges. The river made them necessary and they complied.

"Oh," I said. For the second time that morning.

"There it is," Sam said. He was looking out the window now, the book closed in his lap. Even Sam, who had been to more countries than I could name off the top of my head, was looking at Drevska with the expression of someone who has just been given something they had not quite expected.

The wheels touched down with a double thud that is always, regardless of how many times you experience it, slightly more abrupt than you remember. The engines reversed. The world outside blurred and then slowed and then stopped.

From near the back of the plane, someone began to clap. Others joined in, in the slightly embarrassed way that people clap on planes — aware that it is a strange thing to do, unsure whether to stop, carrying on anyway.

I did not clap. But I understood the impulse entirely.

* * *

The doors opened, and the air of Drevska came in.

This is the moment I have come to think of as the real arrival — not the touchdown, not the taxiing, not the slow procession through the jet bridge, but that first breath of outside air, before you have adjusted to it, when it is still entirely foreign. Every country has its own smell, and you can only properly smell it in that first unguarded moment before your nose adapts and it becomes simply where you are.

Drevska smelled of something green and cool, with a trace of something underneath it — something earthy and faintly sweet, like damp stone after rain, or the inside of an old building that has been well-maintained. It was not a dramatic smell. It did not announce itself. It simply was, and it was completely unlike anywhere I had been before.

Sam was behind me in the queue, and I heard him inhale.

"Smell that?" I said.

"Yes."

"What is that?"

He considered it for a moment. "I don't know. It's just here. It's what here smells like."

We walked out onto the jet bridge, then through the terminal — small, as terminals go, and quieter than I'd expected, with high ceilings and a clock tower visible through the windows

at the far end — and out through the glass doors into the arrivals hall, where a small number of people were waiting with signs and expressions of varying degrees of enthusiasm.

No one was waiting for us. We had arranged no one. There was something both mildly alarming and deeply exciting about this — the clean blankness of it, the fact that whatever happened next was entirely ours to determine.

Sam stopped and looked around the arrivals hall with an expression I had come to recognise over the years: alert, interested, pleased, ready. The expression of a man who has arrived somewhere new and finds the newness agreeable.

"Right," he said. "We need a taxi, we need to find the guesthouse, and we need something to eat that isn't a foil tray."

"In that order?"

"In that order."

We walked towards the exit. Through the glass doors, I could see the row of taxis Sam had mentioned — dark, orderly, waiting with the particular patience of taxis that know they will eventually be needed. Beyond them, the sky over Dreveska was the pale clear blue that comes after rain has finished and the day has decided, somewhat belatedly, to be decent about it.

I had been awake since four fifty-three in the morning. I had eaten airplane couscous and drunk excellent airplane orange juice. I had survived turbulence, a Christmas dog film, and eleven pages of a magazine about watches. I had arrived, with one bag and no particular plan, in a country I had never visited, whose language I could not speak, whose roads I did not know, and whose currency I had only a partial supply of.

I felt, in a way I had not felt in rather a long time, completely alive.

I did not write this down. Some things, I have learned, are better left in the moment where you find them.

—

In his notebook, Sam would later find a single line written in Alex's handwriting:

Everything smells different here. I don't know what it means yet. I think that's the point.

Chapter Three

The Place That Had No Business Being This Good

In Which We Arrive Somewhere Real and Discover That Real Places Have Opinions About You

The taxi driver's name was Borek, according to the laminated card on the dashboard, and he had the look of a man who had seen every variety of confused foreign visitor that the world could produce and had arrived, through long experience, at a position of benevolent tolerance towards all of them.

He did not speak much English. We did not speak any Drevskian, which is what I had taken to calling the language in my head, though Sam had gently pointed out at the airport that it was called Drevsk and that I might want to know this before I tried to use the word in front of an actual Drevskian. Drevskian. I was already doing it.

What Borek and I did have in common was a shared willingness to communicate through other means. He pointed at things as we drove. I nodded at them. Sam, who had the back seat, looked out the window and occasionally said "hm" in the tone of someone filing information away for later use.

The road from the airport into the city was the kind of road that exists in every country but belongs to no particular one — a

dual carriageway with flat industrial buildings on either side, the occasional petrol station, a billboard advertising something I couldn't read but which appeared to involve a man in a suit looking pleased with himself. Universal, all of it. The international language of approaching a city from its least interesting side.

And then, without much warning, it changed.

The road narrowed. The buildings got older and closer together. The industrial units gave way to apartment blocks, and the apartment blocks gave way to something more human-scaled — shops with actual signs in the windows, a market with awnings, a square with a fountain that was either decorative or broken, it was difficult to tell which. People were walking. An old man was sitting on a bench reading a newspaper with the absorbed contentment of someone who has found the precise right bench. A woman was arguing with a vegetable stall in a way that suggested this was an ongoing negotiation rather than a new development.

I had the window down. The air smelled of bread.

"Bread," I said.

"Bakery," Borek said, pointing, and there it was — a small shop with wooden trays in the window, steam on the glass, a queue of three people outside at half past two in the afternoon, which told you something important about the bread.

"Can we—" I began.

"Later," Sam said.

"But—"

"Guesthouse first."

I watched the bakery disappear behind us. I wrote down the street name, which was something I could not pronounce but could at least copy. I underlined it twice.

The guesthouse was called Penzion Malá Hvězda, which Borek translated, with a small gesture that suggested this was a question he had been asked before, as "Little Star." It was on a cobbled street in the old part of the city, the kind of street that had not been designed so much as accumulated — buildings added over centuries, each one slightly different in height and style from its neighbours, the overall effect being one of cheerful architectural disagreement that had, over time, settled into something charming.

The door was painted dark green. There was a small brass bell beside it. I rang the bell.

Nothing happened for long enough that I began to wonder if we had the right address, which would have been a characteristically Alex thing to have happen. I checked the confirmation email on my phone. The address matched. I rang the bell again.

The door opened, and a woman appeared who I can only describe as someone who had decided, at some point in her life, that she was going to do things properly or not at all. She was perhaps sixty, with white hair pinned up with the confidence of someone who has never second-guessed a hairpin in her life, and she looked at us with an expression that was not unfriendly but was absolutely assessing.

She said something in Drevsk.

"We have a booking," I said. "Alex and Sam. Two nights — actually three nights. Reservation." I did the thing people do when speaking to someone who doesn't share their language, which is to say the words more slowly and slightly more loudly, as though the problem is speed and volume rather than vocabulary. I am aware this is entirely useless. I do it anyway.

The woman looked at me for a moment. Then she looked at Sam. Then she looked back at me with the expression of someone who has made a decision.

"Yes," she said, in English that was accented but entirely precise. "I know who you are. I have been expecting you since two o'clock. It is now two forty-five. Come in."

We came in.

* * *

Her name was Mrs Vachová, and she ran the Little Star with the focused efficiency of a woman who had no interest in running it any other way. She showed us our rooms — mine was small and white with a window that looked out onto a courtyard where a cat was conducting some private business in the corner, and Sam's was next door and apparently identical — and she explained, in the careful English of someone who had learned it properly rather than accidentally, the rules of the house.

Breakfast was at eight. Not eight-fifteen, not half past seven, eight. If you wanted breakfast at a different time, you were welcome to find it elsewhere. Dinner was not provided, but she could recommend three restaurants within five minutes' walk, one of which was excellent, one of which was good, and one of which she described simply as "acceptable, in an emergency." The front door locked at eleven. If we were going to be later than eleven, she required notice. The hot water was reliable unless someone else was using it, in which case it was less reliable, and the solution was to wait.

She said all of this without apparent apology and without any of the performative warmth that hospitality sometimes wraps around its requirements to make them seem optional. They were not optional. This was, I thought, rather refreshing.

"Any questions?" she said.

"The restaurant that's excellent," Sam said. "What do they do?"

Mrs Vachová looked at him with what might have been approval. "Everything. But order the duck. Do not order the lamb. The lamb is fine. The duck is not fine, the duck is extraordinary. There is a difference."

"Noted," Sam said.

"What about the bakery on—" I checked my notebook—"Ulice Kamenná?"

There was a pause. Mrs Vachová looked at me with an expression that had shifted, very slightly, towards something warmer.

"You found Kamenná already?"

"I smelled it from the taxi."

She nodded once, with the small satisfaction of someone whose city has performed correctly. "Go in the morning," she said. "Before nine. After nine, the good ones are gone. Ask for the žemle. Small rolls, seeds on top. Do not get the ones without seeds. I don't know why they make them without seeds. No one knows."

I wrote this down. I wrote all of it down. Mrs Vachová watched me do this and said nothing, but I had the sense that she approved of the notebook in the way that people who do things properly tend to approve of other people taking notes.

* * *

I should tell you something about Drevska, because it is the kind of city that requires a small amount of orientation before it makes complete sense, and because I find that cities, like people, are easier to understand once you know a little of their history. Not a lot. Just enough.

Drevska is old. I mean this in the way that European cities are old, which is to say it is old in a way that puts the concept of "old" in most other countries to shame. The oldest part of the city — the part we were staying in, the part with the cobbled streets and the accumulated buildings — dates to the twelfth century, and there are bits of wall and foundation that are older still, though the archaeologists are apparently still arguing about exactly how old, which is what archaeologists tend to do when they are not digging. The city had been, at various points in its history, a trading post, a regional capital, a contested border town, a place of some cultural significance, and for a brief period in the seventeenth century something that the guidebook described as "a centre of considerable theological controversy," which I found intriguing but could not get further details on because the relevant chapter ended there and continued on a page that had been torn out of the copy in the guesthouse common room.

What I could tell you — what anyone who has spent twenty minutes walking the old city can tell you — is that Drevska has a quality that some places have and many do not, which is the quality of being completely itself. It has not been arranged for visitors. It has not been tidied up or made more photogenic or stripped of the things that make it inconvenient. It is simply a city going about its life, and if you happen to want to watch it doing that, it will not object, but it will not perform for you either.

I find this, in cities as in people, enormously appealing.

* * *

We went out at four o'clock, when the light was doing the particular thing that late afternoon light does in old cities — turning the pale stone buildings a colour somewhere between gold and amber, making shadows long and interesting, generally behaving as though it had been hired to make the place look good and was taking the job seriously.

Sam had a rough map that Mrs Vachová had produced from a drawer with the air of someone who keeps maps specifically for people who will need them, and he held it in front of him with the casual competence of someone who has navigated by paper map in a dozen countries and finds the process more interesting than Google Maps, which offers no opportunity to be interestingly wrong.

I followed him.

This is worth explaining. Between the two of us, Sam was the navigator. I was what I would call the "observer and documenter," which is a generous way of saying that I was the one who stopped every five minutes to write things down or look at something and fell behind. We had established this division of responsibilities early in our friendship and found it worked well. Sam always knew where we were. I always knew what had happened on the way there. Between us, we generally managed to be in the right place and remember it afterward.

The old city was a maze, but a friendly one. The streets were narrow enough that you were always close to something interesting — a doorway with an old lintel carved with something, a window with a cat on the sill, a corner where two streets met at an unexpected angle and opened briefly onto a view of the river below, appearing and disappearing between buildings like something being shown and then taken away again before you could quite look at it directly.

We passed a church. Not a cathedral — too small for that — but old and confident, with a bell tower that listed very slightly to the left in the way of things that have been standing long enough to develop opinions. The door was open. We went in.

Inside it was cool and dim and smelled of the particular combination of candle wax and stone and the faint trace of incense that old churches everywhere seem to share regardless of denomination, as though sanctity has a universal scent. There

were a few people — an old woman in a headscarf lighting a candle, a young man sitting in a pew looking at the floor with the expression of someone having an important interior conversation, a tourist at the back taking photographs with a camera that seemed very large and serious for what was, if I am honest, a fairly modest church.

We sat for a while. Neither of us is particularly religious. But there is something in old churches — something in the accumulated weight of all the people who have sat in them over the centuries, wanting things and hoping for things and being afraid and being grateful — that I find it difficult to be in the presence of without feeling, briefly and unexpectedly, moved.

Sam sat with his hands in his lap and looked at the ceiling, which was painted with faded figures whose colours had softened with age to something almost pastel. I sat beside him and did not write anything down, which was unusual for me, but seemed right.

We stayed about ten minutes. When we left, the young man was still looking at the floor. The old woman had gone.

* * *

The restaurant Mrs Vachová had recommended — the excellent one, not the good one and certainly not the emergency one — was called U Tří Mostů, which she had told us meant "At the Three Bridges," though from where it stood you could only see one bridge, which Sam felt was either a historical reference or an aspirational one.

It was the sort of restaurant that does not need to advertise. It had been there, by the look of it, for a considerable time, and had developed the particular confidence of places that know they are good and have decided that making a fuss about it would be undignified. There were perhaps fifteen tables. Most of them were occupied. The walls had the dark wood panelling of a place that

has absorbed several decades of good meals and retained the general atmosphere.

A waiter appeared. He was young — perhaps twenty, with the focused expression of someone taking the job seriously in the way that young people sometimes do when they have decided that whatever they do, they will do it properly.

He handed us menus. The menus were in Drevsk.

I looked at mine. My menu looked back at me.

"Duck," Sam said, without opening his.

The waiter nodded, wrote it down, looked at me.

I looked at the menu. I found the word that I believed, based on its position in the list and a vague sense of its shape, was probably the duck as well. I pointed at it.

The waiter said something.

"I'm sorry?" I said.

He said it again, helpfully, at the same volume.

"He's asking how you want it cooked," Sam said.

"How do you know that?"

"I don't. But it's the most logical question."

I looked at the waiter. "However the chef prefers," I said.

The waiter considered this for a moment. Then he nodded, with the expression of someone who has just been given an answer they respect, and wrote something down, and left.

"What if I pointed at the wrong thing?" I said.

"Then you'll eat whatever you pointed at."

"What if it's something alarming?"

"Then you'll have a story."

This is, I have found, one of Sam's fundamental operating principles. Everything that goes wrong is a story. Everything that goes right is a pleasure. There is no scenario in which you lose. I have been trying to adopt this outlook for seven years and have achieved approximately thirty percent penetration, which I consider reasonable progress.

* * *

The duck arrived.

I should be careful here, because I want to be accurate and I also do not want to overstate things, and I find that with extraordinary food there is always a risk of doing both simultaneously. What I can tell you is this: the duck at U Tří Mostů was, without any question, the best thing I had eaten in recent memory. It arrived as two pieces — a leg and something from the breast — on a plate with a dark sauce that smelled of something I could not identify but which was deep and complex in the way of sauces that have been thought about seriously, alongside a small pile of something that appeared to be a kind of dumpling and was, it turned out, an even more extraordinary thing than the duck, which I had not thought possible.

I ate it all. I ate it slowly, because it seemed wrong to rush it. I ate it with the attention it deserved.

"All right?" Sam said.

"Don't talk to me," I said. "I'm eating."

He smiled and returned to his own plate.

There are meals you remember because of where you are, or who you are with, or what has just happened or is about to happen — meals that are significant for reasons outside themselves. And then there are meals that are simply, on their

own terms, remarkable. This was the second kind. I was in a country I had arrived in three hours ago, in a restaurant I had been pointed at by a woman I had met forty-five minutes ago, eating a dish I had not ordered so much as gestured hopefully at, and it was one of the best meals of my life.

This is one of the things travel does that nothing else quite manages. It finds things for you that you did not know you were looking for.

I wrote that down after dinner, standing on the cobblestones outside U Tři Mostů with the cold evening air coming off the river and Sam reading the laminated dessert menu that the young waiter had pressed on us as we left with an enthusiasm that suggested he was personally invested in the tiramisu.

"We're coming back tomorrow," I said.

"Obviously," Sam said.

"And the night after."

"If Mrs Vachová allows it."

I looked up at the street — the old stone buildings, the lamplight, the narrow strip of dark sky above — and thought that I had been here for less than a day and already it felt, in some small but definite way, like somewhere I was glad to be.

* * *

We walked back through the old city as the bells from the listing church struck nine, the sound spreading outward in the way that bells always do in old places, as though the stones themselves are part of the instrument. The streets were quieter now but not empty — there were couples walking, a group of young people outside a bar, a man walking a dog that appeared deeply uninterested in walking and very interested in a particular lamp post.

We stopped on a bridge — not one of the three implied by the restaurant's name, but a smaller one, more recent by the look of it, that crossed a narrower part of the river — and looked down at the water, which caught the reflections of the lights on the bank and broke them up and rearranged them constantly, the way water does, into new configurations that were never quite the same twice.

"Good first day," Sam said.

"Yes," I said. "Though I'm still thinking about the duck."

"The duck was exceptional."

"What was in the sauce?"

"I don't know. Red wine, probably. Something else."

"I want to know what the something else was."

"Some things," Sam said, "are better as mysteries."

I considered this. Below us, the river moved in its ancient, indifferent way, going wherever rivers go at nine o'clock on an October evening in Drevska. The bells finished their count and the silence came back, not a dead silence but a living one, full of the small sounds of a city settling into its night.

"I think," I said, after a while, "that this was a good idea."

"The trip?"

"The trip."

Sam nodded, looking at the water. "I know," he said, in the tone of a man who had known this some time ago and had simply been waiting for me to catch up.

Which was, I supposed, fair enough.

—

From the notebook:

Day one. Duck extraordinary. Sauce unidentified. Mrs Vachová correct about everything so far. This is a good sign.

Chapter Four

The Wrong Turn

In Which We Go Somewhere We Did Not Intend and Find It Considerably More Interesting Than Where We Were Going

The žemle were everything Mrs Vachová had promised, which I should not have been surprised by but was.

We had arrived at the bakery on Kamenná street at eight forty, which I felt was a reasonable time, and which turned out to be twenty minutes later than necessary. The žemle — small, round, generously seeded, warm in the hand in the specific and unrepeatable way that bread is warm when it has just come out of an oven rather than been reheated in one — were still available, but only just. There were four left on the tray when we walked in. We bought all four. The woman behind the counter, who had the cheerful purposefulness of someone who has been up since five and considers this a perfectly sensible arrangement, wrapped them in paper without being asked and said something that I took, from her tone and expression, to mean something along the lines of "good choice, you nearly missed them."

We ate two each, standing on the pavement outside, and I want to be careful here because I am aware that bread eaten while travelling always carries a slight advantage over bread eaten at home — there is a romanticism to it, a context, that flatters the thing itself. But I have thought about this carefully, and I

genuinely believe that the žemle on Kamenná street were the best bread I have ever eaten in my life. They were soft inside and had a crust that gave way exactly as much as you wanted it to and no more. The seeds — some combination of poppy and sesame and something else I couldn't identify — were toasted just enough. There was a faint sweetness underneath everything that I could not account for and did not need to.

I ate mine in four bites. I would have preferred to eat it in forty, to make it last, but I lacked the self-discipline.

"We're coming back tomorrow," I said. This was becoming a habit.

"Before eight-twenty," Sam said.

"Before eight-twenty," I agreed.

We stood on the street in the thin October morning sun, brushing seeds off our jackets, and I felt the particular contentment that comes from starting a day well — from having done the first thing correctly, which creates an optimism about the rest of it that is not always justified but is always useful.

"Right," Sam said, folding his paper wrapper with the economy of someone who wastes nothing. "Where are we going?"

I produced the map.

Sam looked at it. Then he looked at the street around us — the old buildings, the cobblestones, the narrow gap between two houses that revealed a further street beyond, going somewhere unknown. Then he looked back at the map.

"Put it away," he said.

"Sorry?"

"Put the map away. Let's just walk."

I looked at him. "Walk where?"

"Somewhere. Anywhere. Whatever's there."

There was a pause in which I considered several responses, including a reasonable one about the value of orientation in unfamiliar cities, and a practical one about the fact that neither of us spoke the language and getting genuinely lost would present specific challenges, and a mild one about the fact that I had spent twenty minutes last night highlighting points of interest on the map with a yellow marker.

I put the map away.

"Good," Sam said, and turned left down the street that wasn't on it.

* * *

The thing about walking without a map in an old city is that it is either a terrible idea or a brilliant one, and you generally don't know which until it's over.

The street Sam had turned down was narrower than Kamenná, and older-feeling — the buildings on either side were four or five storeys, their upper floors close enough that you felt they were leaning in, and the light came down in the way it does in narrow streets, vertical and particular, leaving the lower floors in a pleasant dimness. There were doors painted various colours, most of them in various stages of a relationship with their original paint. There were window boxes with the last of the autumn flowers doing their best. There was, strung between a second-floor window and a nail in the wall opposite, a line of washing that included, among other things, a very small pair of trousers that suggested the presence somewhere above us of a very small person.

Nobody else was on the street. Our footsteps on the cobblestones were the only sound.

"This isn't in the guidebook," I said.

"No," Sam said, with the satisfaction of someone who considers this a point in the street's favour.

We walked. The street turned. We followed it. It turned again, and we followed it again, and then it opened unexpectedly into a small square that was not a tourist square — no café tables arranged with calculated charm, no information board explaining the historical significance of the fountain — just a square, with a fountain that was definitely broken this time rather than decorative, and four benches, and a tree that had decided October was an appropriate time to let go of its leaves and was doing so with the calm efficiency of an organisation conducting an orderly shutdown.

A dog was sitting by the fountain. It was a medium-sized dog of no particular breed, with the self-possessed air of an animal that is exactly where it has decided to be. It looked at us when we came in. It assessed us for a moment with the unhurried competence of a dog that has assessed many people and has a reliable internal system for categorising them. Then it stood up, walked over, sniffed Sam's hand, and fell into step beside him as we crossed the square.

"You have a dog," I said.

"Apparently."

"Is it — should we—"

"It'll go when it wants to go."

The dog walked with us for two more streets, with the easy confidence of a local showing visitors around a neighbourhood it knew well. Then, at the corner of a street I could not have found again if my life depended on it, it stopped, looked at Sam once more with an expression of mild approval, and turned back the way we had come.

"Goodbye," Sam said, to the dog.

The dog did not look back. It had other things to do.

* * *

We heard the market before we saw it.

It announced itself first as a low, continuous murmur — the sound of many people conducting many transactions simultaneously, the kind of sound that is made up of individual voices but has merged into something collective and almost musical. Then, underneath the voices, other things: something wooden being moved across cobblestones, a burst of laughter from somewhere within, and a smell that came in layers — first the fish, sharp and cold and honest, then underneath it the earth smell of vegetables brought in from somewhere not far away, and underneath that something else, something warm and faintly spiced that I couldn't place and immediately wanted to find.

We turned a corner and there it was.

It filled a square that was considerably larger than the one with the broken fountain — perhaps fifty stalls arranged in rough rows, with gaps between them that functioned as corridors and were being used as such by what appeared to be most of the local population. This was not a market for tourists. There were no stalls selling miniature replicas of the castle or tea towels with a map of the country on them or little jars of locally-sourced artisan honey with handwritten labels in English as well as Drevsk. There were, instead: vegetables of every variety, many of which I recognised and several of which I did not, arranged on wooden tables with the straightforward abundance of things that have been grown rather than curated. There were fish, laid out on ice in the unsentimental way of fish markets everywhere. There were cheeses, great pale rounds of them, and things in jars that had handwritten labels in Drevsk only, which told you that whoever made them was not particularly concerned about the export market. There was a stall selling nothing but mushrooms — an extraordinary number of varieties, in baskets and boxes and loose

piles, a small universe of fungi that a man with a grey beard was presiding over with the concentrated pride of a person who has devoted a significant portion of his life to a single subject and regards this as entirely reasonable.

I bought a jar from a stall run by a woman of perhaps seventy who seemed amused by my presence and who charged me, with the mild benevolence of someone not inclined to take advantage of the obviously confused, what I calculated later to be approximately forty pence. I have no idea what was in the jar. It had a handwritten label featuring a drawing that might have been a plum or might have been a small round animal of some kind. I put it in my bag and decided I would open it later and deal with the consequences then.

"What did you buy?" Sam asked.

"I'm not sure."

"Is that wise?"

"Almost certainly not. But it was forty pence."

Sam considered this logic and apparently found it acceptable.

* * *

Tomáš found us at the mushroom stall.

I say he found us, because that is how it felt — less like a meeting and more like something that was going to happen regardless, the way certain things on trips seem to have been arranged in advance by nobody in particular. We were standing in front of the mushroom stall, where I had been attempting, with limited success, to ask the grey-bearded man a question about one of the varieties — a dark, almost black mushroom with a cap that curled under itself in a way I found intriguing and slightly sinister — through a combination of pointing and an expression I hoped

conveyed intelligent curiosity rather than blankness. The man was responding with what appeared to be considerable information, delivered in Drevsk with the enthusiasm of a specialist who has been waiting for someone to ask. Neither of us was understanding the other. Both of us were continuing anyway, in the optimistic fashion of conversations that are enjoyable regardless of their content.

A voice behind me said, in English: "He is telling you that this mushroom should not be eaten raw under any circumstances, and that his cousin once ignored this advice and was ill for two weeks. He says the cousin deserved it for not listening."

I turned around.

The man who had spoken was perhaps sixty-five, short and broad, with white hair that had been combed with evident care and a face that had the weathered quality of someone who has spent a great deal of time outdoors and found this agreeable. He was wearing a coat that had clearly been good once and was now comfortable in the way that old coats are comfortable, and he was carrying a canvas bag that contained, visibly, three large potatoes and what appeared to be an entire cabbage.

He looked at me with an expression of cheerful assessment.

"The mushroom is called a Drevský černák," he said. "You cook it for at least twenty minutes. In butter, preferably. With a little garlic. It is very good. Don't let anyone tell you to put cream with it. This is wrong."

"Thank you," I said. "I'm Alex."

"Tomáš," he said. He shook my hand with the directness of someone who considers the handshake a serious undertaking. Then he looked at Sam, who had appeared beside me, and shook his hand too. "You are tourists?"

"Travellers," Sam said.

Tomáš considered the distinction. "Is there a difference?"

"Tourists go to the places in the guidebook," Sam said. "Travellers go to the mushroom stall."

Tomáš looked at him for a moment with the expression of a man recalibrating his assessment. Then he laughed — a short, genuine sound, more like a bark than a laugh, but entirely without self-consciousness. "All right," he said. "Travellers. What are you doing this morning, travellers?"

"Walking," I said. "Without a map."

"Whose idea was that?"

"His," I said, indicating Sam.

"Good idea," Tomáš said, in Sam's direction, with a nod of approval. Then, to me: "You look like a man who wanted to keep the map."

"I had highlighted it," I said, with a dignity I did not entirely feel.

Tomáš smiled. "Come," he said. "I will show you something."

Sam looked at me. I looked at Sam.

"We don't want to take up your morning," I said, in the polite way that means the opposite.

"You are not taking it up," Tomáš said, already walking. "I come to the market every Thursday. I have my potatoes. I have my cabbage. The rest of the morning is my own." He looked back over his shoulder. "Are you coming?"

We came.

Tomáš had lived in Drevska for all sixty-seven years of his life, a fact he delivered not with the apologetic air of someone explaining a limitation but with the straightforward satisfaction of a man who had looked at the available options and made a considered choice.

"People always ask if I have travelled," he said, as we followed him out of the market and into a street that ran alongside the river. "As if not travelling is something that requires an explanation. I know this city. I know it the way you know something you have paid proper attention to for a long time. Every street. Every building. Who lives where, who used to live where, what stood here before what stands here now." He paused to shift his canvas bag from one hand to the other. "There are people who go everywhere and know nothing. I have stayed here and know one thing properly. I prefer to know one thing properly."

"What's the one thing?" Sam asked.

Tomáš looked at him. "Drevska."

"That's not a small thing."

"No," Tomáš agreed. "It is not small at all."

He had been a schoolteacher — history, for thirty-one years, at a school three streets from where he had grown up — and had retired four years ago with a pension that was, he said, adequate, and a great deal of time that he had organised carefully so as not to waste it. Mornings were for the market, or walking, or reading. Afternoons were for his allotment, which was a twenty-minute walk from the old city on a patch of ground that the city had designated for growing things and which Tomáš had been cultivating for fifteen years. Evenings were for his wife, who was, he said, considerably more interesting than he was, and who taught piano to children and had opinions about everything.

"She sounds formidable," I said.

"She is the most formidable person I have ever met," Tomáš said, with an uncomplicated pride that I found rather moving. "I have been married to her for thirty-eight years and I have not yet won an argument. I have come close. But not yet."

* * *

He took us, first, to a place that was not in any guidebook I had read, which was either because the guidebooks had missed it or because Tomáš had a specific and curated idea of what visitors deserved to see.

It was a courtyard.

From the street, there was no indication of it — just a door, wooden, painted the faded blue of something that had been painted blue a long time ago and was now in the later stages of that commitment, set into a wall between two buildings. Tomáš produced a key from his coat pocket and unlocked it without ceremony, in the way of someone who has a key to something and regards the having of the key as entirely natural.

Inside was a courtyard that the street gave no clue to — rectangular, perhaps fifteen metres by ten, with a cobbled floor and walls on all four sides that were covered, and I mean covered in the genuine and total sense of the word, in ivy. Not the scrubby, perfunctory ivy you find on the sides of buildings that tolerate rather than encourage it, but deep, layered, ancient ivy, dark green at the edges and turning, in October, to red and amber and a colour I want to call copper but which was something more specific and exact than copper, a colour that seemed to be made of the light itself rather than reflecting it.

In the centre of the courtyard was a stone bench. On the bench was a cat — a different cat from the one in the guesthouse courtyard, or possibly the same cat who had a very efficient travel system, orange and entirely relaxed, occupying the bench with the

unassailable confidence of an animal that has never once questioned its right to be wherever it happens to be.

I stood in the courtyard and looked at the walls of ivy and the light coming down from the square of sky above and said nothing, because there was nothing to say that wasn't already being said by the place itself.

"What is this?" Sam asked, after a while. His voice was quieter than usual.

"It was the garden of a house that no longer exists," Tomáš said. "The house was destroyed — a long time ago, before I was born, before my parents were born. But the garden stayed. The city owns it now. They were going to do something with it at some point. They have not yet decided what. In the meantime, it is like this." He looked around with the expression of a man who is satisfied with an arrangement. "I have been coming here since I was a boy. I have the key because my father had the key. I don't know who gave my father the key. Someone who trusted him, I suppose."

"Does anyone else know about it?" I asked.

"Some people. Not many." He looked at me steadily. "Now you."

We stayed in the courtyard for perhaps twenty minutes. The cat remained on the bench throughout, indifferent to us and to the ivy and to the quality of the light, which continued to be extraordinary. When we left, Tomáš locked the door behind us and put the key back in his coat pocket, and we stepped back into the street as though nothing in particular had happened, which was not how it felt.

* * *

He took us, afterward, for coffee.

The café was two streets from the courtyard, down a set of steps that descended from street level to what appeared to be a former cellar, low-ceilinged and warm, with walls of bare stone and half a dozen tables and a man behind a small counter who greeted Tomáš by name and set about making coffee without being asked, which told you something about the regularity of Tomáš's visits.

The coffee, when it came, was small and dark and extremely serious about itself. I took one sip and my brain, which had been operating at its normal, slightly understimulated pace, shifted immediately into a higher gear. It was the kind of coffee that reminds you that coffee, done properly, is not a beverage but a statement.

"Good?" Tomáš asked.

"Extraordinary."

"Yes," he said simply. "It is."

He asked us about ourselves, which people on trips sometimes do and which I always find interesting, because the version of yourself you describe when you are traveling is subtly different from the one you'd describe at home — stripped of its usual context, it becomes more essential, more edited, more the version you actually want to be.

I told him I worked in publishing, editing other people's books, which was true and which was a job I had, over the last year, come to feel faintly dissatisfied with in a way I had not quite looked at directly. Sam told him he was a graphic designer, which was also true and which Sam seemed, by contrast, entirely fine with.

"And why Drevska?" Tomáš asked.

"Honestly?" I said.

"Always honestly."

"We had no particular reason. We had three countries to see and Drevska was the first one."

Tomáš received this without offence. "And what do you think of it so far?"

"The duck last night was one of the best things I've ever eaten," I said. "The bread this morning was the second best. The courtyard just now was—" I paused. "I don't have the right word for it yet."

"That's all right," Tomáš said. "Some things take time to find the word for. The city will wait."

We sat in the cellar café for an hour, drinking coffee and talking. Tomáš told us about the history of the old city with the ease of someone for whom history is not a subject but simply the texture of the place he lived — the buildings we had walked past that morning and what they had been before they were what they were now, the market and how it had changed over the decades he had been coming to it, the river and its habits, the castle on the hill and the specific and colourful reasons it had been built and rebuilt and partially demolished and rebuilt again over seven centuries.

He told us about the theological controversy. It was, as I had suspected, extremely interesting.

"You should have been a guide," Sam said.

Tomáš shook his head. "A guide tells people what they should see. I am telling you what I see. It's different." He finished his coffee. "A guide would have taken you to the castle first. I took you to the courtyard. One of these is more useful to you, I think."

"The courtyard," I said, without hesitation.

"Yes," Tomáš said. "The courtyard."

We said goodbye to Tomáš at the top of the steps outside the café, in the thin noon sunlight that had decided, belatedly, to make an effort. He shook our hands again with the same seriousness as before. He told us to go back to U Tří Mostů and this time order the soup to start — a specific soup, whose name he wrote in my notebook in Drevsk, which he said I should simply show to the waiter — and to tell them Tomáš sent us, which would not get us a discount but would, he said, ensure that the soup was hot.

"The soup is always better hot," he said, as though this were a piece of wisdom he had arrived at through hard experience.

"Will we see you again?" I asked.

He considered it. "I am at the market every Thursday. I am at this café most mornings. Drevska is not a large city." He picked up his canvas bag of potatoes and cabbage. "If you walk without the map, you will probably find me again."

He went off down the street at the unhurried pace of a man going somewhere he knows well and is in no particular hurry to leave. We watched him go.

"I like him," Sam said.

"Yes," I said. "He's the real thing, isn't he."

"What do you mean?"

I thought about it. "I mean he's someone who has paid attention to his life. The whole time. Not just occasionally." I paused. "I find that rarer than it should be."

Sam was quiet for a moment. Then: "Is that why you came on this trip?"

It was a more direct question than Sam usually asked. I looked at him.

"Partly," I said.

"What's the other part?"

I looked down the street where Tomáš had gone, now empty. "I'm not entirely sure yet," I said. "I think that's rather the point."

Sam nodded. He didn't push it further, which was one of the things I valued most about him. He knew when a thing needed more time, and he gave it the time without making a point of doing so.

We walked back through the old city in the noon light, and I did not use the map, and I did not get us lost, and somewhere between the market and the guesthouse we passed a street I had not seen before and which I wrote down in my notebook, for no particular reason except that it seemed worth remembering.

In the afternoon we went back to the courtyard. Tomáš had given me the key.

"Just leave it under the stone by the door when you're done," he had said, pressing it into my hand at the café steps so naturally that I had almost missed the significance of it.

The cat was still there. Or it was back. The ivy was even better in the afternoon light than it had been in the morning.

Sam sat on the bench beside the cat and read his book. I sat on the cobblestones with my back against the ivy-covered wall and wrote in my notebook and occasionally said nothing and found the saying nothing entirely sufficient.

There are afternoons that justify the whole enterprise of travel simply by existing. This was one of them. I knew it at the time, which is rarer than you might think.

—

From the notebook:

*Day two. The best things were: the bread, the courtyard, Tomáš, the
coffee, the cat.*

*None of these were on the map. None of these were in the guidebook.
This seems important.*

Chapter Five

The Last Morning

In Which We Discover That Leaving a Place You Have Only Just Found Is a Specific and Unreasonable Kind of Cruelty

I woke at six-fifteen without an alarm, which was either my body being helpful or my brain being anxious, and in the half-dark of the small white room at the Little Star I lay still for a moment and listened.

The city was doing what cities do at six-fifteen in the morning, which is to say it was waking up quietly and getting on with things. There were footsteps on the cobblestones below — someone going somewhere with the purposeful rhythm of a person who knows where they are going and has done it many times before. There was a door somewhere, opening and closing. There was, faintly and then more clearly, the bells from the listing church, which apparently rang at every quarter hour regardless of what time it was or how many people were trying to sleep within earshot, and which I had, over three nights, gone from finding slightly intrusive to finding entirely right.

There was, underneath all of it, that smell. Still there. The green and stone and something sweet underneath. I had been in Drevska for three days and I still could not fully account for it, which I had come to accept as simply one of the things about this place that was going to stay unresolved.

I lay there for a while longer than I needed to.

This is something I never do at home. At home, when I wake before my alarm, I check my phone and read emails and generally begin the anxious process of engaging with the day before the day has properly arrived. Here, I lay in the quiet and listened to the city and felt, with a clarity that was slightly uncomfortable, that I had been living my mornings incorrectly for quite some time.

I wrote this down. Then I got up, because the žemle were not going to wait.

* * *

The woman at the bakery on Kamenná street recognised us.

I want to be precise about this because it matters more than it should, and I think it matters more than it should for a reason worth examining. We had been to the bakery twice before. She had served perhaps two hundred people in the intervening time. There was no particular reason for her to remember us, and every practical reason not to. And yet when we came through the door at seven fifty-three — earlier than our previous visits, as Tomáš's counsel about the best ones going quickly had taken root — she looked up from what she was doing and said something in Drevsk that had, unmistakably, the quality of recognition.

She said it to Sam first, then to me. Her expression was not effusive — it was not the performed warmth of hospitality — but it was real, and it was warm, and it was the expression of someone who had noted our existence and filed it under something positive.

"What did she say?" I asked Sam, who had marginally more competence in Drevsk than I did, which is to say he had downloaded a translation app.

Sam checked his phone. "Something like — the early ones today, good."

"The early ones today, good," I repeated.

"More or less."

It was six words, approximately, in a language I didn't speak, from a woman I had met three times, in a bakery I would probably never visit again. I found it, to a degree that I recognised was disproportionate and did not care, genuinely moving.

We bought four žemle. We ate two each on the pavement outside, as before. They were, as before, extraordinary. The seeds. The crust. The faint sweetness underneath that I had still not identified and had now decided I preferred not to identify, on the grounds that some things are better experienced than explained, which is not a position I hold naturally but which Drevska had been gradually persuading me towards.

"Last ones," Sam said. Not sadly, exactly. Just noting the fact.

"Last ones," I said.

We stood on Kamenná street and ate our bread in the early morning light, and neither of us said anything else for a while, and this seemed entirely correct.

* * *

We went to the courtyard before we checked out.

The key had been in my jacket pocket for two days, and I had been aware of it there in the way you are aware of things you are not quite ready to put down — not heavy, not uncomfortable, just present. A small weight with a specific meaning.

The street was quiet. The blue door looked the same as it always looked, which is to say it looked like a door that had been there for a very long time and expected to be there for a great deal longer. I unlocked it. We went in.

The courtyard in the early morning was different from the courtyard in the afternoon. The light came in at a lower angle and caught the ivy differently — less of the copper and amber warmth of the afternoon, more of a cool, clear green, the colours more themselves somehow, less theatrical. The cobblestones were slightly damp. The air smelled of stone and ivy and the particular freshness of early morning in a walled space.

The cat was there.

Of course the cat was there.

It was in exactly the same position on the bench as it had been every time we had seen it, with the imperturbable settledness of an animal that has determined its optimal location and sees no reason to reconsider. It looked at us when we came in. It blinked once, slowly, in the way of cats who are acknowledging your presence without conceding any particular importance to it. Then it looked away.

"Hello," Sam said to the cat.

The cat said nothing. This was, from the cat, practically a warm welcome.

We stayed for about fifteen minutes. Sam sat on the bench at the far end from the cat and looked at the ivy and was quiet in the way he was quiet — fully, without any of the restlessness that quiet sometimes covers in people who are not actually comfortable with silence. I stood in the middle of the courtyard and tried to fix it in my memory with the thoroughness that you apply to things you know you are about to lose.

This is one of the stranger exercises that travel involves. The attempt to hold a place in your mind before you leave it, to press it like a flower between pages, to retain it with a fidelity that you know, even as you are attempting it, will be imperfect. Memory does not work like a photograph. It works like a painting done from a photograph — the broad shapes right, the details

shifting, the whole thing coloured by how you felt at the time rather than strictly what was there. In ten years, I would remember the courtyard. I might not remember the exact colour of the ivy, or the precise dampness of the cobblestones, or the cat's specific expression of magnificent indifference. But I would remember that it was the kind of place that exists outside the usual order of things, and that we had been in it, and that someone had trusted us with the key.

Some things you keep not in the details but in the feeling. The feeling is enough.

I crouched down and put the key under the stone by the door. It went with a small, definite sound — the sound of a thing returned to its proper place. I stood up. We left. I pulled the blue door closed behind us and heard the latch catch, and then we were back on the street and the courtyard was on the other side of the door and already, in the way of things on the other side of closed doors, becoming the past.

* * *

Tomáš was not at the café.

We had not arranged to meet him. There was no reason he should be there at eight-thirty on a day that was not, as far as I knew, a market day. And yet I had half-expected him, in the way that you half-expect certain people in certain places when the trip has been going well and your sense of the possible has expanded accordingly. He was not there, and this was entirely reasonable, and I felt his absence with a sharpness that surprised me.

The man behind the counter — whose name I did not know, because I had not thought to ask, which I noted as a failure of attention — looked up when we came in and reached for two cups without being asked.

This, too, meant more than it should. Three visits to a café in three days and the man behind the counter knew what we wanted. We had become, in the smallest and most temporary sense, regulars. We had a coffee place. In Drevska, in a city we had never visited before and would probably not visit again for years, we had a café where they knew us well enough not to ask.

I sat down and thought about the word "home" and what it actually meant and whether it was a place or a habit or simply the accumulation of small recognitions — the baker who notes your return, the courtyard you have a key to, the café where your coffee appears without discussion. Whether home was somewhere you were from or somewhere you had paid enough attention to be known.

I did not reach a conclusion. I wrote the question down instead and left it open, on the grounds that open questions are more useful than closed ones, which is something I believe intellectually and struggle with personally.

The coffee was as serious as it had always been. We drank it slowly.

"Do you think we'll come back?" I asked.

Sam turned his cup in his hands. "To Drevska?"

"Yes."

He thought about it properly, in the Sam way. "I think the question is whether Drevska will be the same if we do."

"What do you mean?"

"Places change. But more than that — we change. The version of us that's here now, doing this for the first time, won't exist if we come back. We'll be different people coming to a place we already know." He paused. "That's a different trip."

I considered this. "That's either very wise or quite depressing."

"Probably both," Sam said.

We finished our coffee. I left what I hoped was a reasonable amount of money on the table, having never fully resolved the tipping question in Drevska despite three days of meaning to look it up. We thanked the man behind the counter, who nodded in the straightforward way of someone who is thanked many times a day and takes it at face value rather than performing a response to it. We went out into the morning.

* * *

Mrs Vachová was waiting for us in the front hall of the Little Star with the expression of a woman who knew exactly what time it was and had assessed the probability of our being ready to leave at this time and had found it, on balance, acceptable.

Our bags were by the door. We had brought them down earlier, at her instruction — checkout was at nine, she had told us on arrival, with the certainty of someone for whom checkout being at nine was not a policy but a fact of nature, like the sun rising or water running downhill. It was now eight fifty-seven. We were, on this occasion, ahead of schedule, which I felt said something good about what three days in Drevska had done for my general outlook.

"Your train is at ten-fifteen," she said. "The station is twelve minutes on foot. You have time, but not a large amount of it."

"Thank you," I said. "For everything. The restaurant recommendation was — the duck was—"

"I know," she said, in the tone of someone who has always known and finds the confirmation agreeable without being necessary.

"And the bakery."

"Did she remember you?"

"This morning, yes."

Mrs Vachová gave a single, satisfied nod. "Good. She only remembers people who come back before the good ones are gone. It means you did it correctly."

This was, I felt, one of the finest compliments I had received in recent memory.

She shook Sam's hand. She shook mine. Her handshake was firm and brief and entirely without ambiguity. Then she looked at us both for a moment with an expression that was not sentimental — Mrs Vachová, I felt confident, did not do sentiment, or if she did she kept it in a place where it couldn't cause any trouble — but which was warm, in the way that things can be warm without being soft.

"Come back in spring," she said. "The city is different in spring. Everything is different in spring." A pause. "The bakery is still the same. But everything else."

"We will," Sam said.

She looked at him with the assessing expression she had used when we first arrived, three days ago, at the green door. Then she gave a small nod that suggested she had decided to believe him.

We picked up our bags. We went out through the green door into the cobbled street. I looked back once. The door had already closed.

* * *

The walk to the station took fourteen minutes, not twelve, because I stopped twice — once to look at a building I had passed

every day and not properly looked at, a narrow thing wedged between its neighbours like a book that won't quite fit on a shelf, with a carved stone face above the door that might have been a saint or might have been a local dignitary or might have been someone's idea of a joke, and once because we turned a corner and the river appeared below us at the end of a short street, catching the morning light in that way it had, and I stood there for a moment with my bag on my back and simply looked.

Sam waited both times without comment. This is the thing about travelling with the right person. They let you stop.

The station was small and functional and had the particular smell of all train stations, which is its own universal language — metal and distance and a trace of something industrial underneath, the smell of departure. There were perhaps twenty people on the platform. A family with too much luggage. An elderly man reading. Two young women with matching backpacks who were consulting a map with the focused energy of people at the beginning of something.

I bought a coffee from the station kiosk, which was not the coffee from Tomáš's café. I drank it anyway.

Our train came in at ten-twelve, three minutes early, which I noted with the particular pleasure I take in trains that are early, which is a pleasure I am aware is slightly eccentric but which I have decided to embrace rather than apologise for. It was a medium-sized train, clean and functional, the kind of train that goes about its business without any particular drama. The seats were comfortable enough. The windows were large.

We found our seats. We put our bags in the overhead rack. We sat down.

The platform slid past the window as the train began to move — slowly at first, then with gathering purpose — and I watched the station go and then the outskirts of the city, the backs of buildings, a yard with something mechanical in it, a stretch of

wall with old paint, and then the buildings thinned and there were the hills and the particular green of them that I had seen from the plane three days ago and that I now knew, having been in the city under those hills, as something specific and named rather than simply a view.

Drevska appeared for a moment — the old city visible from a distance, the castle on its hill, the river between the bridges — and then a curve in the track took it away, and it was gone.

I looked at the empty space where it had been for a moment longer than was strictly necessary.

"All right?" Sam asked.

"Yes," I said. "Just — you know."

"I know," Sam said.

He opened his book. I opened my notebook. Outside, the countryside of the country we were leaving unrolled past the window in the October light — fields and forests and the occasional small cluster of buildings that might have been a village, each one its own world of things I would never know about, whole lives being lived at speed past my window on the way to somewhere else.

I tried to write about Drevska. I tried three times. The first attempt was too long and became a list. The second attempt was too short and felt like a dismissal. The third attempt began well and then arrived at a sentence that didn't quite work and after that I couldn't get back to it.

Some places resist being summarised. This is, I think, a mark in their favour. The things that can be fully contained in a description were probably not very large to begin with.

In the end I wrote one line, which was not a summary and was not a description and was not, strictly speaking, even a complete thought. But it was the truest thing I could find, and on

that particular morning, on a train leaving a city I had known for three days and would carry for considerably longer, it was enough.

—

From the notebook, on the train out of Drevska:

Three days was not enough. I am not sure how many days would have been enough. I suspect that is the point.

Chapter Six

Everything I Blamed on the Walls

In Which Everything Goes Slightly Wrong in Ways That Are, in Retrospect, Entirely Our Own Fault

The train from Drevska to Vrest took three hours and forty minutes, which was long enough to finish the remains of the žemle we had wrapped in paper that morning, read forty pages, watch the landscape change completely through the window, and arrive at the philosophical question of whether it was possible to miss a place you had left only four hours ago.

It was, I discovered. Entirely possible.

The landscape outside had shifted from the particular green of Drevska's hills — close, wooded, the kind of hills that feel like they are keeping an eye on things — to something flatter and more open, fields that went further than they needed to, interrupted occasionally by lines of trees that appeared to have been planted with a ruler. It was not an unpleasant landscape. It was simply a different one, with a different personality — less intimate, more spacious, the sky a larger proportion of everything.

Sam had finished his book somewhere around the second hour and was now looking out the window with the alert, interested expression he brought to new things, which had not notably diminished across the entire trip so far. I had always found this quality in him — the consistent freshness of his

attention — to be one of the more admirable things about him, and also, in certain moods, one of the more quietly irritating, in the way that genuinely good qualities in other people can become slightly irritating when you are aware of not quite sharing them.

I was not in a bad mood. I was in the mood that follows leaving somewhere you liked more than you expected to, which is a specific and not entirely pleasant mood, a sort of low-grade wistfulness that is not quite sadness but is adjacent to it and borrows some of its furniture.

"Tell me something about Vrest," I said.

Sam had done most of the research on Kalvenia, in the same way I had done most of the booking and most of the lists, which was a division of labour that had developed naturally and that suited us both.

"Population around eight hundred thousand," he said. "Built around a river, like Drevska, but the river is wider and the city is less — coherent. It grew fast in the middle of the last century and they didn't always plan carefully. So you have the old parts, which are genuinely old and quite beautiful apparently, and then the newer parts, which are—" he paused— "functional."

"Functional how?"

"Functional in the sense that they function."

"That's not reassuring."

"It's an honest answer."

I looked out the window at the flat fields going past. "Where's the accommodation?"

Sam was quiet for a fraction of a second longer than the question warranted.

"Central," he said.

I looked at him. He was looking out the window.

"Central," I repeated.

"Broadly."

"Sam."

"It's centrally located relative to—"

"Sam."

He turned from the window and had the expression of a man who has been meaning to mention something and has simply been waiting for the right moment, which had not arrived and was now being forced. "It's a twenty-minute tram ride from the old city," he said. "The reviews said it was clean and the host was very responsive."

I considered this. "The reviews said clean and responsive."

"And good value."

"Not central."

"Not in the strictest sense, no."

I looked back out the window. The fields continued. "Right," I said.

"It'll be fine," Sam said, in the tone of a man who believes this and also knows that the person he is saying it to is not entirely convinced.

"It'll be fine," I said, in the tone of a man who is choosing, as an act of conscious will, to believe it.

Outside, a small town went past the window and was gone before I could read its name.

Vrest Central Station announced itself from half a mile out.

It was large. That was the first thing — it was simply much larger than I had expected, a vast industrial cathedral of iron and glass and a particular shade of dirty cream that the concrete had been painted at some point and was now in the process of reverting to its natural grey. The platforms were long and numerous. The roof was high and arched and had, in several places, been repaired with something that was a slightly different shade from the original, giving it the patchwork quality of a thing that has been maintained by people who prioritised function over appearance, which I found, on reflection, rather honest.

The noise hit us first through the windows as we slowed — a deep, layered sound quite unlike the relative quiet of Drevska's station, a sound made up of trains and announcements and the movement of several hundred people doing several hundred things simultaneously. And then the doors opened and the noise became total and we were in it.

Vrest smelled different too. Where Drevska had smelled of green things and stone and something sweet, Vrest smelled of fuel and food and the specific warm metallic note of a large enclosed space containing a great many people. It was not an unpleasant smell, precisely. It was simply an urban smell, the smell of a city that has a lot going on and is not particularly self-conscious about it.

"Right," Sam said, which he always said at the beginning of things.

We consulted the tram map, which was posted on the wall of the station concourse in the slightly faded way of official information that has been there long enough to become part of the scenery. Tram number seven would take us to within three streets of the accommodation. Tram number seven departed from stop C, which was outside the main entrance, which was in that direction,

according to the signs, which appeared to agree with each other on this point at least.

We found stop C. We waited eight minutes for tram number seven. The tram arrived with the solid, unhurried authority of something running on rails, which I find enormously reassuring — there is something about a vehicle that cannot deviate from its course that I respond well to, possibly for reasons that say more about my personality than about trams.

The tram was full. Not aggressively full — not the sardine-tin fullness of rush-hour transport in very large cities — but comfortably, humanly full, the fullness of a city going about its afternoon. We stood and held the rail and the city slid past the windows.

It was, I had to admit, interesting. Not beautiful, not in the way Drevska was beautiful — this was not a city that was going to give itself to you in the first glance. But there was something to it. The streets were wide, the buildings mixed — an old ornate thing next to a flat concrete block next to something being renovated, scaffolding wrapped around it, new windows going into old frames. A city in the process of becoming something, not entirely sure yet what.

There was a market on one street — different from Drevska's market, louder and less orderly, with stalls crowding onto the pavement and a general atmosphere of enthusiastic commerce that bordered on the combative. There was a square with a large statue in it, the statue being of a man on a horse doing the thing that men on horses in statues always do, which is to say gesturing heroically at something in the middle distance. There were, on one corner, three cafés next to each other in a row, which seemed like more cafés than one corner needed but which appeared to be doing sufficient business to justify the arrangement.

Vrest was not Drevska. This was becoming clear. Vrest was its own thing entirely, and it was going to require a different kind of attention.

* * *

The accommodation was not central.

I want to be measured about this, because "not central" covers a wide range of situations and some of them are perfectly fine. Our accommodation in Vrest occupied a position on that range that was not the worst possible but was also not what I had, based on the website photographs and the word "central" used in the booking confirmation, pictured.

The building was a residential block of the kind that had been constructed, at a guess, sometime in the nineteen-seventies by people who were primarily concerned with putting roofs over heads and only secondarily, if at all, with the aesthetic experience of the people under those roofs. It was six storeys, grey, with small balconies on each floor, some of which had plants on them and some of which had bicycles and one of which had, inexplicably, a small trampoline. The surrounding street had the washed-out quality of streets that are not on the way to anything, streets that exist for the people who live on them and no one else.

Our host, whose name was Gábor, met us in the lobby. He was perhaps forty, with the slightly harassed air of a man managing several things at once, and he shook our hands efficiently and led us to the lift, which was small and made a noise on the way up that I chose not to think about too carefully, and then to the apartment on the fourth floor, which was — and I want to be fair here — clean. Genuinely clean. The kind of clean that requires regular effort rather than occasional attention. The floors were clean. The bathroom was clean. The small kitchen had been cleaned to a standard that suggested Gábor took this seriously and perhaps personally.

It was also, in every other respect, relentlessly beige.

The walls were beige. The sofa was beige. The curtains were a shade of beige that had been given a different name — "oatmeal," perhaps, or "natural linen" — but which was, in practice, beige. The one picture on the wall was a print of a landscape that managed to contain rolling hills and a sunset and absolutely no emotional content whatsoever.

"It's very clean," I said to Sam, after Gábor had shown us the wifi password and the spare keys and explained the recycling system, which was thorough, and left.

"Very," Sam agreed.

We stood in the beige sitting room with our bags and looked at the beige walls.

"We should find somewhere else tomorrow," I said.

Sam looked at me. "We've been here four minutes."

"I know. But—" I gestured at the walls, at the curtains, at the landscape print with its cheerful absence of feeling.

"It's fine, Alex."

"It's very beige."

"Beige doesn't hurt anyone."

"It doesn't help anyone either."

Sam set his bag down with the deliberate calm of someone managing their response carefully. "We have two nights here. It's clean, it's quiet, the beds will be fine, and we're going to spend most of our time out in the city anyway. What does it matter what colour the walls are?"

This was entirely reasonable. I knew it was entirely reasonable even as he was saying it. The problem was not, if I am

honest, the walls. The problem was that I had left somewhere I liked and arrived somewhere unfamiliar and the unfamiliar was presenting itself, at this particular moment, as beige, and beige was a perfectly adequate surface on which to project a general dissatisfaction that had nothing to do with interior decoration.

I knew this. I did not say it. What I said instead was: "I just think we could do better."

"For two nights," Sam said, "we can do fine."

There was a pause. Outside the window, the street was quiet. A pigeon landed on the balcony railing, looked at us with the blank assessment of a pigeon, and left.

"Okay," I said. "Two nights."

"Two nights," Sam said. "And then we'll find somewhere better in Moltravia."

"Promise?"

He looked at me with an expression that contained, I thought, a small amount of amusement and a larger amount of patience. "I promise that in Moltravia I will personally ensure that no wall in our vicinity is beige."

"Thank you," I said. "That's all I ask."

We unpacked. The unpacking took eleven minutes. We went out.

* * *

Vrest, it turned out, rewarded the going out.

The tram back towards the old city took us through the wide streets we had seen on the way in, and this time, going in the right direction with the specific purpose of finding the city rather than finding the accommodation, it looked different. The mixed

buildings I had noticed before seemed, on second look, less like inconsistency and more like character — a city that had layers, that had not been built all at once but had been added to by different people with different ideas at different times, and the result was a kind of argument in stone and concrete and glass that was ongoing and unresolved and, in its way, alive.

The old city, when we reached it, was everything Sam's research had quietly promised. It was smaller than Drevska's old town but denser — the streets tighter, the buildings pressing in from both sides with the close familiarity of old neighbours, the whole thing arranged around a central square that was large enough to contain a proper market and a cathedral and a considerable number of pigeons and still have room left for the people who were using it.

The cathedral was extraordinary. I am not a person who uses that word carelessly — I have been in a number of churches and cathedrals across several countries and I have found most of them impressive and some of them beautiful and a very few of them the kind of thing that stops you in the street before you have even gone in. This was the last kind. It was not especially large, as cathedrals go. What it had was detail — every surface of the exterior covered in carved stone figures and patterns and scenes, layer upon layer of it, accumulated over centuries by people who apparently felt that blank stone was an opportunity rather than a resting point. I stood in front of it for quite a long time.

"You're doing the thing," Sam said.

"What thing?"

"The thing where you stand in front of something and your mouth is slightly open."

I closed my mouth. "It's remarkable."

"It is," Sam said, looking up at it with rather more composure than I was managing. "Fourteenth century, mostly,

with additions up to the seventeenth. They apparently never quite agreed on a style, so they just kept adding things in whatever style was current at the time."

"How do you know that?"

"I read."

"When?"

"On the train. While you were being wistful about Drevska."

I chose to take this as information rather than a comment. I looked back at the cathedral. The accumulated centuries of people who had not agreed on a style but had kept adding things anyway had produced something that should not have worked — should have been a muddle, an argument in stone — but which was instead, against all odds, magnificent. There was a lesson in this. I wrote it down.

* * *

We were hungry by seven o'clock, which in Vrest turned out to be slightly early for dinner in the way that it is early for dinner in cities that eat late and regard anyone who eats before eight with mild curiosity.

We had no recommendation. Mrs Vachová was three and a half hours away on a train, Tomáš did not know Vrest, and the internet, when consulted, offered seventeen options within walking distance that all had reviews either inexplicably enthusiastic or specifically disappointed with the chips. We decided, in the absence of better information, to walk until we found somewhere that looked right.

This is a method I have used in various cities with varying results. The key variable, I have found, is how you define "looks right," which is a judgment based on factors that are partly rational and partly entirely instinctive and which I have never

been able to fully articulate but which involves, at minimum: whether people inside appear to be eating rather than waiting for food, whether the menu in the window contains a number of items that is neither suspiciously small nor suspiciously large, and whether the general atmosphere of the place suggests that the people running it care about something more than getting you in and out quickly.

We walked for twenty minutes. We passed several restaurants that failed one or more of these tests. We turned a corner into a street we had not intended to turn into — narrow, a little away from the main thoroughfares, lit by a combination of streetlights and the light spilling from the windows of the buildings — and found it.

I want to be honest about what it looked like from the outside, because honesty requires me to admit that it did not look especially promising. It was small. The sign above the door was hand-painted in a style that suggested the person who painted it was confident in their cooking but had not necessarily given the same attention to typography. The menu, such as it was, was written on a chalkboard just inside the door in handwriting that was enthusiastic but not consistent. There were six tables. Four of them were occupied by people who were very clearly locals, which is either the best possible sign or an ambiguous one depending on the cuisine.

"In?" Sam asked.

I looked at the people inside eating. They had the particular expression of people eating food they have eaten before and expect to be good and which is, in fact, good. Not the expression of discovery — the expression of reliable satisfaction, which is a different thing and in its own way more persuasive.

"In," I said.

* * *

The woman who appeared to run the restaurant — who also appeared to be the only person running the restaurant, taking orders and bringing food and clearing tables with the efficient omnipresence of someone who has done this long enough to have developed a personal system — was perhaps fifty-five, with the kind of face that has been in a warm kitchen for many years and is entirely at peace with this. She looked at us when we came in with the assessing expression of someone determining, very quickly, what category of customer we were.

Whatever she determined, she appeared to find it acceptable, because she seated us at a table near the window with a nod and produced two menus, which were in Kalvenian only, and said something that I took to mean she'd be back in a moment.

The menus were short. This was encouraging. I have a theory that the length of a menu is inversely proportional to the quality of what's on it — that a place offering one hundred and forty dishes has spread its attention too thinly, while a place offering twelve has had to think carefully about each one. I cannot prove this theory. I have found it reliable.

The menu had nine items. I could not read any of them.

"What does yours say?" I asked Sam, who had his translation app open.

"Mine says—" he scanned it— "something with pork, something with chicken, something with fish, two things I can't identify, and what appears to be a soup."

"Which soup?"

"The app just says 'soup.'?"

"That's not a translation, that's a category."

"The app is doing its best."

The woman came back. She looked at us with the patient expression of someone who has had the foreign visitor menu problem many times and has a method.

She pointed at something on my menu and said a word.

I looked at it. I looked at her. "Is it good?" I asked, which was a question she could not understand but which I asked anyway because asking felt more respectful than simply nodding.

She looked at me for a moment. Then she put her hand flat against her chest, over her heart, and patted it twice. It was not a large gesture. It was entirely unambiguous.

"That one," I said.

She pointed at the same item on Sam's menu. He nodded. She took the menus and left.

"What did we just order?" Sam asked.

"Something she is personally invested in," I said. "I have no further information."

* * *

What arrived, twenty minutes later, was a stew.

I say "a stew" the way you might say "a painting" when what you mean is that the thing in front of you is technically within the category but has been done with a degree of care and intention that puts it in a different conversation from most other members of its category. It came in a heavy pot, dark and deep and smelling of things that had been cooking together for a long time and had reached the stage of cooking where individual ingredients stop being individual ingredients and become something collective and more than the sum of their parts. There was bread on the side — not žemle, not the bread of Drevska, but its own bread, thicker and darker, with a density that turned out to

be exactly right for the purpose of the stew, which required something that could hold up.

I ate it with the attention it deserved, which was considerable.

It was not the duck. The duck at U Tři Mostů occupied, and would continue to occupy, a specific position in my personal hierarchy of meals that I did not expect anything on this trip to challenge. But the stew was something else — rougher, less refined, the kind of food that has been made the same way for a very long time because no one has found any reason to change it, and which carries in it the particular authority of things that have not needed to improve.

"All right?" Sam said.

"Don't talk to me," I said. "I'm eating."

It was the second time I had said this on the trip. Sam smiled in the way he smiled when something was funny and also when something was right, a smile that covered both situations with the same expression, which I found efficient.

We ate. The restaurant filled up around us — slowly, as restaurants fill up when it gets later and the city moves from the business of the early evening to the business of the proper evening. The four tables that had been occupied when we arrived were still occupied by the same people, who showed no particular signs of leaving. Two more tables filled. The woman who ran the place moved between them all with the unhurried competence of someone who knows exactly how much she can manage and has arranged her world accordingly.

At the table next to us, two men of roughly our age were having a conversation that was clearly an argument of some kind — voices raised slightly, hands moving, the specific energy of people who disagree strongly about something and are enjoying the disagreement. At one point one of them noticed us looking and

said something that made both of them laugh, and raised his glass in our direction. We raised ours back. No further communication was attempted or necessary.

This, I thought, was the other thing about travel that nothing else quite manages. The permission it gives you to be in the middle of life — other people's lives, ordinary life, the life that is going on regardless of whether you are there to see it — without needing to explain yourself or justify your presence. You are simply there, watching, being, part of it for an evening. And then you leave, and it continues without you.

I wrote this down on the paper tablecloth, because I did not have my notebook to hand, and tore the corner off to keep. It is on my desk at home, as I write this, slightly stained with stew.

* * *

We walked back to the tram stop through the old city at ten o'clock, the streets quieter now but not empty, with the specific quality of a city that stays up rather than goes to bed. The cathedral was lit from below, which gave it an entirely different character from the daytime — more dramatic, the carved figures casting long shadows up the stone face, the whole thing looking slightly more serious about itself than it had in the afternoon sun.

We waited for the tram in a companionable silence that had, I noted, a different quality from the silence we'd had that afternoon in the beige apartment. That had been a silence with something unresolved in it. This was simply the silence of two people who had eaten well and walked enough and had nothing urgent to say.

The tram came. We rode it back through the wide streets and got off at our stop and walked the three blocks to the residential building with the small balconies. In the lift, which made the same noise as before, I looked at the floor.

"The stew was exceptional," I said.

"It was," Sam agreed.

"I was wrong about the walls."

Sam said nothing for a moment. The lift arrived at the fourth floor with a small jolt. The doors opened.

"You weren't entirely wrong about the walls," he said. "They are very beige."

"But it doesn't matter."

"It genuinely doesn't matter."

We went into the apartment. The walls were beige. The curtains were beige. The landscape print had the same rolling hills and the same sunset and the same emotional vacancy. None of it mattered in the slightest.

I slept very well.

* * *

A thing I have noticed about disagreements between people who know each other well is that they are rarely about what they appear to be about. The thing you argue about is the surface. Underneath is something else — tiredness, or disappointment, or a feeling you have not yet found the words for and have displaced onto the nearest available object, which in our case had been the colour of a wall.

I had been, I think, slightly sad about leaving Drevska, and the sadness had arrived in Vrest looking for somewhere to put itself and had found the apartment available. This was not the apartment's fault. It was not Sam's fault. It was no one's fault, because sadness about leaving places you have liked is not a fault. It is simply the cost of the thing, and the cost is worth paying.

Sam had known this, I suspected. He had waited for me to work it out, which had taken approximately four hours and one exceptional stew.

I wrote this down the next morning in the notebook, sitting on the beige sofa with a cup of coffee made from the packet Gábor had left on the kitchen counter — instant, entirely mediocre, drunk without complaint.

Some mornings require extraordinary coffee. Some mornings are fine with whatever is there.

I was, I realised, making progress.

—

From the notebook, Vrest, day one:

The stew was rough and serious and entirely right. The cathedral was built by people who could not agree and produced something magnificent. The walls are beige.

I am trying to learn something from the cathedral.

Chapter Seven

What Vrest Does at Night

In Which the City Reveals Itself to People Who Are Paying Attention, and One of Us Definitely Is

I want to tell you about six-fifty in the morning in a city you don't know, because I think it is one of the best things there is and it does not get talked about enough.

Sam was asleep. I could hear this through the wall between our rooms — not snoring exactly, more a deep, settled breathing that had the quality of someone who has gone somewhere and is not coming back for a while. Sam slept with the same thoroughness he brought to everything else: fully, without apparent reservation, getting the maximum available value from the exercise. I envied him this. I sleep in the way of someone who is mostly asleep but keeping one ear open for developments, which is not restful and has never been restful and which I have largely given up trying to change.

It was six-fifty. It was our last full day in Vrest. The apartment was quiet and the street outside was making the specific sounds of a city at the beginning of its day — a vehicle somewhere, unhurried, the distant percussion of something being unloaded, a sound that might have been a shutter being raised.

I got dressed quietly. I took my notebook and my jacket and my room key and, after a moment's consideration, left Sam a note

on the kitchen counter that said: *Gone out. Back by nine. Don't worry.* The "don't worry" was for me rather than for him. Sam would not worry. Sam would wake up, see the note, make coffee with the mediocre instant, and read his book, and be entirely fine. I was the one who needed the reassurance of having told someone where I was going, even if where I was going was simply out.

I closed the apartment door behind me with the care of someone trying not to wake a sleeping house. I took the stairs rather than the lift with its alarming noise. I went out through the lobby into the morning.

* * *

The street at six-fifty was a different street from the one we had walked back along at ten-thirty the previous night. Same street, same buildings, same cobblestones — but emptied and rearranged by the early hour into something quieter and more essential, the way a room looks different when the furniture has been moved to the edges.

There was a man with a small orange street-cleaning vehicle, the kind with rotating brushes underneath, working his way methodically along the pavement with the focused purposefulness of someone in the middle of a job they have done many times and which they are, if not passionate about, at least entirely competent at. He did not look up as I passed. I had the feeling, which I always have in cities at this hour, of being briefly invisible — of moving through a world that is occupied with its own business and has not yet started performing for anyone.

I walked in the direction of the old city, which I had established well enough the previous day to navigate without the map, or at least to navigate in the approximate right direction without the map, which is a different thing but was sufficient for the purpose. The streets were mostly empty. Occasionally another person — walking a dog, or carrying something, or simply going somewhere with the early-morning energy of a person who keeps

different hours from the majority — and we would pass each other with the brief acknowledgment of people sharing an hour that most people are missing. Not a nod, not quite. Something subtler. The simple recognition of mutual presence.

The city smelled different at this hour. The cooking smells of the evening were gone, replaced by something cooler and cleaner — wet stone from overnight, the faint green note of whatever trees Vrest had found room for, the first traces of bread from somewhere not yet visible. The light was low and particular, coming in at an angle that made the buildings look like they were made of something other than they were made of, something warmer and less definite.

I walked and I did not think about anything specific and this was, I found, remarkable. At home, walking without a destination meant walking while thinking about work, or about things I had left undone, or about conversations I should have had differently, or about the general low-level administrative anxiety of a life that has accumulated obligations. Here, walking without a destination meant walking. The mind, deprived of its usual material, had settled into something quieter and was simply receiving.

I had not realised, until that morning on a street in Vrest at ten past seven, how long it had been since I had done that.

* * *

The flower stall was being set up in a small square off the main road to the old city, and I stopped because the man setting it up was doing it with a ceremony that I found unexpectedly moving.

He was perhaps sixty, with large, careful hands, and he was arranging flowers on the wooden trestles of the stall with the deliberate attention of someone who understands that the first arrangement of the day sets the tone for everything that follows.

He was not rushing. He was not, as far as I could tell, thinking about anything other than the flowers in his hands and where they should go. He would place a bunch, step back, look at it, sometimes move it slightly, sometimes leave it. He worked without music, without a phone, without any apparent need for anything other than the flowers and the morning and the incremental satisfying process of arranging things correctly.

I watched him for longer than was strictly polite. He was aware of me — he glanced over once, briefly, with the unconcerned look of a man who is used to people watching him work and has no objection to it — and then returned to the flowers.

I thought about Tomáš, and what he had said about knowing one thing properly. The man with the flowers knew flowers. He knew them the way you know something when you have spent years paying attention to it — not just the names and the varieties but the feel of them, the weight, the specific quality of each one, the way they needed to be arranged to be most fully themselves. He had made his world small enough to know it completely, and this gave his movements a quality that I can only describe as precision, though it was not the precision of efficiency — it was the precision of care.

I bought a small bunch of something yellow whose name I did not know and which I had no particular use for. He wrapped them in paper without being asked, with three practiced movements, and handed them over and told me a price that I paid without negotiating because it seemed wrong to negotiate with someone who arranged flowers like that.

I carried them for the rest of the morning. They were slightly awkward to carry. I did not mind.

* * *

The old woman and the pigeons were in the square in front of the cathedral, and I had the immediate and specific impression

that they had been in the square in front of the cathedral every morning for a very long time and would continue to be there every morning for as long as she was able to come.

She was small and bent slightly at the shoulders with the gentle forward lean of age, wearing a dark coat that had the settled look of a coat worn so many times it had taken on the shape of its owner. She had a paper bag in one hand from which she was taking pieces of bread and distributing them to the pigeons with the methodical generosity of a person fulfilling an obligation — not casually, not carelessly, but with the specific attention of someone who has decided that this matters and acts accordingly.

The pigeons, for their part, had organised themselves around her in the way of creatures that know something reliable is happening. There were perhaps thirty of them, jostling mildly in the way of pigeons, making the small cooing sounds that pigeons make and which, in large enough numbers and in a quiet enough square in the early morning, become something not unpleasant — a low, warm, collective murmur.

I sat on the cathedral steps, not close enough to disturb anything, and watched.

She finished the bag. She folded it with the economy of someone who wastes nothing and put it in her coat pocket. She stood for a moment and watched the pigeons continue their meal with the expression of someone checking that a thing has been done correctly. Then she turned and walked away across the square in the direction she had presumably come from, with the unhurried regularity of a person on a schedule they have long since stopped needing to think about.

The pigeons dispersed gradually, in the indifferent way of pigeons, back to wherever pigeons go.

I sat on the steps for a while longer. The cathedral above me was doing the thing it had done the previous day — being extraordinary — but in the early morning light it was a different

kind of extraordinary. Less dramatic, more present. I could see the individual carved figures on the lower sections that I had missed from a distance the day before — small, detailed, each one distinct, people and animals and things I couldn't identify, covering every available surface up to the height a person could reach, above which the stone was plainer, as though whoever was carving had run out of either time or scaffolding and had simply stopped.

I found this detail — the carving stopping at roughly head height, the plain stone above, the ambition meeting the practical limit — oddly comforting. Even the people who built extraordinary things ran out of something eventually. They left it as it was. It was still extraordinary.

I wrote this down. I also wrote down the old woman, the pigeons, the flower man, the early morning street. My notebook was becoming, I noticed, less a record of places and more a record of people — the specific, unhurried people who fill the hours of cities that tourists mostly miss, because tourists arrive when the day is already fully underway and the unhurried early morning people have gone back inside.

* * *

I got lost on the way back.

I want to be precise: I was not lost in the way that causes genuine concern, the way of being in an unfamiliar place with no bearings and no means of recovery. I had my phone. I had the map app. I was, in a technical sense, findable and navigable at any moment.

What I did was choose not to use it, which is a different thing, and which I did partly out of the spirit of the morning and partly because I had turned down a street that seemed to be going in approximately the right direction and wanted to see where it went.

It went, as streets will, somewhere unexpected.

It narrowed first, and then opened into a small courtyard — not the courtyard of Drevska, not Tomáš's key and the ancient ivy, but a different kind of courtyard entirely, more functional, more lived-in. There were residents' bicycles along one wall. There were pot plants in various stages of ambition. There was a line of washing. There was, sitting on a plastic chair in the corner with a cup of something and a newspaper, a man of perhaps seventy-five who looked up when I appeared with the mild surprise of someone not expecting a visitor and the equally mild lack of concern of someone who has seen enough of the world to find most things only moderately surprising.

We looked at each other.

"Sorry," I said. "I'm — wrong turn. I'll—" I gestured back at the street.

He said something in Kalvenian that I could not follow, but which had the tone of someone saying that it was no problem, come in, these things happen. He gestured at the courtyard in the manner of a general invitation.

I stood there for a moment, holding my yellow flowers, in a courtyard I had not intended to find, being invited to stay by a man whose name I didn't know.

I stayed.

I found a low wall to sit on. The man returned to his newspaper. We occupied the courtyard together in a silence that was, remarkably, entirely comfortable — two people sharing a space with no common language and no particular agenda, in the easy way of people who have both, for their own separate reasons, found themselves in a courtyard on a weekday morning and have decided that this is all right.

After perhaps ten minutes he folded his newspaper, stood with the careful movements of a man respecting the limits of a body that has been well used, and went inside. He paused at the door and said something and gestured at me and then at the courtyard, which I interpreted as a general indication that the courtyard was available for as long as I wanted it.

I stayed another ten minutes. Then I used the map app to find my way back, feeling only slightly guilty about it.

* * *

Sam was awake when I got back, as expected. He was sitting at the kitchen table with a cup of the mediocre instant coffee and his book, and he looked up when I came in with the equanimity of a man who had read the note, processed its contents, and found them unsurprising.

"Good?" he said.

"Very." I put the yellow flowers on the table, where they looked slightly incongruous against the beige but cheerfully so. "I got lost."

"On purpose?"

"Mostly."

Sam looked at the flowers. "Where did those come from?"

"A man setting up a stall. He was arranging them—" I paused, trying to find the right description— "like they mattered."

Sam looked at me for a moment with the specific attention he occasionally brought to things I said, the look of someone filing something away.

"You seem different," he said.

I poured myself a cup of the mediocre instant. "Different how?"

He thought about it. Sam always thought about things before he said them, which was one of his better qualities and occasionally one of his more unnerving ones. "Lighter," he said finally. "Like something you were carrying has gone down a bit."

I sat down across from him and looked at the yellow flowers on the beige table. Outside, Vrest was getting on with its day.

"I've been thinking," I said. "About work."

"Okay."

"Not in the way I usually think about work. Not the — the immediate stuff, the deadlines, the things I haven't done. More about—" I stopped. Started again. "I edit other people's books. All day, every day. I make them clearer and better and I send them back and someone else publishes them and people read them. And I'm good at it."

"You are."

"But I've been doing it for six years and I don't think I've written a single thing in six years that was mine. Not properly. Nothing I put my own—" I made a gesture that was supposed to indicate the whole of oneself and which probably looked like someone batting away a fly. "I stopped."

Sam was quiet. This was not the quiet of someone without a response. It was the quiet of someone giving the response room.

"When did you stop?" he asked.

"I'm not sure. I didn't notice while it was happening. I just—" I looked at the notebook on the table. "I've written more in this notebook in six days than I have in the last two years. Actual things. Things I noticed, things I thought, things that felt—" I stopped again. "Real," I said finally. "Things that felt real."

Sam looked at the notebook. Then at me. "Why are you telling me this at eight in the morning in Vrest?"

"Because I've been thinking about it since the flower stall and I needed to say it out loud to someone before I talked myself out of it."

"Talked yourself out of what?"

I held the coffee cup in both hands. "I don't know yet. That's the problem."

Sam nodded. He did not offer solutions, which was the correct response. He did not tell me what I should do, or what I clearly wanted, or that everything would work out, which are the three things people most often say when someone tells them something they don't know what to do with. He simply received what I had said and gave it the space it required.

"Drink your coffee," he said, after a while. "We've got a whole city to deal with."

I drank my coffee. It was, as before, entirely mediocre. I barely noticed.

* * *

Vrest in the afternoon was the Vrest I had not yet seen — the residential Vrest, the ordinary Vrest, the Vrest that had nothing in particular to show you and was getting on without you regardless.

We walked without a plan, which had by now become our operating method, and the city produced, in the way that cities do when you give them the opportunity, an afternoon of the kind that defies easy summary. There was a park along the river — not grand, not designed to impress, just a park, with benches and old trees and a path along the water where people were walking dogs and pushing prams and doing the things that people do in parks

on weekday afternoons when the weather is cooperative. We walked along it for forty minutes and Sam photographed a heron on a post at the river's edge, which stood with the complete stillness of something that has committed entirely to its current position and will not be moved.

There was a bookshop in a side street that had the particular atmosphere of a bookshop that has been in the same place for a long time and has organised itself according to a system that makes complete sense to the owner and possibly to no one else. The shelves were floor to ceiling and the books were in Kalvenian and I could not read any of them, but I spent twenty minutes in it anyway because I find that the physical fact of books — the smell of them, the density of them, the accumulated human effort and attention that they represent — is something I respond to regardless of whether I can read them. Sam found a shelf at the back that appeared to be translated fiction and bought something that I could not read the cover of but which he said was by an author he had been looking for for two years and which he had not expected to find in a second-hand bookshop in Vrest, and which he held with the particular satisfaction of someone who has been given something they did not ask for but needed.

We had lunch at a place that was not a restaurant exactly — more a room at the back of a deli, with four tables and a handwritten daily menu that Sam translated as containing something with cabbage and something with sausage. We had the sausage, which was dense and smoky and arrived with bread and a small pot of mustard that was, I want to say, one of the finest mustards I have ever encountered. Sharp and complex and dark, the kind of mustard that has opinions. I took a photograph of it. I am not normally a person who photographs food. I photographed the mustard.

"You're photographing mustard," Sam observed.

"It's exceptional mustard."

"It's mustard."

"You haven't tasted it yet."

He tasted it. He was quiet for a moment. Then he took out his own phone and photographed it as well, which I felt was vindication enough.

* * *

Vrest at night was a revelation, and I use that word carefully because I think it is the right one.

We went out at eight, which by Vrest standards was when the evening was beginning rather than already underway. The streets of the old city were full in a way they had not been during the day — not tourist-full, not a managed crowd moving between sights, but city-full, the fullness of people who live here and are using the evening for the things evenings are for. Groups of young people. Families. Couples walking with the specific gait of two people who have chosen, out of all available options, to walk next to each other.

The square in front of the cathedral, which had been the domain of the old woman and the pigeons at dawn and the tourist and the market at midday, was something else entirely now. Someone had set up a small stage in one corner — not a professional stage, just a raised platform with some lights rigged above it — and a band was playing. I want to describe the music precisely because it deserves precision: it was not the folk music of tourist restaurants, performed for people who want to feel they have experienced something authentic. It was simply music, made by four people who were good at it, for an audience of people who wanted to hear it. It had in it something that I recognised as Kalvenian — a particular rhythm, a particular use of a stringed instrument I could not name — but it was not performing its Kalvenianness. It was just playing.

People had arranged themselves around the square in the organic way of people drawn to music without having planned to be — standing, sitting on the steps of the buildings, leaning against walls. There was, in the middle of the square, a small area of open cobblestones where several children were dancing with the complete unselfconsciousness of children who have not yet been taught that dancing in public requires justification.

We found a place to stand near the edge and listened.

After a while, I stopped listening in the deliberate way and simply heard it, which is a different thing — the music becoming part of the evening rather than the focus of it, the sound mixing with the voices around us and the distant traffic and the cool air coming off the river somewhere nearby. I was aware of being very specifically here, in this square, on this evening, in a city I had arrived in without expectations and which had turned out to have a great deal to say for itself.

I thought about the morning. The flower man. The old woman and her pigeons. The courtyard and the man in the plastic chair who had invited a stranger to share his space without requiring explanation. The bookshop. The mustard.

I thought about what I had said to Sam over mediocre instant coffee — the thing I had not planned to say, which had come out because the morning walk and the early hour and the particular quiet of the city had loosened something that had been held too tight for too long. I had not said it all. I had not known all of it yet. But I had said the beginning of it, which was more than I had managed in two years of knowing it was there.

Travel, I was understanding, did not just show you places. It showed you things about yourself that the ordinary routine of your life kept politely out of view — things that required the particular conditions of being somewhere unfamiliar and slightly uncertain and unexpectedly free to become visible. The flower man knowing one thing properly. The cathedral built by people

who disagreed. The key to the courtyard passed from hand to hand by people who trusted each other.

I was not sure yet what all of it meant. I was beginning to think that working out what it meant might be one of the things the trip was for.

Next to me, Sam was watching the children dance with an expression that was simply happy — the uncomplicated, present happiness of a person who is exactly where he is and finds it sufficient.

"Good evening," I said, which is a slightly formal thing to say to someone you've known for seven years, but which seemed right.

"Very good evening," Sam said.

The band played on. One of the children, a small girl of perhaps five in a red coat, danced her way to the edge of the cobblestone area and looked up at us and then, with the sovereign confidence of someone who does not yet know about self-consciousness, held out her hand.

Sam looked at me.

I looked at Sam.

He went. He took the small hand and was led to the cobblestones and danced, badly and entirely willingly, to the music of a band in a square in Vrest on a Thursday evening in October. The child found this satisfactory. The people nearby found it amusing. Sam found it, by the expression on his face, excellent.

I stayed at the edge and watched and wrote nothing down for once, because some things you have to just let happen without reaching for the notebook, and this was one of them.

I did write it down later, at the kitchen table, after we got back, while Sam made tea with the emergency teabags he had been carrying in his bag since Stravnik and had been saving, he said, for the right moment.

"Was that the right moment?" I asked.

"That was definitely the right moment," he said.

We drank our tea. The beige walls were still beige. Neither of us mentioned them.

—

From the notebook, Vrest, last night:

Things I am carrying that I did not expect to carry: the flower man's hands. The child in the red coat. Something Sam said this morning that I have been thinking about all day.

He said I seemed lighter. I think he was right. I am trying to stay that way.

Chapter Eight

The Light Is Different Here

In Which Ference's Warning Turns Out to Be Entirely Justified and Also Completely Insufficient

The bus to Moltravia left Vrest Central Station at seven forty-five in the morning from a bay that was not clearly marked, or rather was marked with a sign that had been placed at a height and angle that suggested it was intended to be read by someone considerably taller than either of us, and which we found eventually by the simple method of walking along the row of bays until we found a bus with "DOLKA" written on the front in letters large enough to be unambiguous.

I want to say something about buses, because buses are not trains and the distinction matters.

Trains have a dignity to them. They run on rails, they know where they are going, they arrive and depart with a precision that suggests the whole enterprise has been thought through carefully by people who take punctuality seriously. There is a quality of intention about a train that I find, as I have mentioned, reassuring.

Buses are different. Buses have a more improvisational quality. They use roads, which are shared with everything else, and are therefore subject to everything else — the lorry that has stalled at a junction, the roadworks that have materialised since

the route was planned, the driver who has a different relationship with amber traffic lights than the official guidance suggests. Buses stop at more places, pick up more people, and have a more democratic atmosphere than trains — less the feeling of everyone going somewhere specific and more the feeling of everyone going somewhere, which is a broader and more various category.

I have mixed feelings about buses. I respect them. I do not entirely trust them. On this particular morning I was on one for six hours, which gave me plenty of time to develop my position further.

* * *

The bus filled, in the ten minutes before departure, with a collection of people that I found immediately interesting.

There was, directly across the aisle from us, a woman of perhaps fifty-five who had the organised competence of someone who travels this route regularly and has it managed to the last detail. She had a window seat, a neck pillow deployed before the bus had even moved, a small bag from which she produced, in sequence over the next twenty minutes, a thermos of tea, a wrapped sandwich, a paperback, and a pair of reading glasses with tortoiseshell frames. She arranged these items on the tray table and the seat beside her with the efficiency of someone setting up a workstation, and then settled in with the thermos and the paperback and did not look up again for two hours. I found her entirely admirable.

Behind us was the teenage boy. He was perhaps sixteen, travelling alone, with headphones the size of small satellites and a rucksack that he had placed on the seat beside him in a way that suggested he was either unaware that the seat might be needed or aware of it and had decided to address the issue if it arose. He fell asleep before the bus had left the station, in the sideways, totally committed way that teenagers sleep — head against the window, mouth slightly open, arms folded across his chest — and remained

in this position for the entirety of the journey in a feat of sustained unconsciousness that I found both impressive and faintly enviable.

And then there was the man three rows ahead.

The man three rows ahead waited until the bus had been moving for approximately forty minutes — past the city limits of Vrest, past the flat fields and the lines of trees we had seen from the train, into open countryside — and then reached into the bag at his feet and produced a hot meal.

I want to be specific: it was hot. Not a sandwich, not a packet of biscuits, not the portable, ambient-temperature food of normal bus travel. It was a container of something that steamed when he opened it, something with a rich, savoury smell that drifted back through the bus with the particular confidence of an aroma that knows it is welcome and does not require permission. He had a fork. He had, apparently, a napkin. He ate with the settled pleasure of a man who has made adequate provision for himself and is now benefiting from it.

Half the bus looked at him. He did not appear to notice. He ate his hot meal, tidied everything away with the same efficiency with which he had produced it, and then folded his hands and looked out the window at the countryside going past with the expression of someone who has done everything that needed doing and is now content.

"How," I said to Sam, in a low voice, "did he keep it hot?"

"Thermos container, probably. The kind with the vacuum seal."

"He planned this."

"Clearly."

I looked at the man three rows ahead with something that was very close to respect. He had considered his journey, identified the problem of being hungry on a bus, and solved it

completely and without drama. There was a lesson here about preparation that I felt complicated my existing position on the subject, given my previous disagreements with Sam about overpacking and the antacids and so forth. I chose not to share this thought.

"I should have brought something," I said instead.

"We have the remainder of the žemle," Sam said, producing from his jacket pocket a slightly flattened paper parcel that I had forgotten he had organised at the bakery that morning.

It was the last of the Drevska bread, eaten on a bus going to a third country, slightly compressed and no longer warm. It was still, somehow, very good.

* * *

The border crossing into Moltravia happened at a town whose name I did not catch, at a point where the road went through a low valley between two hills and a cluster of official-looking buildings appeared on either side.

The bus slowed and stopped. A uniformed officer came aboard — young, serious, with the focused expression of someone performing a role they take seriously and intend to perform correctly. He worked his way down the aisle checking passports, which he did with a thoroughness that suggested he was actually looking at them rather than simply satisfying a procedural requirement.

When he reached us, he took my passport, looked at it, looked at me, looked at the passport again with the specific attention of someone checking that the photograph and the person are in agreement, which in my experience they often are not, as passport photographs tend to capture a version of a person that the person in question would rather not be reminded of. My passport photograph makes me look like a man who has just been

told some moderately bad news and is processing it with insufficient sleep. The officer looked at this photograph, looked at me, and appeared to reach the conclusion that we were the same person, which we were, though I understand the uncertainty.

He handed it back. He moved on.

I looked out the window. On the other side of the low valley, the landscape looked, at first glance, exactly the same as it had on the other side — the same countryside, the same sky, the same unhurried fields. And yet there was something different. Not in the physical geography, which cared nothing for borders, but in some quality of the light or the colour or simply the knowledge that the same landscape now had a different name.

We were in Moltravia.

I thought of Ference, in the taxi from my apartment to the airport, eleven days ago. His eyes in the mirror. The word "Moltravia" said in that specific tone. "Nice people," he had said. "Very enthusiastic drivers."

Within four minutes of crossing the border, a car overtook our bus on a stretch of road where overtaking required a level of confidence in one's own judgement that I found startling. The car was not travelling at an unreasonable speed. It was travelling at a speed that suggested its driver had calculated the available space and time with precision and was operating at the outer limit of what that calculation permitted. The bus driver did not react. The woman with the thermos did not look up. The teenage boy slept on.

"Enthusiastic drivers," Sam said, watching the car disappear ahead.

"He warned us," I said.

"He did."

We drove on into Moltravia.

* * *

Dolka appeared after three more hours of countryside that was, I want to say, genuinely beautiful in a way that had nothing to do with being scenic and everything to do with being real. It was agricultural land, mostly — fields and farms and the occasional small town that the road passed through rather than around, which meant that for brief periods the countryside gave way to high streets and squares and the daily life of places that were not trying to be anything other than what they were.

In one town, the bus stopped for ten minutes at what appeared to be a combined bus stop and hardware shop, and several passengers got off and one got on, and the driver disappeared inside for what turned out to be a cup of coffee that he drank standing at the counter with the ease of a regular. The woman with the thermos changed legs. The teenage boy, impossibly, continued to sleep.

And then Dolka.

I had looked at photographs of Dolka before the trip, in the general research I had done in those weeks of preparation, and the photographs had given me a rough idea of the place — a medium-sized city, a river, an old town, some notable buildings. What photographs do not convey, and what I was not prepared for, was the light.

Dolka sits in a wide flat plain, with nothing for miles around to interrupt the sky, and the sky above it at midday was enormous in a way that cities surrounded by hills or built on coasts simply are not. It was a sky that had room in it, that went on in every direction and suggested distance rather than enclosure. The light coming down from this sky onto the low buildings of the outskirts was direct and clear and a shade warmer than I had expected — not the pale northern light of Drevska, not the businesslike grey of Vrest on a cloudy morning, but something

with amber in it, something that made the stone and brick of the buildings look as though they were lit from within.

"The light is different," I said.

"We're further south," Sam said. "Different latitude. Different angle."

"I know why it's different. I'm noting that it is."

"Noted," Sam said.

I wrote it down anyway.

* * *

The hotel was called Hotel Tři Světla, which Sam's app translated as "Three Lights," and it was in the old city, and it was the opposite of beige.

I want to pause on this, because Sam had made a promise and had kept it, and promises kept deserve acknowledgment. The Hotel Three Lights was on a narrow street in the oldest part of Dolka, in a building that was eighteenth century at the outside and possibly older within, and when we pushed open the front door — heavy, wooden, with a brass handle worn smooth by a great deal of use — we stepped into a lobby that was a specific, deliberate shade of deep red that I can only describe as the colour a room turns when whoever decorated it was not playing it safe. There were two armchairs in the corner of a colour that was either very dark green or very dark blue depending on the light, and a small table between them with a lamp on it that gave off the warm, slightly amber glow that good table lamps give off and that overhead lights never manage. The floor was stone, old and slightly uneven. The ceiling had painted details on it that were faded to the point where you could see they had been beautiful without being able to fully determine what they depicted.

It smelled of wood and something floral — not aggressively, not the performative scent of hotels that pipe fragrance through their ventilation systems, but the real smell of a building that has flowers somewhere and old wood everywhere and has simply absorbed both over a long period of time.

"Better?" Sam said.

"Considerably," I said.

The man behind the desk was Felix.

I had not expected Felix. I had expected a receptionist — pleasant, professional, the standard interface between a traveller and their accommodation. Felix was something else. He was perhaps forty-five, tall and narrow, with a face that was mostly angles and the kind of eyes that are always slightly amused, as though the world is continuously providing him with material and he finds the material good. He was wearing a jacket that suggested he had opinions about jackets, and he greeted us not with the standard welcome of hospitality but with the straightforward warmth of someone who is genuinely pleased to see you, which is a different thing entirely.

"Alex and Sam," he said, before we had introduced ourselves, in English that was accented and exact. "I have been expecting you since—" he checked something— "three hours ago."

"The bus was—" I began.

"Buses are always something," Felix said, with the serenity of a man who has long since made peace with buses. "You are here now. That's what matters. Come, I'll show you your rooms."

He came out from behind the desk and led us up a staircase that turned twice and was lined with framed things — old maps, prints of the city, one very large oil painting of a woman who looked at you with an expression that was difficult to read and

which I decided, after a moment, was amusement. Felix noticed me looking at it.

"My great-grandmother," he said, without slowing down. "She found everything funny. It drove my great-grandfather mad. He loved her completely."

* * *

The rooms were on the third floor and they were, I want to say, the best rooms of the trip. Mine had a window that looked out over the rooftops of the old city to the plain beyond, where the sky was doing the enormous thing it had done on the way in. The bed had a frame of dark wood and a quilt that was heavier than modern quilts and more comfortable than anything that had a right to be at this price point. The walls were a pale yellow — not beige, I want to be absolutely clear about this, not beige, but a deliberate and specific yellow, the colour of old paper or afternoon light, a colour that was doing something to the room rather than simply covering the walls.

I sat on the bed for a moment and looked at the ceiling and felt, with a clarity that was almost physical, that I was glad to be alive and in this room and on this trip. It was a simple feeling. It required no analysis. I sat with it for a moment, which is not something I am in the habit of doing, and then I unpacked, which took longer than usual because I kept stopping to look at the light on the rooftops through the window.

Sam knocked on the connecting door ten minutes later.

"Well?" I said.

"Better," he said.

"Same?"

"Similar. Mine has a smaller window but a better chair."

"There's a chair?"

"An armchair. By the window. It's the kind of chair you read an entire book in without noticing the time."

I went and looked at the chair. He was right. It was exactly that kind of chair.

"Felix," I said.

"What about him?"

"He's interesting."

Sam looked at me. "You say that about everyone."

"Not everyone. Tomáš. The flower man. Mrs Vachová. Felix."

"That's everyone we've met."

I considered this. "We've been lucky," I said.

"Or paying attention."

I thought about Tomáš saying the same thing, in different words. "Both," I said. "Probably both."

* * *

Felix, it turned out, was impossible to categorise, which was probably why I found him so immediately interesting.

We encountered him again at six o'clock, when we came downstairs to go out for the evening, and he was behind the desk but also somehow not behind the desk — conducting three things at once with the fluid competence of someone for whom the desk is a base rather than a station. He was on the phone. He was writing something in a large ledger with a fountain pen. He was also, apparently, eating a small piece of something that he had on a plate to one side, which he consumed in the intervals between

the phone and the writing with the efficiency of a man who is not going to let the fact of a phone call prevent him from having dinner.

He finished the phone call, capped the pen, and looked at us with the air of someone giving us his full attention, which was remarkable given the number of things he had just been doing.

"Going out?" he said.

"Exploring," Sam said.

Felix nodded. "Good. I will tell you three things." He held up a finger. "One: go to the Starý Trh — the old market square. At this hour it is good. Later it is very good. Even later than that it is something else, which may or may not be appropriate depending on the people, but you look sensible so probably fine."

He held up a second finger. "Two: there is a street called Ulice Barvy — Colour Street, you will understand when you see it — that is not in the guidebooks because the guidebooks were written by people who did not look carefully enough. Go there."

A third finger. "Three: do not eat at the restaurant directly across from the old market square. It has a very nice sign. The sign is the best thing about it. Eat anywhere else. The city is full of good places. That one is not one of them."

He lowered his hand. "Any questions?"

"What is Colour Street?" I asked.

Felix smiled. It was the smile of someone who has been asked this question and prefers not to answer it. "You'll see," he said. "That's the point."

* * *

Dolka in the early evening was, as Felix had suggested, good.

It was different from Drevska's evenings, which had the quality of an old city settling into its night with the ease of long habit, and different from Vrest, which had the energy of a larger place that had more going on than it could fully contain. Dolka's evening energy was harder to name — something between the two, with a specific additional quality that I eventually identified as spontaneity. Things seemed to happen in Dolka not because they were planned but because the conditions were right for them.

The Starý Trh was a large cobbled square, longer than it was wide, surrounded on all sides by buildings of various ages that had been painted in colours — not the neutral, self-effacing colours of buildings that don't want to impose, but deliberate colours, each building its own shade, the whole effect being of a kind of argument in ochre and terracotta and faded blue and green that had been going on for a long time and showed no signs of resolution. It was lit, at this hour, by a combination of the last of the day's light and the lights coming on in the restaurants and bars that occupied the ground floors of the buildings, and the mixture of the two produced a quality of illumination that I found difficult to look away from.

There were people everywhere, but arranged in the organic way of people who have arrived independently and found their own positions rather than the managed distribution of a tourist attraction. Groups at tables outside. People walking. A man playing a guitar on the steps of what appeared to be a small municipal building, with a case open in front of him into which people were dropping coins with the casual generosity of people in a good mood. Two dogs, apparently unaccompanied, investigating something of mutual interest near the base of a stone column in the centre of the square.

We stood at the entrance to the square and took it in.

"Felix was right," Sam said.

"Felix was right," I agreed.

We found a table outside a restaurant that was neither the one across the square with the nice sign nor any of the several others whose menus I inspected with the caution of a man who has been told to be careful and has taken it seriously. The place we chose had a menu written in three languages, one of which was English, and a waiter who greeted us with the confidence of someone who knows the menu is good and is happy to let it speak for itself.

We ordered. The food arrived. It was excellent — not the revelation of the duck, not the rough authority of the Vrest stew, but something lighter and more intricate, the kind of food that shows off without being showy, that has been thought about and prepared by someone who cooks because they find it interesting.

We ate and watched the square and the square produced, as good squares do, a continuous supply of things to watch. The guitarist finished one song and started another. The two dogs concluded their investigation and went their separate ways with the satisfied air of parties who have reached a satisfactory arrangement. A group of young women at the next table erupted in laughter about something and then, gradually, stopped, and the silence between the laughter was as interesting as the laughter itself.

* * *

Colour Street was everything Felix had declined to explain and more.

We found it after dinner, guided by a handwritten map that Felix had produced from behind the desk when we returned briefly to collect warmer jackets, and which he had drawn with the fountain pen on a piece of hotel notepaper in thirty seconds, with the accuracy of someone for whom the city is so known that its streets are a kind of memory rather than a map.

The street was narrow, which was not unusual for the old city. What was unusual was that every surface of every building on both sides, from pavement to roofline, had been painted.

Not painted the way buildings are normally painted — one colour per building, or a design element here and there. Painted entirely, covered, every available inch of wall given over to images that covered the range from the straightforwardly pictorial — scenes of the city, figures, landscapes — to the abstract, the symbolic, the frankly inexplicable. It was not a uniform style. It had clearly been done by many different people over many years, each one painting over or around or in conversation with what was there before, the whole thing accumulating into something that was not coherent in the way of a planned artwork but was coherent in the way of something that has been made by a community over time — made out of the specific desires and impulses and ideas of a place, rather than by a single vision imposed from above.

I stood in the middle of Colour Street and turned slowly and looked at all of it.

There was, on the wall directly to my left, a painting of a woman looking out of a window. She was painted in a style that was realistic enough to be specific — you felt she was someone, a particular person, not a type — and she was looking out with an expression that I could not fully read. Not sad, not happy. Something in between that had more complexity in it than most expressions you see on painted walls, which tend towards the legible. She had been painted over at the edges by something more recent — a geometric pattern, dark blue and gold — so that she was partly obscured, her right side swallowed by the newer work, leaving only the window and her face and her left hand on the sill. The effect was of something partially remembered or partially lost, and it was, I thought, the most affecting thing I had seen on the whole trip.

I stood in front of it for a long time.

Sam stood beside me, and for once did not take a photograph, which I noticed and which seemed right. Some things you take a photograph of and some things you simply look at, and the woman in the window was the second kind.

"Who painted it?" I said, though I knew he wouldn't know.

"Someone who knew her, maybe," Sam said. "Or wanted to."

I thought about this for a long time afterward. I thought about it on the walk back to the hotel, and at the desk when Felix asked how we had found Colour Street and we both said "extraordinary" at the same moment, which made Felix smile the smile of a man who had known this would happen. I thought about it in the room, looking at the sky through the window, which was clear enough that night to show stars, the enormous Moltravian sky full of them.

I wrote in the notebook for an hour before I slept. Not about the woman in the window specifically — I was not ready to write about her specifically — but around her. About things that are partially lost and how the partial loss sometimes makes them more present rather than less. About the city as a surface on which people leave marks, and what it means to leave a mark, and who decides which marks stay.

It was the longest I had written in one sitting in two years.

I noticed this. I did not make a large thing of it. I simply noted it, the way you note something that might matter, and closed the notebook, and slept.

* * *

I should tell you what happened the next morning, because it is the thing that changed the shape of the rest of the time in Dolka and which I had not planned for and could not have planned for.

We went back to Colour Street.

This was Sam's idea, or rather Sam had said over breakfast — which Felix produced from a kitchen behind the desk and which was, of course, excellent, involving bread that was neither žemle nor the dark bread of Vrest but its own thing, denser and slightly sweet, with butter and a pot of something dark that turned out to be a plum preserve of startling intensity — that he wanted to photograph the street properly, in the morning light, before the day was fully underway.

We went. The street in the morning was different from the street at night — the colours more themselves in the direct light, less theatrical, more present. We walked slowly, looking at everything, and I looked again at the woman in the window and found her, in the morning, slightly different. Still there. Still partly obscured by the geometric pattern. But the expression I had read the night before as being between sad and happy seemed, in this light, to be something else. Not between anything. Simply waiting. Patient and still and waiting for something, or for someone.

A voice behind us said, in Moltravian, something that Sam's app translated, after a moment, as: "You came back."

We turned.

The woman who had spoken was perhaps thirty, with paint on her hands — not fresh paint, the ingrained paint of someone for whom paint is an occupational constant. She was looking at us with the interested, unsurprised expression of someone who sees people standing in front of the woman in the window not infrequently and has opinions about them.

"She gets people," she said, in English now, with an accent that placed her somewhere between Moltravian and somewhere else I couldn't place. "The ones who stand there longest are usually the most interesting. I notice."

"You painted her?" Sam asked.

The woman looked at the painting. "The face, yes. The rest—" she made a gesture that indicated the layers of the wall, the accumulation of other people's work around and over her contribution— "that happened after. I can't decide if it made it better or worse. I think it made it truer."

"Truer how?" I asked.

She looked at me with the expression of someone deciding how much to say. "The painting I did was complete," she said. "A woman in a window. You could see her whole. Then people painted over her and now you can only see part of her. But she's more interesting now, when she's partial. You fill in the rest yourself. You make her into whoever she is to you."

She paused. "That's what I mean by truer. The whole painting was mine. The partial painting is everyone's."

We stood in Colour Street in the morning and talked to her for forty-five minutes, which was forty minutes longer than I had expected to be in the street and which made us late for nothing because we had nothing to be late for, and I found this, which would have made me anxious three weeks ago, entirely fine.

Her name was Nela. She had been painting in Dolka for eight years. She knew every inch of Colour Street and the history of every wall on it, who had painted what and when and why and what had been there before. She was, it became clear, one of the people the street belonged to in the way that places belong to the people who have given the most of themselves to them.

She asked us where we were from and where we had been, and we told her about Drevska and Vrest and the courtyard with the key and Tomáš and the stew and the child in the red coat. She listened with the particular quality of attention that people have when they are genuinely interested rather than performing interest, and asked questions that went to the things we hadn't fully said.

"You're writing about this?" she said to me at one point, having noticed the notebook.

"Writing in it," I said. "I don't know if it's about anything yet."

She looked at me for a moment. "That's the best kind of writing," she said. "The kind that hasn't decided yet what it is. The kind that's still finding out."

She said this simply, not as wisdom, just as a thing she thought was true. But it landed in the way that true things land when you are ready to hear them — not dramatically, not with trumpets, just with the quiet weight of something that has found its place.

I wrote it down. She watched me do it and seemed satisfied.

—

From the notebook, Dolka, day one:

Felix was right about everything. The city has a quality I haven't found the word for yet. Nela said the best writing is the kind that hasn't decided yet what it is.

I wrote for an hour tonight. I haven't done that in two years. I am trying not to make a big thing of it. It feels like a big thing.

Chapter Nine

What Nela Showed Us

In Which We Spend Three Days with Someone Who Sees the City Differently and Discover That This Changes Everything

Nela was waiting outside the hotel at nine the next morning with two coffees and the expression of someone who has already been up for three hours and finds this entirely normal.

She had not been invited, precisely. What had happened, at the end of our conversation in Colour Street, was that she had said "I'll show you something tomorrow" in the tone of someone making a statement rather than an offer, and we had not said no, and the matter had apparently been settled on those terms. I had half-expected, as I often half-expect things that seem too good to be straightforwardly true, that she would not appear. She appeared.

"Felix told me you were up," she said, handing us the coffees.

"Felix told you?" I said.

"Felix tells me things. We have an arrangement." She said this without elaboration and in the tone of someone who does not feel that arrangements require explanation. I accepted this. In Dolka, I was finding, things operated according to a logic that was

perfectly coherent once you stopped trying to map it onto the logic you had brought with you.

The coffee was from a place two streets away that I made a note to find later, because it had the same quality as Tomáš's café in Drevska — the quality of coffee made by someone who thinks about coffee — and I wanted to be able to return to it independently, which felt important.

"Where are we going?" Sam asked.

Nela looked at him with the expression she had, I was beginning to understand, for questions she considered interesting. "Somewhere being demolished," she said.

"That's—" I paused. "Not what I expected."

"Good," she said. "Follow me."

* * *

The building was on the eastern edge of the old city, at the point where the old city met something newer and less considered — a transitional zone where the centuries-old stone gave way to twentieth-century concrete and the twentieth-century concrete was, in places, giving way to nothing, to empty plots where things had stood and now didn't.

The building being demolished was five storeys, or had been. The front wall was gone entirely, removed by the machinery that was parked at the side and which would, Nela said, return on Monday to continue the work. For today, the Saturday, the building stood open to the street like a doll's house — each floor visible from outside, each room exposed, the interior walls facing the morning with the slightly stunned expression of things that have spent their entire existence in private and have been abruptly made public.

There was no one else there. The site was technically fenced — there was an orange plastic barrier along the pavement — but the barrier had been arranged with a gap in it that was either an oversight or a deliberate accommodation, and Nela walked through it without slowing down. We followed.

We stood in what had been the ground floor of what had been a building, looking up through the open front at the floors above, and Nela pointed.

"Look at the walls," she said.

I looked at the walls.

The interior walls, stripped of their plaster in places by the demolition, were a record. That is the only word for it. Layer upon layer upon layer — paint and paper and paint again, each layer a different era, a different choice, a different idea of what a room should be. On the first floor I could see, going inward from the exposed edge: a deep red that was the most recent, beneath it a pale green with a floral border that belonged to some mid-century decade, beneath that a dark paper with a geometric pattern that was older still, and then, at the deepest layer, where the plaster had come away entirely, the bare stone of the original wall, with traces on it of a whitewash that must have been the first thing ever applied to it, two or three centuries ago.

Every family that had ever lived here had left a layer. Every generation's idea of what a home should look like was still there, compressed into a few centimetres of wall, readable if you knew how to read it.

"How old is this building?" Sam asked.

"Seventeenth century at the base," Nela said. "They added floors in the nineteenth. The top two are early twentieth. It's been three or four different things in its life — a merchant's house, a tenement, apartments. The walls have been painted over so many

times that if you could unroll them they would be longer than the wall itself."

I stood and looked at the layers and thought about the people who had made each one. The person who had chosen the dark geometric paper had been expressing something — a preference, a period, an idea of beauty that had seemed right at the time and had since been covered over. The person who had painted the pale green with the floral border had done the same. Each layer had been the current layer once. Each layer had been what the room was, for someone, at some point.

And now they were all visible simultaneously, which was not how they had been intended to be seen but which was, as Nela had said in the street the day before, truer.

"Why did you want us to see this?" I asked her.

She considered the question carefully, which I appreciated. She did not give the first answer that came, which would have been an answer about history or architecture or the importance of preservation. She gave the considered answer.

"Because people think that covering something over means it's gone," she said. "But it's not gone. It's just underneath. Everything you've ever done to a wall is still in the wall." She paused. "I find that comforting. I think most people would, if they thought about it."

I wrote this down. She watched me, as she had before, with the expression of someone satisfied that a thing is being recorded.

Sam was photographing the layers of wall with the careful attention he brought to things he found genuinely interesting, moving along the exposed edge, choosing his angles, not rushing. I watched him for a moment and thought about the seven years I had known him and how he had always been able to see what deserved looking at without needing it explained to him. It was

one of the most useful qualities a person could have, and one of the rarer ones.

We stayed at the demolished building for an hour. An hour, at a demolition site, on a Saturday morning. I would not have predicted this. I would not have predicted most of the last nine days.

* * *

The makers' market was in a square I had not found on my own, tucked behind the Starý Trh down a street that the Starý Trh's gravity tended to pull you past rather than into. It happened every Saturday, Nela said, and had been happening every Saturday for about six years, ever since a group of people who made things had decided that they wanted somewhere to sell them that was not the internet.

It was smaller than either of the markets we had been to in Drevska or Vrest — perhaps thirty stalls, arranged without particular order in the square, each one different in what it offered and in how it presented itself. There was a woman selling ceramics — plates and bowls and cups with a glaze that had the organic variation of things made by hand rather than the uniform surface of things made by machine, each piece slightly different from the last in colour and texture. There was a man selling woodwork — small objects, mostly, things whose function I could not always determine but whose form was careful and considered in the way of things made slowly. There was a stall of textiles, and a stall of prints, and a stall of something that appeared to be handmade soap but which had, arranged around the soaps, small handwritten cards explaining where each ingredient had come from and why it had been chosen, which was the most thorough accounting I had ever seen for a bar of soap and which I found, despite myself, genuinely interesting.

Nela moved through the market with the ease of someone who knows everyone in it, which she did — stopping at stalls,

exchanging words, picking things up and looking at them and putting them down with the quick, informed assessment of someone who makes things herself and knows what she is looking at. She introduced us, here and there, as "friends from the road," which was a phrase I liked and which seemed to be sufficient explanation in a context where people moved through constantly.

At the ceramics stall, the woman — whose name was Petra, and who had paint under her nails in a different colour from Nela's paint, as though they shared an occupational condition but expressed it differently — held up a small bowl and said something in Moltravian.

"She says this one came out wrong," Nela translated. "The glaze did something unexpected. She almost discarded it."

The bowl was pale, mostly, with a dark streak through the glaze that ran from the rim to the base in an irregular line, like a crack that wasn't a crack — a mark left by something in the firing process that Petra hadn't planned for. It was, I thought, the most interesting piece on the stall.

"Almost?" I said.

Petra smiled and said something else.

"She says she kept it because it was more itself than the ones that came out right," Nela said. "The ones that come out right look the way she intended. This one looks the way it needed to."

I bought the bowl. I carried it for the rest of the trip wrapped in a shirt in the middle of my bag, with the care I bring to things I don't want to lose.

* * *

The rooftop was accessed through a door at the top of a building that Nela had a key to, which she produced from the same jacket pocket as always with the same unsurprised

confidence, and which led up a narrow staircase to a flat roof with a low parapet around the edge and nothing else — no furniture, no structure, just the roof and the sky above it and the city below and the plain beyond.

I have stood on rooftops in various cities and the view from a rooftop is always interesting and sometimes good and occasionally remarkable. The view from this rooftop was something I did not have adequate preparation for.

Dolka sat in its plain, and the plain went in every direction without interruption, and the sky above the plain was the largest sky I have ever stood under. It was not dramatic in the way of mountain skies or coastal skies — there was no vertical element to it, no cliff or peak to give it scale. It was simply enormous in the horizontal way, going outward rather than upward, a sky that had taken all available room and filled it completely. The clouds in it were the large, slow clouds of a plain sky, moving at the pace of things that have a great deal of space to move through and are in no particular hurry.

Below, Dolka went about its Saturday. I could see the Starý Trh from here — tiny, the market stalls like coloured dots, the movement of people through it reduced to something abstract and rather beautiful, the way human activity always looks from sufficient height. I could see Colour Street, or could see where it was — a narrow line through the old city. I could see the river, which I had not found on foot yet, catching the morning light in the distance.

I stood at the parapet and looked at all of it for a long time.

Sam was beside me, doing the same, in the particular silence that large views produce — the silence of being made small in a way that is not diminishing but clarifying. You see yourself correctly from a height. Not less important, but more appropriately sized relative to everything else.

Nela sat on the rooftop with her back against the parapet and her face to the sun, eyes closed, with the ease of someone for whom this rooftop is familiar — who has been here many times and has a specific relationship with this particular patch of sky.

"Do you come here often?" I asked, which is a terrible question in every context except this one, where it was the right question.

"When I need to remember the scale of things," she said, without opening her eyes. "When whatever I'm working on has gotten too close and I can't see it properly anymore. I come up here and everything gets smaller and then when I go back down it's the right size again."

"Does it work?"

"Always." She opened her eyes and looked at the sky. "Everything looks different from up here. Not better or worse — just more true to what it actually is."

* * *

We came down from the rooftop at noon and walked back through the old city in the Saturday crowds, and Nela bought a portion of something from a street stall that she shared between the three of us — fried dough with a dark filling that she said was a Moltravian thing, eaten at markets and on street corners for centuries, unchanged because there was no reason to change it. It was extraordinary. Of course it was.

We ate it standing on a pavement, getting the oil on our fingers, and I thought about how much of the best food on this trip had been eaten standing up, or at tables without tablecloths, or from containers that were not plates, and how this seemed to be a reliable indicator of something — that the best food was the food that was made because someone wanted to eat it, rather than because someone wanted to serve it.

I said this to Nela.

"That's true of most things," she said. "Made because you needed to make it, not because someone asked you to. You can always tell the difference."

She said it lightly, not aiming it at me. But it landed where it was going to land regardless.

* * *

That afternoon, while Sam went back to the ceramics stall — he had been thinking, he said, about the bowl with the irregular glaze and had decided he wanted to talk to Petra about her process, which was very Sam — Nela and I walked.

I want to describe this carefully because it was, in retrospect, one of the more important afternoons of the trip, and important afternoons deserve care.

We walked without a destination along the river, which I had seen from the rooftop and which turned out, at ground level, to be wider and slower than it had looked from above — a river in no particular hurry, going through the city with the unhurried confidence of something that has been here longer than the city and will be here after it. There was a path along the bank, old trees on one side and the water on the other, and it was the kind of path that produces conversation the way some places produce silence — by providing just enough to look at that you don't need to look at each other, which makes honesty easier.

Nela told me about coming to Dolka.

She had not been from here. She had grown up in a city to the north — she named it and I did not catch it, a city she described as "correct and cold and good at the things cities are supposed to be good at" — and she had come to Dolka at twenty-two with the intention of staying for a year. She was thirty now. The year had become two, and then five, and then eight, and at

some point the intention to leave had become an assumption that she had stayed, which was a different thing.

"Was it a decision?" I asked. "Staying?"

"I'm not sure it was conscious," she said. "It was more like — I kept finding things here that I needed. Not things I had looked for. Just things that turned out to be necessary. The street. The people. The light." She looked at the river. "The light is different here. I couldn't paint in the north the same way. The light was too even. It didn't do anything interesting. Here it does something interesting all the time."

"Do you miss the north?"

She considered this in the specific way she considered things — not avoiding it but taking the time to find the accurate answer rather than the easy one. "I miss certain people," she said. "I miss my mother's cooking on Sundays. I miss the winters, sometimes, which were harder but clearer. But I don't miss the version of myself I would have been if I'd stayed." She paused. "Is that a strange thing to say?"

"No," I said. "I think I understand it exactly."

She looked at me. "What did you leave behind to come on this trip?"

It was a direct question and I had not expected it, which meant I answered it more honestly than I might have with preparation.

"A job I'm good at and don't love," I said. "A routine that works perfectly and means nothing. A version of myself that has been very sensible for about three years and is exhausted by it."

Nela nodded, not with sympathy exactly — she was not a sympathy person, I had understood this quickly — but with the recognition of someone who has been somewhere adjacent.

"And what do you want instead?"

We walked a few steps. The river went past. A bird landed on a branch overhanging the water, looked at its reflection for a moment with apparent dissatisfaction, and left.

"To write something," I said. "Something of my own. I don't know what yet. But something that — that has my name on it for the right reason. Not because I corrected it. Because I made it."

It was the first time I had said this out loud to anyone, in those words, with that specific directness. I had said something in the direction of it to Sam in the beige apartment in Vrest, early in the morning over mediocre coffee, but I had not said it this clearly. Saying it clearly felt like stepping off something — not a cliff, nothing so dramatic, but a step down from a kerb into a road, a small commitment to direction.

Nela said nothing for a moment. We walked.

"The writing you've been doing in the notebook," she said finally. "Is that what it is? The beginning of it?"

I thought about the notebooks. The flower man. The old woman and the pigeons. The demolished building and its layers. The woman in the window. The child in the red coat dancing in the square in Vrest.

"I think so," I said. "I'm not certain yet."

"That's the best answer," she said. "Certainty too early is just another way of not looking."

We walked along the river for another half hour, and the conversation moved to other things — to her work, to the street, to a project she was planning for the spring involving the wall of a building that had been empty for years and which the owner had, after considerable negotiation, agreed to let her paint. She described what she wanted to do with it, and as she described it I

could see it, which was the mark of a person who understood not just the visual thing but the words for it.

When we turned back towards the city, the afternoon light was doing the Dolka thing — amber and direct, making the buildings look as though they were generating it rather than receiving it. I walked alongside Nela and felt, with the specific clarity that comes sometimes at the end of afternoons that have gone somewhere unexpected, that I was in the right place at the right time, which is not a feeling I am accustomed to having with any frequency and which I have learned, on this trip, to receive without immediately questioning.

* * *

Sam had, in our absence, had a three-hour conversation with Petra about ceramic glazes, during the course of which he had also apparently helped her pack up at the end of the market, eaten the remains of a lunch she had brought, and been introduced to her husband and her two children who had come to collect her at five. He reported all of this over dinner with the satisfaction of someone who has had a thoroughly good afternoon and is happy to give it its full due.

"The glaze thing is more interesting than I expected," he said.

"How so?"

"She has very little control over the final result. She knows what she's trying to do, she prepares everything as carefully as she can, and then the kiln does what the kiln does and the glaze does what the glaze does and sometimes it comes out right and sometimes it comes out different and sometimes it comes out like your bowl." He looked at me. "She says the ones that come out different are the ones she remembers."

"Nela said something similar about the woman in the window. The partial painting being more interesting than the complete one."

Sam turned his wine glass in his hands. "It's a theme."

"What's a theme?"

"Things that don't go according to plan being more interesting than things that do." He looked at me. "The trip being one of them."

I thought about this. "You planned this trip," I said.

"I planned the framework," Sam said. "Three countries, three weeks, a direction. The actual trip—" he gestured at the square around us, at the evening, at the whole ten days of it— "was nothing like what I planned. Tomáš wasn't planned. The courtyard wasn't planned. Nela wasn't planned."

"The beige apartment was planned."

"The beige apartment was a mistake," he said, with the equanimity of someone acknowledging a mistake without distress. "Everything else was the glaze doing something unexpected."

I sat with this for a moment. Outside, the Starý Trh was filling with its evening self — the lights coming on in the buildings, the guitarist back on the steps, people arranging themselves in the organic way of people who know where they like to be.

"I talked to Nela today," I said. "Properly."

"I know," Sam said.

"You know?"

"You've had the look you have when you've said something you needed to say." He picked up his wine. "Since about five o'clock."

I looked at him. Seven years. He had known me for seven years and had apparently been reading me with more accuracy than I had been aware of.

"I told her I want to write something," I said. "Something of my own."

Sam nodded. Not with surprise. With the expression of someone hearing a thing confirmed that they had known for some time.

"I know that too," he said.

"How long have you known?"

He thought about it. "Since about the second day of the trip," he said. "Since you started writing in the notebook and couldn't stop. Since Drevska." He paused. "Actually, I think I've known longer than that. I think I've known since before we left. I think part of why I suggested the trip was—" he stopped.

"Was what?"

He looked at me with the expression I had come to understand, over seven years, as the expression he had when he was saying something he had thought carefully about. "I could see you getting smaller," he said. "At home. Over the last year or two. Like you were — compressing yourself into something that fit the available space. And I thought that if we went somewhere where the available space was different—" he made a gesture that indicated the square, the city, the whole trip.

I looked at him for a long moment.

"You engineered this," I said.

"I suggested a trip," he said. "You did the rest."

The guitarist in the square began a new song. Nela arrived — she had been home for an hour, she said, and had washed the

paint off her hands, which I noted took something away from the image I had formed of her but which was probably necessary — and sat down with us and ordered wine and looked at the square with the easy proprietorial affection of someone who has watched this square do its evening thing many hundreds of times and still finds it good.

The three of us sat at the table in the Starý Trh and the evening did the thing that good evenings do, which is to become gradually less about anything specific and more about the simple fact of being together in a place at a time that is the right place and the right time. The conversation moved and stopped and moved again. Someone at the next table laughed at something. The guitarist finished his song.

At some point Nela said, looking at the square: "I never get tired of this."

"Of the square?" I asked.

"Of the fact that it's always the same and always different," she said. "Every evening it's this square. Every evening it's new people. Both things are true at the same time. I find that—" she searched for the word— "sustaining."

I wrote it down. She saw me do it and said nothing, which was her way of approving.

Sam watched me write it and said nothing, which was his way of doing the same thing.

* * *

We said goodbye to Nela the next morning, on the street in front of the hotel, in the thin October sun.

She shook Sam's hand and then mine, with the directness that was entirely her own — not a hug, not the elaborate farewell of people performing attachment, but the firm, real handshake of

someone who means the contact. She had brought us, without ceremony, two small prints from her studio — rolled and wrapped in paper, one each. Mine, when I unwrapped it later on the train, was a detail of the woman in the window. Not the whole painting — just the face and the hand on the sill and a suggestion of the geometric pattern at the edge, the covering and the covered existing together in a space about the size of a paperback book. Sam's was the river, done in three colours, abstract but immediately recognisable as the river along which we had walked.

I have them both on my wall at home, as I write this. They are the first things I look at in the morning.

"Come back in spring," she said, which was what Mrs Vachová had said in Drevska, and which I was beginning to understand was not just an invitation but a form of benediction — the acknowledgment that you had been somewhere real enough that it would want you back.

"We will," Sam said.

She looked at me.

"I will," I said. And meant it differently than Sam had meant it — not just the return to a city, but the return to whatever had started in this city, the thing that had been loosened and was still, carefully, finding its shape.

She nodded once, satisfied, and walked back down the street in the direction of Colour Street, where she had work to do.

We watched her go.

"Right," Sam said.

"Right," I said.

We went inside to pack.

—

From the notebook, Dolka, last morning:

Things that don't go according to plan are more interesting than things that do. The glaze doing something unexpected. The partial painting.

The wrong turn that finds the courtyard.

Sam said he could see me getting smaller. I think he was right. I think the trip has been the space to get larger again. I am not sure yet into what.

Chapter Ten

The Day Everything Went Wrong

In Which the Universe Decides That Things Have Been Going Too Well and Takes Corrective Action

I want to say, before I describe what happened, that none of it was Sam's fault.

This is not entirely true. Some of it was Sam's fault. But the distribution of fault across the day was, on reflection, fairly even, and I think it is important to establish at the outset that I am not writing this chapter to assign blame but to give an accurate account of events, which is a distinction I feel strongly about and which Sam, when he reads this, may feel differently about, but that is his prerogative.

The day began well. This is always a bad sign. Days that begin well have a quality of borrowed time about them, a sense that the morning is spending something it doesn't have, and that somewhere further along in the afternoon the bill will arrive.

Felix had given us, over breakfast — the good bread, the plum preserve, the coffee that had been making everything else seem worse by comparison for three days — a handwritten note with directions to the bus station and the number of the bus to Vranov. He had written it in his careful fountain pen hand, on the same hotel notepaper as the map to Colour Street, and it had the authority of everything Felix produced, which was the authority of

someone who is accurate about things because inaccuracy is a form of disrespect.

The note said: Bus 14. Departs 09:15. Platform 3.

We checked out at eight forty-five, said goodbye to Felix, who shook our hands and told us to come back and mean it rather than saying it the way people said it, which I found simultaneously perceptive and slightly unsettling. We walked to the bus station, which was twelve minutes away. We arrived at nine-eleven.

Platform 3 was empty.

This was not, in itself, alarming. Buses sometimes ran a little late. We stood on Platform 3 with our bags and waited with the patience of people who have been on a trip long enough to have acquired a certain equanimity about minor delays.

At nine-eighteen I looked at the departures board.

Bus 14 was listed. Its scheduled departure was 09:15. Its status, in small letters beneath the time, was: DEPARTED.

"Sam," I said.

"I see it," Sam said.

We looked at each other across the space of three minutes and twenty seconds, which was how late we had been, and which was, I want to note, entirely sufficient to miss a bus that had apparently departed with Swiss precision despite operating in a country where, as Ference had warned us, the driving was enthusiastic.

"The next one," I said, with the optimism of a man who has not yet checked.

We checked.

I should explain something about the bus timetable for the Dolka to Vranov route on a Sunday, which is that it is a document of remarkable simplicity, containing, on the Sunday column, exactly one entry.

09:15.

That was it. One bus. One departure. Departed.

There was, in the small print at the bottom of the timetable — and I want to be clear that it was very small print, the kind of small print that exists to technically contain information while practically concealing it — a note that said, in Moltravian, which Sam's app translated with its usual approximate enthusiasm, something along the lines of: "Sunday service limited. Travellers are advised to confirm availability before travel."

"Travellers are advised to confirm availability before travel," I read aloud.

"Yes," Sam said.

"Did we confirm availability before travel?"

"We did not."

"Why did we not confirm availability before travel?"

Sam looked at the timetable with the expression of a man examining evidence that reflects poorly on him and deciding to receive it with dignity. "Because Felix said Bus 14 and I assumed Felix knew about Sundays."

"Felix knew about the bus," I said. "Felix did not know we were going on a Sunday. We did not tell him we were going on a Sunday. This is—" I paused, working through the chain of responsibility with the thoroughness of a man who edits documents for a living and has opinions about clarity— "a communication failure distributed equally between us."

"Yes," Sam said.

"Right," I said.

We stood on the empty platform in the thin Sunday morning of Dolka and considered our position, which was: no bus, no alternative listed, bags in hand, Vranov unreached, the day ahead of us without a plan.

A pigeon landed on the platform, looked at us, found us uninteresting, and left. I found this, given the circumstances, slightly rude.

* * *

The minibus was Sam's idea, which I record not to assign blame — I said I was not doing that — but because it is accurate, and accuracy matters.

He had found, on a noticeboard near the station entrance, a handwritten card advertising shared transport to various destinations in the region, with a phone number. The card was old enough that the edges had curled and the ink had faded slightly, which were not signs that inspired confidence, but the destinations listed included something that began with "Vran—" and was partially obscured by a coffee ring, and Sam felt this was sufficient.

He called the number. A man answered. Sam held the phone out and I listened to a brief exchange that consisted mostly of Sam saying place names in an enquiring tone and the man responding with what appeared to be confirmation, and then Sam saying a number that I assumed was a price and the man agreeing to it, and then Sam hanging up and saying "Sorted."

"Sorted how?" I asked.

"He's coming in twenty minutes. He's going our way."

"Which way is our way?"

"Vranov direction," Sam said, in the tone of a man who has done what he can with the available information.

I looked at him. "Vranov direction," I repeated.

"He said Vran—something. I'm confident."

We waited twenty minutes. A minibus appeared. It was white, or had been white, and had the settled dinginess of a vehicle that spent most of its time on roads that were not entirely kind to it. The driver's window came down and a man leaned out who I can only describe as someone who had decided, at some point in his life, that silence was a resource not to be wasted and had since been making up for lost time.

His name was Oskar.

* * *

Oskar was perhaps fifty, with a grey moustache that he appeared to groom with the same attention he gave to his opinions, which was considerable. He spoke no English. This did not impede him in any meaningful way, because Oskar communicated primarily through tone and volume and the expressive use of one hand while the other remained on the wheel, which I watched with a degree of attention that I maintained for the entire ninety-minute journey.

He spoke, as far as I could determine from Sam's running translation, about the following subjects: the state of the roads in this part of Moltravia, which he found inadequate; the state of roads in general, which he found declining; a specific pothole on a specific stretch of the route which he had reported to the relevant authority seventeen times and which remained unaddressed, a fact that he clearly considered a personal affront; a politician whose name I did not catch but whose policies regarding road maintenance Oskar found catastrophic; his brother-in-law, who

had a van and had once driven from Dolka to the capital in a time that Oskar considered either impressive or suspicious, it was difficult to tell which; and the weather, which he felt had been behaving unreliably.

He delivered all of this with the even, continuous energy of someone who has been storing up observations and has found, at last, an audience. That the audience could not understand him did not appear to concern him. He seemed satisfied by the act of expression itself, regardless of reception, which I found, when I stopped being anxious about the roads, almost philosophically interesting.

"What's he saying now?" I asked Sam at one point, when Oskar's tone had shifted to something that sounded like conclusion.

"I think he's saying we're nearly there."

"Nearly where?"

Sam consulted the app. "Vranka."

There was a pause.

"Vranka," I said.

"Vranka," Sam confirmed.

"Not Vranov."

"Not Vranov."

We looked at each other. Outside, the minibus was pulling into a small town square, stopping with a finality that suggested Oskar considered his obligations discharged. He turned and said something that the app translated as approximately: "Here we are. Very nice town. The pothole on the main road is also not fixed."

He appeared to find this funny. He laughed, a short single sound, and looked at us expectantly.

We got out.

* * *

Vranka was not Vranov.

I want to establish this clearly, because the towns shared enough letters that the mistake was, in a certain light, understandable — the light of a person who had written down what he heard on a phone call made in a language he did not speak, from a handwritten card with a coffee ring obscuring part of the text, regarding a bus that had already departed. In that specific light, the mistake was almost reasonable.

In every other light it was simply a mistake.

Vranka was smaller than Vranov would have been — we established this later, when we had the opportunity to look at a map — and was situated about thirty kilometres in the wrong direction, and had, according to the single guesthouse we found after fifteen minutes of walking in light but persistent rain that had started approximately four minutes after Oskar drove away, no available rooms. The woman at the guesthouse — who was apologetic in the specific way of someone who has genuinely tried to be helpful and found the circumstances uncooperative — explained this at length, in Moltravian, and offered us tea, which we accepted, and which was the best thing that had happened since breakfast.

We sat in the guesthouse kitchen with our bags and our tea and the rain on the window and took stock.

"Right," I said.

Sam said nothing. He was looking at his phone, running through options with the focused calm of someone who has encountered problems before and treats them as logistical rather than existential, which was a quality I found useful at this precise moment.

"There's a bus back to Dolka at four," he said. "And a guesthouse in Vranov with availability if we can get there."

"How do we get there?"

"Taxi, probably. There's a number here." He showed me his phone.

I looked at it. Then I looked at the rain on the window. Then I looked at my bag, which had chosen this moment, as if in solidarity with the general direction of the day, to produce a sound from its main zipper that was identifiable as the sound of a zipper failing. I tested it. The zipper moved approximately two centimetres and stopped, firmly and permanently, in the manner of something that has given notice.

"The zipper's broken," I said.

"I heard."

"Everything is breaking."

"The zipper is breaking," Sam said, with a precision I found, at this specific moment, slightly annoying. "The day is going wrong. Those are two things."

"They feel like part of the same thing."

"That's because you're cold and it's raining and we're in the wrong town," Sam said. "You're reading the zipper in context. Out of context it's just a zipper."

I looked at him. The guesthouse woman refilled our tea without being asked, which was kind.

"I hate it when you're right," I said.

"I know," Sam said. "Drink your tea."

It was while Sam was outside making the call to the taxi company — stepping into the doorway of the guesthouse with his phone and his jacket and the rain coming down with renewed purpose around him — that he lost his phone.

Or rather, he did not lose it exactly. What happened, as far as we could reconstruct afterward, was that he put it in his jacket pocket at the end of the call and the jacket pocket, which had a tendency he had mentioned before and which he had been meaning to address since Stravnik, did not retain things with the reliability one hoped for. The phone slid out at some point in the next ten minutes, during which Sam came back inside, told me the taxi was coming in thirty minutes, accepted more tea, and sat down at the kitchen table.

He reached for his phone to check something.

It was not there.

What followed were the forty-five minutes that I will remember, I think, for the rest of my life — not because they were the most dramatic forty-five minutes I have ever experienced, but because they were a very precise and concentrated version of the feeling of something important being gone, and the specific quality of that feeling, and what it does to two people who are already cold and slightly damp and in the wrong town.

We searched the kitchen. We searched our bags. We retraced Sam's steps to the doorway, which involved standing in the rain examining a patch of wet doorstep with the focused attention of archaeologists, which produced nothing. The guesthouse woman joined the search with admirable commitment, opening doors and checking corners and communicating a level of concern that I found disproportionate to our relationship — we had known her for twenty minutes — and also enormously touching.

Sam was calm. I want to record this because it matters and because I was not especially calm and the contrast was instructive.

He was methodical rather than panicked — going through possibilities in order, backtracking without drama, checking the same places twice because checking the same places twice was what the situation required. He was worried — I could see it, the particular set of his face when something is genuinely wrong — but the worry was contained and directed rather than spreading, the way a good dam contains water rather than letting it go everywhere.

I was less calm. I was performing calm, which is different, with the specific effort of someone who knows that the other person is handling a bad moment well and feels a social obligation not to make it worse by handling it badly themselves. Internally I was cycling through the inventory of things on the phone — the photographs, the contacts, the book Sam had found in the Vrest bookshop of which he'd photographed several pages he wanted to remember — and feeling the loss of each of them in advance of its being confirmed.

I did not say any of this. I helped look.

Thirty-eight minutes in, the guesthouse woman's husband — who had been fetched from somewhere at the back of the house and who was the kind of man who approached problems with a screwdriver regardless of whether they required one — came in from outside holding something up.

It was the phone. It had been in the gutter at the edge of the step, where the rain had been running. It was wet. It had a crack across the lower corner of the screen from the fall. When Sam pressed the button, it turned on.

The screen lit up. Everything was there.

Sam looked at it for a moment. Then he looked at the ceiling. Then he put it in his inside pocket — the interior one, the reliable one — and said, quietly, "Thank you" to the man with the screwdriver, and then said it again in Moltravian from the app, which came out slightly wrong but which the man received with a

nod and what appeared to be genuine satisfaction at having been useful.

I sat down on the kitchen chair and felt the particular exhaustion that comes after forty-five minutes of sustained low-level dread.

"Okay?" I said.

"Yes," Sam said. He sat down across from me. He looked, for the first time on the trip, tired — not physically tired, but the specific tiredness of having held something together under pressure and being able, now that the pressure had passed, to acknowledge the effort.

I thought about what he had said in Dolka. That he could see me getting smaller. That he had suggested the trip because of it. Seven years of friendship and this was the first time I had seen him look tired in the way I recognised as the tiredness of caring about someone.

"Thank you," I said. "For the calm. Earlier. When everything was going wrong."

He looked at me. "You were calm too."

"I was performing calm."

He smiled — the small, genuine one. "I know. I appreciated it anyway."

The taxi arrived outside. We thanked the guesthouse woman, who had by this point provided us with tea on three separate occasions and helped search for a phone belonging to people she had met under an hour ago, and who received our thanks with the modest satisfaction of someone who has done what the situation required and finds the doing of it sufficient reward. Her husband stood in the background with his screwdriver and nodded.

We got in the taxi. The rain continued. The zipper remained broken. The day remained the day it had been.

None of it mattered in the slightest.

* * *

I want to tell you about what happened before the taxi came, in the thirty minutes between Sam finding his phone and us leaving, because this is the part of the day that mattered most and which I have not yet told you.

The guesthouse woman — whose name we had established, through the patient application of the translation app, was Ludmila — had, while we were drinking our third tea and recovering from the phone situation, been doing something at the stove. She had been doing it quietly, with the focused attention of someone cooking rather than performing cooking, and the smell that had been developing in the kitchen for the last half hour had gone from background to foreground in the way of good cooking, which announces itself when it is ready rather than when you are looking for it.

She produced four bowls. One for us each, one for herself, and one for her husband, who appeared from the back at the smell with the reliability of a man who has spent enough years with this woman to know what that particular smell means.

She had made soup.

I want to be careful here, because I have said several things on this trip were extraordinary and I want the word to retain its value. But the soup was extraordinary. It was a clear broth, dark gold, with things in it — vegetables, something that might have been barley, pieces of something I identified as chicken though cooked to a depth that made the word chicken seem insufficient — and it had the quality that the best broths have, which is not complexity exactly but depth, the flavor going down rather than

across, the kind of thing made by someone who understands that patience is an ingredient.

We sat at Ludmila's kitchen table in the wrong town in the rain and ate soup that she had made because it was Sunday and it was cold and there were people in her kitchen who needed something warm, and I found myself, partway through the bowl, in the condition I have come to associate with the best moments of the trip — the condition of being entirely present, entirely here, not thinking about what comes next or what went wrong earlier but simply in this kitchen with this soup with these people.

"This is," I said to Sam, and then stopped because I did not have the end of the sentence.

"Yes," he said. He understood.

Ludmila watched us eat with the expression of someone who has made food for people who needed it and is satisfied by the result. Her husband ate with the focused pleasure of a man who has eaten this soup many times and has not taken it for granted. Outside, the rain kept raining.

When we finished she offered more. We accepted. It would have been wrong not to.

* * *

The taxi to Vranov took forty minutes, through countryside that the rain had made dark and close, the fields reflecting the low grey sky in the puddles that had formed along the road edges. The driver was the opposite of Oskar — silent, focused on the road with the professional attention of someone who considers conversation an optional extra that he has decided not to offer. I found this, after Oskar, deeply restful.

We arrived in Vranov as the afternoon was considering becoming evening. The town was what Nela had said — old and quiet, its main street curving along the river, the buildings on

either side the particular old stone of a place that has been here long enough to have stopped worrying about whether it looks right. It looked right because it had stopped trying to.

The guesthouse had our room. The room was small and warm and contained no beige whatsoever, which I noted with the satisfaction of a man whose previous accommodation had set a bar that even moderate alternatives could clear easily. There was a window with a view of the river, which was doing the evening river thing — catching the last light, moving in its ancient indifferent way, being the same river it had been all day regardless of what had happened on the bank.

I sat on the bed and took my boots off and felt the specific relief of sitting down after a day that had required continuous standing, metaphorically speaking, and thought about the day from the beginning.

The missed bus. Oskar and his potholed opinions. The wrong town. The broken zipper. The lost phone. The forty-five minutes of low-grade dread. The taxi to the right town, thirty kilometres and three hours later than planned.

And between all of it: Ludmila's soup. The guesthouse woman who gave us tea three times and helped look for a phone that belonged to strangers. The husband with the screwdriver who found it in the gutter and handed it back without ceremony. The kitchen table in the wrong town in the rain.

I thought about something Nela had said, in Colour Street on the first morning, about the painting being truer when it was partial — when other things had covered it and only part of it remained. I thought about the demolished building and its layers. I thought about the bowl that came out wrong and was more itself than the ones that came out right.

The day had come out wrong. It had been, by any reasonable measure, a failure of planning and execution that had resulted in arriving somewhere we had not intended to go, several

hours late, in the rain, with a broken zipper and a cracked phone screen.

It was also, unambiguously, the most interesting day of the trip.

I wrote this in the notebook. Then I wrote: the best days are not the ones that go according to plan. The best days are the ones where the plan fails completely and you find out what is actually there.

I sat with that for a while.

Then I went and knocked on Sam's door because I was hungry and the guesthouse owner had mentioned, when we checked in, a restaurant two streets away that did something with trout that she felt we should not leave Vranov without trying, and I had learned, by this point in the trip, to take local restaurant recommendations seriously regardless of the state of the day.

* * *

The trout was, of course, excellent.

Sam had the same. We ate it at a table by the window with the river visible outside, moving through its evening in the dark, and we talked about the day the way you talk about a day when you are safely at the end of it and can see it whole.

"Oskar," Sam said, at one point, shaking his head.

"Oskar," I agreed.

"Seventeen times," Sam said. "Seventeen times he reported that pothole."

"And nothing."

"I feel for him, actually."

"So do I," I said. "Genuinely."

We were quiet for a moment. The river went past the window.

"The soup," Sam said.

"The soup," I agreed.

"Ludmila," Sam said, with a specificity that was its own form of tribute.

"Ludmila," I said. "Who made us soup in the wrong town in the rain because it was Sunday and we were in her kitchen."

Sam turned his wine glass. "This is the thing about people," he said. "The ones you don't plan to meet. The ones that appear because something went wrong. They're always the ones you remember most."

I thought about Tomáš at the mushroom stall. About the man in the courtyard in his plastic chair. About Nela waiting outside the hotel with two coffees and the expression of someone who had already been up for three hours. About Ludmila refilling the tea without being asked.

"You engineered this trip," I said. "But you didn't engineer any of the people."

"No," Sam said. "You can't engineer the people. The people are what happens when you show up and pay attention."

I wrote this down on the paper tablecloth, as I had in Vrest, because I did not have the notebook to hand. The waiter saw me doing it and brought me a pen without being asked, which was either very perceptive or standard practice in Vranov restaurants, and either way was exactly right.

* * *

We walked back to the guesthouse along the river path in the dark, the water invisible but present beside us, the sound of it

constant and unremarkable in the way of things that are simply there. The rain had stopped. The sky had cleared enough to show stars — not the enormous Moltravian sky of Dolka, not that scale, but a small rectangle of stars between the rooftops, sufficient.

"Tomorrow is the market," Sam said. "The Sunday market Nela mentioned. Except it's not Sunday anymore."

"We'll stay an extra day," I said.

Sam looked at me. "We have a train from Dolka on Thursday."

"I know." I looked at the water, invisible in the dark. "We'll work it out."

"That's not something you usually say."

"No," I said. "I know."

We walked the rest of the way in the easy silence of two people who have had a difficult day together and are, at the end of it, still glad of each other's company. Which is, I have come to think, one of the better tests of a friendship — not whether you enjoy the good days together, which is easy, but whether you can have the difficult ones and arrive at the other end intact.

We were intact. The zipper was still broken. The phone screen was still cracked. None of it mattered at all.

—

From the notebook, Vranov, night of the wrong town:

Missed the bus. Wrong town. Broken zipper. Lost phone. Best day of the trip.

*The people are what happens when you show up and pay attention.
Sam said this. I am writing it down so I don't talk myself out of it when
I get home.*

Chapter Eleven

The Monday Market

In Which We Stay an Extra Day for a Market That Turns Out Not to Be on Sunday and Discover That the Extra Day Was the Whole Point

The market in Vranov was on Mondays.

I want to dwell on this for a moment, not because it is complicated but because it is the kind of detail that illuminates something about the nature of the trip and about us as travellers and about the relationship between planning and reality that I have been circling around since Chapter One and which I feel I am now, finally, in a position to address directly.

Nela had said, in Dolka, that the market in Vranov was the best market in the region and that it happened on Sundays. This was accurate in the sense that it happened every week and that the day she had in mind was the first day of the week, which in Moltravia, as we established over breakfast with the guesthouse owner — a woman named Berta who had the broad, comfortable presence of someone who has run a guesthouse for twenty years and has encountered every variety of confused visitor and arrived at a position of complete equanimity about all of them — began on Monday.

"In Moltravia," Berta explained, with the patient clarity of someone explaining something that should not need explaining but clearly does, "the week begins on Monday. The market is the first day of the week. Therefore the market is on Monday."

"Nela said Sunday," I said.

"In Moltravia," Berta said again, gently, "Sunday is the last day."

There was a pause while Sam and I processed this information and its implications for our understanding of when we had arrived and when the market was and whether our extra day had been, in fact, fortuitously timed rather than the result of having arrived a day late due to a series of errors beginning with a missed bus and a man named Oskar.

"So the market," Sam said carefully, "is today."

"Today," Berta confirmed. "It begins at eight. It is now—" she looked at the clock on the wall, which was shaped like a sunflower and had the specific cheerfulness of clocks in kitchens that are used every day by people who like mornings— "seven forty-two."

We finished our breakfast in the focused manner of people who have somewhere to be.

* * *

The market in Vranov happened in the main square, which was smaller than the Starý Trh in Dolka and considerably smaller than the market square in Vrest, but which had, by virtue of its scale and its purpose, a quality that those larger markets did not quite have. It was not a market for tourists or even for the city. It was a market for the town and the farms around it — the weekly transaction between the people who grew things and the people who ate them, conducted in the same square, in roughly the same

way, for longer than anyone currently present could personally remember.

There were perhaps twenty-five stalls. Vegetables first — the late October vegetables, which are the serious vegetables, the ones that have been in the ground through the whole season and have developed opinions: cabbages of impressive density, root vegetables in varieties and colours I had not fully considered before, onions in plaited ropes, leeks, and something I could not identify that was purple and shaped like an elongated turnip and which the woman selling it indicated, when I pointed at it enquiringly, was excellent in soup. I bought two.

There was bread — a different bread from every other bread on the trip, darker and denser, made in large round loaves that were sold by the half or the whole with the practicality of something made to last rather than to be eaten in one sitting. There was cheese — a hard yellow one and a soft white one and something wrapped in cloth that smelled of caves and age and serious intention. There was a man selling mushrooms, which seemed to be a feature of every market in this part of the world, and whose mushrooms were different from the mushrooms of Drevska and different again from anything I had seen in Vrest, as though each region had its own specific relationship with fungi, which I suppose it did.

There was, at the far end of the square, the man selling tools from the back of a van. He had the van's rear doors open and the tools arranged on a folding table in front of it with the slightly aggressive orderliness of someone who takes the presentation of tools seriously. He was doing reasonable business from a demographic that was entirely agricultural and entirely male, and he regarded the two of us when we wandered past with the expression of a man calculating the probability that we would buy anything and arriving at a figure close to zero. He was correct. We did not buy tools. We looked at them in the way of people who find

tools interesting as objects while having no practical application for them, which he appeared to find mildly baffling.

"What would you even do with a sickle?" Sam said.

"Nothing," I said. "That's not the point."

"What is the point?"

I looked at the sickle, which was old and had a handle worn smooth with use and a blade that still had an edge, and thought about the hands that had held it and the fields it had worked and the distance between that life and mine, which was very large and which I felt, at this specific moment, with a clarity that was both obvious and new.

"It's just interesting," I said. "That it exists. That someone made it and someone used it and here it is."

Sam looked at the sickle. "Fair enough," he said.

* * *

The honey woman was at the corner of the market, at a stall that had perhaps thirty jars arranged on a table covered with a cloth the colour of old gold, and she was, I want to say, a force of nature in the specific and quiet way that certain people are forces of nature — not through volume or drama but through the completeness of their conviction.

She was perhaps seventy, small and upright, with white hair and the particular sharp focus of someone who has spent decades paying close attention to one thing and has developed, through that attention, an expertise that goes beyond knowledge into something more like instinct. She knew her honey. She knew it the way Tomáš knew Drevska — not as information but as understanding, the kind that lives in the hands and the nose and the accumulated experience of years.

She assessed us when we arrived at her stall with the unhurried thoroughness of someone who is not going to be rushed into anything, looked at each of us for a moment in turn, and then turned to her jars and selected two, which she placed on the table in front of us.

"She says these ones," Sam's app reported, from the brief thing she had said.

"Those are the ones for us?" I asked.

Sam relayed this. She replied at some length.

"She says the dark one is for you," Sam said, pointing at a jar that was the colour of dark amber, almost brown, with a thickness that was visible even through the glass. "She says you look like you need something with depth. The lighter one is for me. She says I seem like someone who already knows what he wants and just needs something clear."

I looked at her. She looked back at me with the expression of someone who has made an accurate observation and is waiting for it to be acknowledged.

"How does she know that?" I asked.

Sam relayed this. She said something short.

"She says she's been watching people at this market for forty years," Sam said. "She says people tell you everything if you pay attention."

I bought the dark honey. I opened it that evening in the guesthouse room, spread it on a piece of the dense bread, and sat by the window eating it in the last of the day's light. It had a depth that I had not expected — not sweet in the simple way of honey from a supermarket jar, but complex and slightly dark, with something underneath the sweetness that I could not name but which felt accurate. Like something that had been made slowly, from serious flowers, by bees that knew what they were doing.

The honey woman had been right. I did need something with depth. I was beginning to accept that this was a recurring theme.

* * *

The old man with the notebooks was at a small table near the church, set slightly apart from the rest of the market in the way of someone who is present but not particularly concerned with commerce.

The notebooks were handmade. This was visible immediately — not in the way of things marketed as handmade, with the word on a label and the slightly elevated price, but in the actual fact of the making, which was present in the objects themselves. The covers were thick paper, different colours, each one slightly different from the last. The pages inside were cream, handcut, with the slight irregularity at the edges of paper that has been trimmed by hand rather than machine. They were sewn together — I could see the stitching along the spine, neat and consistent, the thread a dark red. Each one was unique in the way of things made one at a time by someone who is making rather than producing.

The man behind the table was perhaps eighty, with large, careful hands that had the quality of Nela's hands — the quality of hands that make things, that are used to precision and patience. He was watching the market with the mild interest of someone who has seen it many times and still finds it worth watching.

I picked up one of the notebooks. It was small — about the size of a paperback, the cover a deep green — and it had a weight to it that was its own kind of satisfaction, the weight of good paper and solid binding, the weight of a thing made to last.

I looked at the man. He looked at me.

"How long does it take?" I asked, miming the making of it — hands sewing, pages turning — in the uncertain sign language of someone trying to communicate across a language barrier and hoping that enthusiasm will compensate for accuracy.

He understood. He held up both hands, fingers spread. Ten.

"Ten hours?" I asked.

He nodded. Then held up a finger. One.

"One notebook. Ten hours."

He nodded again. He seemed neither proud nor apologetic about this. It was simply how long it took to do it properly, and doing it properly was the point, and the point required no defence.

I bought the green one and a second one — blue, slightly larger — without the usual internal negotiation I conduct about unnecessary purchases. They were not unnecessary. They were exactly necessary, in the way that things are necessary when they are made with care and you are in a condition to recognise care when you see it.

He wrapped them in brown paper, tied with string, with the unhurried attention of someone for whom the wrapping is part of the thing. I carried them for the rest of the morning with the specific care of someone carrying something that matters.

* * *

The conversation with the farmer happened at the vegetable stalls, in the way that the best conversations on this trip had happened — unplanned, from proximity, because someone was in the same place at the same time and neither of them had anywhere more important to be.

He was perhaps fifty-five, broad and weathered in the way of people who work outside in all conditions and have made their peace with this, with hands that made the honey woman's look delicate by comparison. He was examining a neighbouring stall's cabbages with the professional interest of a man who grows cabbages and has opinions about other people's. He glanced at my two purple turnip-things and said something.

I held up the app.

He looked at it, then at me, with the expression of someone encountering a translation app for the first time and deciding to give it a chance. He repeated what he had said, slowly.

"Good choice," the app said. "Those are kohlrabi. Very good for soups. You grow your own?"

"No," I said into the app. "I live in a city. I don't have a garden."

He received this with the app's translation, nodded, and said something else.

"That is sad," the app reported. "Everyone should have something growing."

I looked at the kohlrabi in my hand. "I edit books," I said, which was not a direct response to what he had said but which felt relevant. "I work with things other people have grown, in a way."

The app translated. He thought about this, with the serious consideration he appeared to give everything, and then responded.

"The app says—" Sam, who had appeared beside me, was reading over my shoulder— "he says that's not the same. He says when you grow something yourself you know it from the beginning. You know what the soil was like and what the weather was and how much water it got. You know everything it went through to become what it is. He says when you know that, you respect it differently."

I stood in the market in Vranov on a Monday morning holding a kohlrabi and thought about this.

The farmer was looking at me with the patient expression of someone who has said a true thing and is giving it time to settle.

"He's right," I said, not into the app. Just to Sam.

"I know," Sam said.

The farmer seemed to understand this exchange without translation. He nodded once, with the satisfaction of someone whose point has been received, and turned back to the neighbouring cabbage stall, which still required his assessment.

I bought four more kohlrabi that I had no practical means of transporting or cooking, and carried them in a paper bag for the rest of the morning because it seemed wrong to put them back.

* * *

Vranov in the afternoon was the quietest place I had been on the entire trip.

After the market closed — which happened gradually, the stalls packing up with the unhurried efficiency of people who have done this every week for years and have a system — the square emptied back into itself, the cobblestones returned to their usual state of being simply there, and the town resumed the quiet that was, I was understanding, its natural condition. Not the quiet of a place that had nothing going on. The quiet of a place that had what it needed and was not looking for more.

Sam took his book to the small garden at the back of the guesthouse, where there was a wooden bench in a patch of afternoon sun that had the specific quality of October sun — low, warm, more valuable for being brief — and settled into it with the complete ease of a man who has found his bench and intends to use it. Berta brought him tea without being asked. He thanked her.

He opened his book. He became, in the way he had of becoming, entirely somewhere else.

I sat at the table in our shared sitting room with the green notebook in front of me.

I sat with it for quite a long time before I opened it.

I am going to try to describe what it felt like to open it, because I think it is worth trying to describe, and because it is the kind of thing that gets talked around rather than talked about, which is a habit I am trying to break.

It felt like standing at the edge of something. Not a cliff — nothing so dramatic. More like standing at the edge of a garden in the early morning, before you have gone in, when the possibility of the garden is still whole and undisturbed and contains everything it might contain. The moment before you step in and it becomes specific rather than possible.

I had been carrying things in notebooks for eleven days. The flower man's hands. The woman in the window. The demolished building and its layers. Ludmila's soup. The honey woman's assessment. All of it in the small notebook I had brought from home, the one designated for "important observations," which had turned out to mean everything.

The green notebook was different. It was not for observations. I did not yet know what it was for. I only knew that it was blank, and that blank felt like the right condition for what was trying to happen, and that I had been carrying something for two years that needed somewhere to go and that the somewhere might be here.

I opened it.

I wrote the date at the top of the first page. Then the town. Then I sat for a while longer.

Then I wrote the first sentence of something that was not a journal entry and not a note. It was not about Vranov. It was not about the trip. It was about a morning, before I left, standing at the window of my apartment watching the city go about its business without me. The last morning of the routine. The morning before the last sensible morning.

I wrote for two hours. The afternoon light moved across the table. Berta came in once, saw what was happening, and left again without a sound, which I appreciated. Outside, the town went about its Monday. The river went about its river.

When I stopped, I did not stop because I had finished — I stopped because two hours was enough for the first day and I had learned, from watching Nela work, that you had to leave something for tomorrow or the well ran dry. I closed the notebook. I put the pen down. I looked at what I had written, which was the beginning of something I could not yet name but which had the specific weight of the real.

I sat with it for a moment.

Then I went outside and found Sam on his bench and sat beside him in the last of the afternoon sun and said nothing, and he said nothing, and the sun did its low October thing across the garden, and this was entirely sufficient.

* * *

We ate dinner that evening at a place Berta recommended — she had the same quality as Mrs Vachová and Tomáš and Felix of recommending places with the authority of someone who would be personally embarrassed if the recommendation proved wrong — which was on the main street, small and warm and run by a man who cooked and his daughter who served and who between them produced an evening that I find, looking back, difficult to improve upon.

There was a soup to start — not Ludmila's soup, nothing would be Ludmila's soup, but its own soup, clear and deep with something that might have been the serious root vegetables of the market, made by someone who understood that soup was not a preliminary but a statement. There was a main course involving slow-cooked pork and something from the cabbage family and an accompaniment that I could not identify but which was nutty and dense and exactly right. There was bread throughout, the dense round bread of Vranov, which I ate more of than was probably advisable and which I did not regret.

We talked about the day. About the market, and the honey woman, and the old man with his ten hours per notebook and his complete absence of apology about it. About the farmer and his kohlrabi and the thing he had said about knowing something from the beginning.

"I wrote today," I said. "In the green notebook."

Sam looked at me across the table. "What did you write?"

"The beginning of something. I don't know what yet."

"Does it matter what?"

I thought about Nela's painting and the layers over it. The bowl that came out wrong. The demolished building and its exposed history. The glaze doing something unexpected. Things that didn't go according to plan and became more themselves for it.

"No," I said. "I don't think it does. Not yet."

Sam nodded. He picked up his wine. "The farmer was right, you know," he said. "About knowing something from the beginning. About knowing what it went through."

"I know," I said.

"Whatever you're writing — you'll know everything it went through," he said. "The whole trip. All of it."

I looked at him. This was, from Sam, a long speech. He meant it entirely.

"Yes," I said. "I suppose I will."

We finished dinner slowly, in the way you finish dinner when there is nowhere else to be and no reason to hurry, which is the best way to finish dinner. The man's daughter brought us something small and sweet with the coffee — a pastry of some kind, local, specific, the kind of thing you don't find on a menu because it doesn't need to be on a menu, it simply appears. We ate it. It was perfect. Of course it was.

* * *

We left Vranov the next morning on the bus that went to Dolka, which ran on Tuesdays at nine-thirty and which we confirmed in advance, in writing, with Berta, who wrote the time and the platform number on a piece of paper and made us each read it back to her, which I found simultaneously slightly infantilising and entirely correct given our track record.

The bus was on time. The driver was not Oskar. Nobody on the bus ate a hot meal. It was, by the standards of our recent travel, almost disappointingly uneventful, which was fine. After the day of the wrong town we had earned a bus that simply went where it said it was going.

I sat with the green notebook in my bag and the kohlrabi — I had carried them all the way, because putting them down felt wrong — in a paper bag at my feet, and watched Vranov disappear behind us through the window.

It had been two days. One night planned, one night extra. The market we had been told was on Sunday was on Monday. We had arrived in the wrong town, eaten the best soup of the trip, and

found, in a small guesthouse garden in the October sun, a bench where something I had been carrying for two years finally found somewhere to go.

Two days.

I thought about what Tomáš had said in Drevska, in his cellar café, with his canvas bag of potatoes and his cabbage. About knowing one thing properly. About the difference between going everywhere and knowing nothing and staying in one place long enough to know it truly.

I thought that you could apply this not just to places but to time — that two days in a place you were paying attention to was worth more than two weeks in a place you were moving through. That the quality of presence mattered more than the quantity of it. That the extra day in Vranov, arrived at by missing a bus and getting on a minibus going the wrong way and ending up in a different town entirely, had been the most important day of the trip so far.

I wrote all of this in the small notebook — the original one, the observations one — not because I had worked it out and wanted to record the conclusion, but because writing it was how I was working it out, which was, I was coming to understand, the whole point of the notebook. Not to record what I knew. To discover it.

Outside, the Moltravian countryside went past in the morning light, and the sky was doing its enormous thing above it, and I watched it all go and felt, with a clarity that I intended to keep, that I was not the same person who had stood in a bedroom in a crooked apartment building three weeks ago with a half-packed bag and a list that had grown to four pages and a feeling of having committed to something before he had thought it all the way through.

I put the notebook down and looked out at the enormous Moltravian sky and thought about the flight home, which was on Friday. It was Tuesday. We had four days.

Four days.

I turned to Sam, who was reading — he was always reading — and said: "We have four days."

"Until the flight," Sam said, not looking up.

"Until the flight," I said. "Which is Friday. It is Tuesday."

He looked up. He looked at me with the expression of someone who has been thinking the same thing and was waiting to see if the other person would say it first.

"You want to stay," he said.

"I want to not go back yet," I said, which was slightly different and more accurate.

Sam closed his book. He looked out the window at the enormous sky above the fields. "I've been wanting to go into the mountains," he said. "The ones north of Dolka. I looked at them on the map in Vranov. There's a trail. Three days if you go slowly."

"I'd slow you down," I said. I am not a mountain person. I am a city person who has, through the course of this trip, become a small-town person, but I am not yet a mountain person and I am not certain I want to be.

"I know," Sam said, without any particular edge. Just a fact.

"I want to go back to Dolka," I said. "Alone. Two more days. I want to see what it's like without — without someone else."

Sam looked at me with the expression he had when something confirmed something he had already thought. "Yes," he said simply.

"We meet back at Felix's on Thursday night," I said. "Flight's at ten Friday morning."

"Thursday night," Sam said.

We looked at each other across the bus seat. Three weeks of travelling together — of navigating and eating and getting lost and finding things and losing phones and eating soup in wrong towns. Three weeks of being, in some essential way, a unit. And now, for three days, something different.

"Is this strange?" I asked.

Sam considered it genuinely. "A little," he said. "Good strange."

"Good strange," I agreed.

The bus pulled into Dolka at half past twelve. We collected our bags. At the station entrance we stopped. Sam had a map on his phone — the mountain trail, the northern route. I had the city, which I knew well enough now to navigate without one.

We shook hands, which felt both slightly formal and entirely right.

"Thursday," Sam said.

"Thursday," I said. "Don't fall off anything."

"Don't talk yourself out of anything," he said.

He turned and walked towards the northern bus platforms. I watched him go — the familiar backpack, the easy walk of someone who knows where he is going — and then I turned in the other direction, into the city, alone for the first time in three weeks. It felt like stepping into a room where the furniture had been slightly rearranged. The same room. New arrangement. Worth investigating.

—

From the notebook, on the bus from Vranov:

*Sam has gone to the mountains. I have gone back to the city. Thursday
we meet at Felix's. Four days left.*

I am trying not to think of this as running out.

Chapter Twelve

Going Solo

In Which I Discover That Travelling Alone Is a Completely Different Kind of Travelling and That I Am, Against All Expectation, Adequate at It

I want to be honest about the first two hours of being alone in Dolka, because honesty requires me to admit that they were not the liberating, self-discovering, quietly triumphant hours I had imagined when I suggested the arrangement on the bus.

They were, instead, the hours of a man who had been travelling with another person for three weeks and had forgotten, in a way that was more complete than he had expected, what it felt like to be entirely responsible for his own next decision.

I stood on the pavement outside Dolka station with my bag and the kohlrabi — still carrying the kohlrabi, I had committed to the kohlrabi — and looked at the city, which looked back at me with the cheerful indifference of a city that has no particular opinion about whether you have a plan.

I did not have a plan.

At home, not having a plan was a condition I found mildly distressing. On the trip, not having a plan had been fine because Sam was there and Sam always had a direction, even when the direction was wrong, and a direction — even a wrong one — is

better than the open, possibility-filled blankness of no direction at all. Possibility, I had always known intellectually, was a good thing. Faced with it on a Tuesday afternoon on a pavement in Dolka with the kohlrabi, I found it approximately forty percent more vertiginous than advertised.

I considered my options.

I could go to the Hotel Three Lights and check in early. I could go to Colour Street. I could find the café where Tomáš's equivalent might exist in Dolka — the serious coffee, the regulars, the man behind the counter who would eventually learn my order. I could walk. I could find a bench. I could eat something, because it was half past twelve and I had not had lunch, and being hungry in a foreign city alone is a different and more complicated experience than being hungry in a foreign city with someone else.

I decided on lunch first, on the grounds that most decisions improve when made from a position of adequate blood sugar, which is a rule I have always known and consistently failed to apply.

I found a place three streets from the station. I sat down. I ordered something by pointing at what the person at the next table was eating, which was a method I had refined over three weeks into something approaching an art form. What arrived was a bowl of something involving noodles and a broth that was lighter than the broths I had been eating, cleaner, with fresh herbs on top and a piece of something that I identified as fish after the first mouthful.

I ate it alone, at a table by the window, watching the street outside.

And somewhere between the first mouthful and the last, something settled. The vertiginousness went down. The city outside the window was simply the city — going about its Tuesday, doing what cities do, entirely unconcerned with the state of my blood sugar or my plan or the fact that I was alone. And I was in it,

at a table, with a bowl of noodles, and this was, when I stopped adding the anxiety to it, perfectly fine.

More than fine, actually.

I ordered a coffee. I took out the observations notebook. I began to write. The waitress did not look at me with the expression of a woman feeling sorry for a man eating alone, which I had been half-anticipating. She looked at me with the expression of a woman who has tables to manage and whose attention is distributed accordingly and who finds a man writing in a notebook at a table entirely unremarkable. I found this, unexpectedly, enormously freeing.

* * *

The thing about travelling alone that no one tells you — or rather, that people tell you and you do not fully believe until you experience it — is that it is not lonelier than travelling with someone. It is differently populated.

When you travel with another person, your attention divides. Some of it goes to the place, and some of it goes to the person — to the conversation, to the shared navigation, to the small negotiations of two people moving through the world together. This is not a complaint. The divided attention produces things the undivided attention cannot: the joke that only works because Sam is there to appreciate it, the moment in the square in Vrest when a child in a red coat took his hand, the four-hour conversation with Tomáš that required both of us to be in the room. These things are specific to the company.

But alone, the attention goes entirely to the place. Nothing mediates between you and it. Every person you see, you see unfiltered. Every sound arrives directly. Every smell is yours alone to place and name. The city becomes more itself, somehow, because there is nothing between you and it — no one to say "look at that" before you have had the chance to look.

I discovered this on the walk from the noodle place to the Hotel Three Lights, which took forty minutes because I went a long way around and stopped several times. I stopped at a doorway where someone had left a row of potted plants on the step — four of them, geraniums, the last flowers of autumn, determined and slightly defiant in the October cold. I stopped at a corner where two streets met at an angle that framed, at the end of one of them, a view of the cathedral that I had not seen from this direction before — closer, more abrupt, the stone filling the gap between the buildings like something that had been there before the buildings and would be there after them. I stopped at a wall where a cat was sitting in a patch of thin sunlight with the specific commitment to warmth that cats bring to thin sunlight, getting the maximum available value from it with complete unselfconsciousness.

At none of these stops did I say anything to anyone. There was no one to say anything to. I simply stopped and looked and then moved on, and the looking was complete in itself in a way that looking-with-commentary is not always complete.

I wrote the geraniums in the notebook. I wrote the cat. I wrote the cathedral framed at the end of the street. None of them were remarkable, individually. Collectively they were the texture of being somewhere, alone, paying attention without an audience.

* * *

Felix received me with the same warm, unsurprised attention as before.

"Sam is in the mountains," I said.

"I know," Felix said. "He called ahead." He produced my key. "Same room. You have it until Friday morning."

"Thank you," I said. "For — all of it. The dinner. Irena." I paused. "The recommendation to Colour Street. All of it."

Felix looked at me with the slightly sideways attention he used when he was actually looking at something. "You seem different again," he said.

"Different from what?"

"From when you arrived with Sam. You were — complete, together. Now you're—" he considered— "more singular."

"Is that good?"

Felix tilted his head. "Singular is not better or worse than complete," he said. "It's different. Both are useful. You're learning which is which."

He handed me the key and returned to his ledger. I took the stairs.

In the room, I unpacked properly for the first time since Drevska — not the partial, I'll-need-this-again-in-the-morning unpacking of someone moving through, but the full unpacking of someone staying. Clothes in the wardrobe. Both notebooks on the desk. Nela's print leaned against the wall, which was as close to hanging it as I could manage without tools. The kohlrabi on the windowsill, where they sat in a row looking purple and slightly bewildered, as well they might.

I stood in the room that was mine, alone, for three days.

"Right," I said.

The room said nothing. The kohlrabi said nothing. The city outside the window went on being the city.

I sat at the desk and opened the green notebook and wrote for an hour.

* * *

The first full day alone I spent, mostly, in the way I had come to spend days on this trip that did not have a plan — walking, stopping, noticing, eating things I could not fully identify, writing about it afterward.

I went back to the makers' market square, which was empty on a Wednesday but which had the quality of a place that has recently been full and retains something of it — a residual warmth, the arrangement of the cobblestones still bearing the faint suggestion of where the stalls had been. I sat on a step and wrote for a while and then walked on.

I went to the cathedral, which I had seen twice from outside and not yet entered. Inside it was cooler than the morning air and smelled of the universal church smell — candle wax and stone and time — and was larger than it appeared from outside, which is a thing cathedrals do, expanding when you are inside them as though the stone has arranged itself to produce a different set of proportions. There were a few people — a woman lighting a candle, an old man in a pew who appeared to be asleep, which I found both irreverent and deeply relatable. I sat for a while. I thought about Tomáš's church in Drevska, the one that listed to the left, and the young man sitting in the pew having an important interior conversation.

I had fewer important interior conversations than I'd expected. Mostly I just sat and let the cathedral be large around me and found this sufficient.

I found the serious coffee café without Nela to take me there, which felt like an achievement. It required three wrong turns and one consultation of the observations notebook, where I had written the street name on the first day. The man behind the counter was different from the man who had been there before — younger, quicker, with the energy of someone who has not yet arrived at the serenity of the other one but is making the coffee with the same thoroughness regardless. He made me a coffee that was, if not identical to the coffee I had drunk before, in the same

family — the same serious, dark-roasted, opinionated family. I drank it at the same table Sam and I had used and wrote in the notebook and felt, very specifically, the difference between alone and lonely, which I had been conflating without knowing it for most of my adult life.

Alone is the condition of being by oneself. Lonely is the condition of wanting company you don't have. I was alone. I was not particularly lonely. The coffee was good, the notebook was filling, the city was outside the window doing its city things, and I was, for the first time in longer than I could accurately identify, simply present in a moment without wanting it to be a different moment.

I wrote this down. It took up half a page. It seemed worth the space.

* * *

The second day alone I did the thing I had been meaning to do since Nela first mentioned it and had not yet done, which was to go to the river properly — not the walk along the bank that Nela and I had done, not the view from the rooftop, but the river itself, at the old bridge on the eastern side of the city where, Nela had said in passing, the river was at its widest and the view along it was worth the walk.

The walk took twenty-five minutes from the hotel, through streets that became progressively less tourist and more residential — the shift that happens in all cities when you go far enough from the centre, the gradual transition from places performing their identity to places simply living it. The buildings became plainer. The shops became the shops of people who lived nearby rather than people who were passing through. There was a school, closed for the day, its playground empty. There was a small park with three benches and a fountain that was off for the season, and a man throwing bread to ducks with the considered generosity of

someone who has been doing this long enough to know the best distribution method.

The bridge was old — older than it looked, which was the trick of old bridges, presenting a face of permanence that concealed the repair and replacement of centuries. It was stone, wide enough for two lanes of traffic that had long since been rerouted elsewhere, leaving it for pedestrians and cyclists and the occasional dog walker who came from the residential streets with the unhurried purpose of someone on a familiar route.

The view along the river was everything Nela had said.

It went in both directions — upstream to the left, where the river narrowed between older buildings, and downstream to the right, where it widened into the plain beyond the city and the sky took over completely. In the October light, the water had the colour of old pewter, moving with the unhurried certainty of water that has been moving in this direction for longer than the city that has grown up beside it and will continue moving in this direction after the city is gone, which is not a morbid thought so much as a calibrating one.

I leaned on the parapet and looked at the river for a long time.

I thought about Irena playing the cello. About the thing the music had done to the room — the specific quality of attention it had produced, the way it had made everyone in it more present to themselves. I thought about the feeling I had when I was writing in the green notebook — the similar quality of it, the similar effect of becoming more present through making something. I had never thought of writing as like music before, but standing on the bridge looking at the river I thought that maybe the similarity was in what they asked of you — the full attention, the self that had to be entirely there to make the thing rather than only partly there, the way that being only partly there produced something you could tell was only partly there.

I had been only partly there, I thought, for a long time. Not dramatically — not in a way that was obvious, not in a way that anyone who didn't know me well would necessarily notice. But the notebook had been empty for two years. The seat in the chair at the desk had been occupied by someone who edited other people's words rather than finding his own. The difference between that and the green notebook filling up, page by page, in Vranov and Dolka, was the difference between a room with the lights off and the same room with them on. Same room. Different condition.

A cyclist went past behind me. The ducks from the park upstream appeared, working their way downriver with the alert, purposeful manner of ducks who know where they are going. The river went on being the river.

I took out the observations notebook and wrote: *The river does not wonder whether it is going the right way. It simply goes.*

Then I looked at this for a moment and wrote underneath: *I am trying to learn this.*

Then I put the notebook away and stood on the bridge for a while longer, not writing anything, just being there, which was, I was finding, its own form of practice.

* * *

Nela found me that afternoon, which I had not expected, in the courtyard café near Colour Street where I had gone for the serious coffee's afternoon equivalent — a tea this time, because the serious coffee twice in one day seemed like too much of a good thing, which is a restraint I do not always manage but which felt correct on this particular afternoon.

She came in with paint on her hands, as before, and saw me at the corner table and came over with the unsurprised directness of someone for whom the city is small enough that running into people is simply what happens.

"Sam is in the mountains," I said.

"I know," she said. "Felix told me." She sat down. She ordered tea without looking at the menu, which was the mark of a regular. "How is it?"

"Being alone?"

"Being alone here."

I thought about the geraniums on the step and the cat in the thin sunlight and the cathedral and the river and the notebooks filling up. "Good," I said. "Better than I expected. I keep finding things."

"That's what happens when you're not looking for them," Nela said. "When you're with someone, you're partly watching the other person. Alone, you're only watching the city."

"That's what I've been thinking," I said.

"It's obvious," she said, without any particular edge. Just a fact. Nela had this quality — of saying true things directly, not to instruct, simply because they were true and silence would be less useful.

We drank our tea. She told me about the wall — the big painting she was planning, the building on the edge of the old city whose owner had finally agreed. She had been sketching it for weeks, she said, trying to find what it wanted to be, which was how she always described the early stage — not what she wanted to paint but what the wall wanted. Every wall had something it was suited to, she believed, the way every piece of paper had a certain kind of writing that fit it best and others that didn't quite.

"What does this one want?" I asked.

She looked at her tea. "Something about time," she said. "About things that go on. The wall has been there a long time. It's seen — everything. Several centuries of everything. I want to paint

something that acknowledges that. That says the wall knows things that the people walking past it don't."

"Like the demolished building," I said. "The layers."

"Yes," she said. "Except not demolished. Still standing. Still witnessing."

We sat with this for a moment.

"I've been writing," I said. "Properly. In the green notebook."

She looked at me with the expression she had when she was deciding how much to say. "About what?"

"All of it," I said. "The trip. The people. The places. What it did." I paused. "What I didn't know it was doing while it was doing it."

"Is it good?"

I thought about this honestly. "Some of it is," I said. "Some of it is still finding out what it is. Which you told me was the best kind."

She smiled — the real one, not the polite one. "I did say that."

"You were right."

"I usually am," she said, entirely without arrogance, just as another fact, and picked up her tea.

* * *

The second evening alone I did something I had not done on the whole trip, which was to eat dinner at the hotel.

Felix, it turned out, produced a small dinner service for guests on certain evenings — not advertised, not a restaurant,

simply a thing he did when he had made something worth sharing. He mentioned it when I came through the lobby at seven, in the way he mentioned things, as a statement that was also an offer.

"I've made something," he said. "If you want."

"What is it?"

"Chicken," he said. "With things."

"What things?"

He considered this. "Good things," he said. "Come at half past seven."

The dining room was a table in the room behind the lobby that I had not previously seen, with four chairs and a window onto the courtyard and a single lamp that produced exactly the right amount of light, which is the amount that makes a room feel inhabited rather than illuminated. There were two other guests — a couple from somewhere I couldn't place, who spoke to each other in a language I didn't recognise and to me in English, and who had the settled ease of people who have been travelling together for a long time and have developed a shared language for it that goes beyond words.

The woman's name was Anya. The man's name was Piotr. They were, it emerged over the chicken with things — which was extraordinary, the things being preserved lemons and herbs and something that tasted of smoke and depth — photographers, both of them, who had been travelling through this part of the world for six weeks documenting something they described as "ordinary light." Not extraordinary light — not sunsets or storms or the dramatic qualities that photographs usually seek. Ordinary light. The light on a kitchen table at nine in the morning. The light through an office window at three in the afternoon. The light in a hallway when someone has just switched it on.

"Why ordinary light?" I asked.

Anya looked at me with the expression of someone who has been asked this question and finds the asking of it the most interesting part. "Because no one pays attention to it," she said. "Everyone photographs the extraordinary. The ordinary light is what people actually live in. It's what life actually looks like. We think it deserves the same attention."

I thought about the corner of my street in April. The light on the building I had walked past hundreds of times and never seen.

"I think I understand that exactly," I said.

Piotr smiled — he smiled less than Anya but when he did it was more complete. "Most people don't, immediately," he said. "You must have been paying attention to something."

"I've had good teachers," I said.

Felix, bringing the dessert, which was a small, perfect thing involving pastry and something dark and sweet, heard this and said nothing, but there was a quality to his silence that suggested he was pleased.

We sat at the table until ten. Anya and Piotr told me about the places they had been and the light they had found there. I told them about Drevska and Tomáš and the courtyard and the demolished building and the river and what the trip had done. Felix refilled the wine once and then left us to it, in the way of a good host who knows when his work is done.

At the door of the dining room, saying goodnight, Anya said: "Write it. All of it. Don't wait until you know what it is."

"I've been told that before," I said.

"Good advice tends to repeat itself," she said. "Until you're ready to hear it."

Thursday morning arrived with the particular quality of last mornings — the awareness of finality giving everything a slight extra clarity, the way things look when you know you are about to stop seeing them. I woke early, as I always did now, and lay for a while listening to Dolka doing its early morning things, and then I got dressed and went out for the last time alone.

I walked to Colour Street first, in the early morning dark that was becoming early morning light, and stood in front of the woman in the window for the last time as a solo visitor. I had been here three times now — with Sam the first evening, alone in the dark before dawn, and now. Each time she had been slightly different, which was not the painting changing but me changing, and the change between us producing a different conversation.

This morning she looked patient, as she had before. The hand on the sill. The waiting. But there was something else I had not seen before — or had not been in a condition to see before — which was that the expression on the partial face that remained, the face not yet covered by the geometric pattern, was not waiting for something external. It was the expression of someone waiting for themselves. The patience directed inward.

I had been doing that. For two years, in the apartment with the cold coffee cups and the manuscripts that belonged to other people, I had been waiting for myself — for the version of myself that would sit down and write, that would open the notebook and mean it, that would stop editing other people's truths and find his own. The waiting had been so quiet I had not known it was happening. It had taken a missed bus and a wrong town and Ludmila's soup and Nela's street and a demolished building and a woman at a honey stall who gave me the dark one because I needed something with depth to show me what I had been waiting for.

I said goodbye to the woman in the window quietly, internally, in the way of things that cannot hear you but which you

address anyway because the addressing is for yourself rather than for them.

Then I walked back through the waking city to the Hotel Three Lights, where Felix had left bread and the plum preserve and the serious coffee on a tray outside my door, which was a thing I had not asked for and which was, as everything Felix did, exactly right.

I ate breakfast at the desk with the notebooks in front of me and Nela's print on the wall and the kohlrabi on the windowsill turning slowly, I hoped, not into a problem. I wrote for an hour. I packed my bag.

At two in the afternoon, Sam arrived.

He came through the door of the hotel with the look of someone who has been in the mountains for three days and is returning to civilisation with mixed feelings — slightly windswept, slightly tired, with the specific quality of someone who has been in large open spaces and is readjusting to walls and ceilings. He had the camera bag over one shoulder and the backpack on the other and an expression that was hard to read from a distance.

I was in the armchair in the lobby, reading, which was something I had not done on the whole trip — just sat and read, the way Sam was always reading, without any purpose beyond the reading. I looked up when he came in.

We looked at each other across the lobby.

"Well?" I said.

"Mountains," he said. It was a complete sentence.

"Good mountains?"

"Very good mountains." He sat down in the other armchair with the considered relief of someone who has earned a chair. "You?"

"City," I said. "Good city."

"Find anything?"

I thought about the geraniums and the cat and the river and Nela in the café and Anya and Piotr and the ordinary light and the woman in the window's expression that I had finally, on the last morning, understood.

"Yes," I said. "Quite a lot."

Sam nodded with the expression of someone who expected nothing less and is satisfied to have been right.

Felix appeared from behind the desk with two coffees that he had, apparently, been preparing in anticipation of this moment, which was either extraordinary perception or simply Felix knowing his guests well enough to know what they would need when they sat down.

"Welcome back," he said, setting the coffees down. "Both of you."

He returned to his desk. Sam picked up his coffee. I picked up mine. We sat in the armchairs of the Hotel Three Lights on a Thursday afternoon in October and drank the serious coffee in the comfortable silence of two people who have been apart for three days and are glad, without needing to say it, to be in the same room again.

—

From the observations notebook, Dolka, solo days:

Alone is the condition of being by oneself. Lonely is the condition of wanting company you don't have. I have been alone for three days. I have not been lonely.

Sam is back. The coffee is serious. This seems right.

Chapter Thirteen

Lost in Translation

In Which Language Proves to Be Only One of the Things We Cannot Understand About Each Other, and Also the Least Important One

I want to tell you about the shop first, because it establishes certain things about how the evening went.

It was a small shop on a street behind the river — the kind of shop that exists in old cities as a last practical outpost of a neighbourhood that has not yet been entirely colonised by the things that colonise old city neighbourhoods: the wine bars, the boutiques, the places that sell expensive candles. It sold bread and tins and things in packets and a small selection of fresh vegetables arranged in a crate outside the door with the practical, unpretentious confidence of a shop that knows what it is and sees no reason to apologise for it.

I wanted vinegar.

I want to explain why I wanted vinegar, because in isolation it seems like a strange thing to want at seven o'clock on a Thursday evening in Moltravia. The kohlrabi were still on the windowsill of my hotel room and had begun, over the three days since Vranov, to develop the slightly reproachful quality of vegetables that have not been eaten. I had looked up a recipe on

my phone — a quick pickle, the kind you can make in a jar with vinegar and salt and sugar and whatever herbs are available — and felt that the kohlrabi deserved at least this much. I required vinegar.

"I'll wait here," Sam said, indicating a bench outside the shop with the expression of a man who has watched me attempt to buy things in foreign languages before and has made a risk assessment.

"It's just vinegar," I said.

"I know," Sam said. "I'll be here."

I went in. The shop was run by a woman of perhaps sixty with the efficient, slightly distracted energy of someone managing several things at once, of which I was one and not the most important. She looked up when I came in. I smiled. She nodded. This was, so far, going well.

I looked around the shop for vinegar. I could not see vinegar. In a supermarket this would have been a navigation problem with a logical solution. In this shop, which had perhaps six shelves arranged in a logic that made complete sense to the woman behind the counter and no sense to me whatsoever, it was something else.

I approached the counter.

"Vinegar?" I said, because sometimes the direct approach works.

The woman looked at me.

"Vinegar," I said again, with a slightly different emphasis, in the way I had noted was entirely useless and which I did anyway.

She said something in Moltravian. I produced the translation app. She looked at it with the expression of someone

being presented with a piece of technology that she finds neither impressive nor objectionable — simply a fact about the present day.

I typed "vinegar" into the app. The app produced the Moltravian word, which I will not attempt to reproduce here because I cannot spell it and attempting to would not convey the experience of hearing it, which was of a word that sounded entirely unlike any version of "vinegar" I had ever encountered in any language.

The woman listened to the app. She nodded. She went to a shelf I had not looked at, because it was behind the counter and I had not thought to look there, and produced a bottle.

The bottle was not vinegar.

I could tell it was not vinegar because it was opaque and dark and had a label featuring what appeared to be a fruit, and because when she opened it briefly to indicate its nature it smelled of something sharp and fermented that was related to vinegar in the way that a cousin is related to you — same family, very different person.

I looked at the bottle. I looked at the app. I typed "this is not vinegar" into the app, which produced a Moltravian sentence that the woman received, read, and then looked at me with an expression that was not offense but was something very close to the look a person gives you when they believe they are correct and are giving you the opportunity to reconsider.

She pointed at the bottle. She said something emphatic.

"The app says—" Sam had appeared in the doorway— "that she's saying this is better than vinegar."

"She said that?"

"More or less. It's a traditional fermented something. She says people who use regular vinegar don't know what they're missing."

I looked at the woman. She looked at me with the patient conviction of someone who has spent sixty years being right about food and is not going to start being wrong about it now for the benefit of a foreign visitor who wants regular vinegar.

I bought the bottle.

The kohlrabi pickle I made the following morning was, I must report, extraordinary. Whatever the traditional fermented something was, it was better than vinegar. She had been entirely correct. I did not know what I had been missing.

* * *

The neighbourhood behind the river had the quality that certain parts of old cities have when they have not been discovered yet — not undiscovered in the sense of untouched, because people had been living here for centuries, but undiscovered in the tourist sense, which meant that it was simply itself without any of the self-consciousness that neighbourhoods develop when they become aware of being looked at.

The streets were narrow — too narrow for cars, which meant that the narrow streets had retained the quality of narrow streets, which is the quality of places built for people walking rather than people driving, which produces a completely different relationship between the person and the place. You were in the street, not on it. The buildings were close enough that the upper floors on either side nearly touched, and the space between them admitted a strip of sky that was more intimate than the open sky of squares and riverbanks — a personal allocation of sky, yours as you walked beneath it.

There were window boxes on several buildings — October had stripped most of them, but a few held the last determined flowers, and one had herbs, still green, that smelled when we passed of something warm and culinary. There were cats, because there are always cats in neighbourhoods like this — three of them in evidence over the course of the walk, each occupying a different elevated position and regarding us with the standard feline assessment of mild contempt overlaid on mild curiosity that is the default setting of the species in the presence of strangers.

"This is what Nela meant," Sam said. "About paying attention. This neighbourhood has been here the whole time."

"We didn't have the map to it," I said.

"We didn't need the map," he said. "We just needed to walk past the edge of where we'd already been and keep going."

This was true. The neighbourhood was perhaps eight minutes from the Hotel Three Lights. Eight minutes from Felix's desk and the serious coffee and Colour Street. Eight minutes from everywhere we had been, sitting quietly and being itself, entirely available to anyone who walked far enough in the right direction.

I wrote it down. Not the neighbourhood specifically — I wrote: *The best things are usually eight minutes past the edge of where you've already been.*

* * *

Karel was on the bench at the end of a small square where two of the narrow streets met and widened briefly into something that was not quite a square and not quite a widening but was clearly used as both — there were three benches arranged in the way of benches that have been there long enough to have established a relationship with their surroundings, and a tree, and a lamp post, and Karel.

He was perhaps eighty. It is difficult to be precise about the age of people who have spent their lives outdoors in all conditions, because the outdoors ages the face in ways that make the usual calculations unreliable. He had a face that had been weathered into something distinguished — not handsome exactly, but specific, with the quality of faces that have experienced a great deal and processed most of it. He was wearing a jacket that had been a good jacket once and was now a comfortable one, and he had a canvas bag at his feet and a walking stick leaning against the bench beside him, and he was doing nothing — not reading, not looking at a phone, not watching anything in particular. Simply sitting in the square at seven in the evening with the settled patience of someone who is waiting for something and has decided that patience is a more useful response to waiting than impatience, which is a conclusion that seems obvious and which very few people actually manage.

He looked at us when we stopped at the edge of the square — not with the usual assessment that strangers in old neighbourhoods get, which is a look that contains both curiosity and a slight territorial awareness. He looked at us with simple interest, the interest of someone who finds people interesting and has not grown out of it.

He said something.

I produced the app. He looked at it with the same neutral acceptance as the woman in the shop, as though technology was simply a thing that existed and he had no particular feelings about it either way.

"What did he say?" Sam asked.

I held up the app's response. "He said: you look lost."

"Are we lost?" Sam said.

I looked around the square. I had no idea where we were relative to the hotel, or to the river, or to anywhere else we had been. "Possibly," I said.

Sam sat down on the bench next to Karel with the ease of someone for whom sitting on a bench next to a stranger requires no particular adjustment. Karel looked at him with the same simple interest. I sat on the other side.

We attempted, over the next forty-five minutes, to have a conversation.

I want to describe this carefully because it was more successful than it had any right to be and less successful than it felt, which is a paradox worth examining.

The translation app worked in principle and intermittently in practice. Moltravian, it turned out, had regional variations, and Karel's Moltravian — he was from a village three hours to the east, in the hills, and had apparently been speaking a version of the language that owed as much to the hills as to the standard form — gave the app occasional difficulties. The app would produce a translation and Karel would listen to it and then say something that suggested the translation had caught most of what he'd said but had missed something essential, the way a photograph catches most of a face but misses the expression.

We persisted.

Through a combination of the app, gestures, expressions, and the specific kind of patience that comes from genuinely wanting to understand rather than simply wanting the conversation to be over, we established the following: Karel was from a village called Horní Dolina, three hours east by bus. He had come to Dolka to see a doctor — a specialist, the kind of specialist that villages of Horní Dolina's size did not have. The appointment had been that morning. He was waiting for the bus home, which left at eight the following morning. He was spending the night at his daughter's apartment, which was on the other side of this

neighbourhood. He had lived in Dolka until he was thirty, which was fifty years ago, and the neighbourhood behind the river was the one he had grown up in, and he came here whenever he was in the city and sat on this bench because it was the bench where he had sat with his father, who had also sat on it with his father, and so it was, he indicated with a gesture that encompassed the bench and the square and the tree and the lamppost and something beyond all of them, a place that mattered.

He said the last part in Moltravian that the app translated as: "When I sit here I am also sitting with people who are not here."

I wrote this in the notebook immediately, which Karel watched with an expression of mild curiosity.

"He wants to know what you're writing," Sam said, reading the app.

"Tell him I'm writing what he said," I said. "That it was good."

Sam relayed this. Karel looked at the notebook and then at me and said something.

"He says his father said it first," Sam said. "He's just been repeating it."

* * *

Karel produced his phone at some point — an old smartphone of the kind that has survived several years of use by someone who is not particularly concerned with updates, its screen slightly cracked at one corner, its case a practical rubber one in dark blue. He held it up to show us photographs.

His wife. She had died, the app told us with the flatness that translation apps bring to things that deserve more — four years ago, after fifty-one years of marriage, of an illness that the app

translated as something I could not entirely parse but which had clearly been long and difficult. The photograph was taken on what appeared to be a summer day, in a garden, and she was looking at the camera with the expression of someone who has been asked to stop what they were doing and look at the camera and has complied, good-naturedly, but would like to get back to what they were doing. She had the same quality of face as Karel — specific, weathered, particular. You could see fifty-one years of shared life in the way they had both arrived at similar expressions through different means.

His children: a son in the city, a daughter here in Dolka, another daughter in another country — the app said "a long way" and then a country name I did not recognise. His grandchildren: seven of them, photographed individually and collectively in various combinations, in various states of being the ages that children are, the photographs taken with the particular combination of pride and slightly unpracticed technology that characterises grandparent photography everywhere.

His house in Horní Dolina — a farmhouse, stone, with a garden that had the productive abundance of a garden that is also a kitchen, full of vegetables and fruit trees and things in rows that were clearly organised with purpose. He pointed at the garden with the same pride as the grandchildren, which told you something about what mattered.

"Beautiful," Sam said, looking at the house photograph, which required no translation.

Karel understood this anyway. He smiled — a complete, unguarded smile, the smile of someone who has been asked about something he loves. He said something.

"He says it needs a new roof," Sam said, reading the app. "He says it has been needing a new roof for ten years. He says he keeps meaning to get to it."

I looked at Karel. He was still smiling, but differently now — the smile of someone who knows that the roof is a joke he tells himself, that the roof is probably not going to get fixed, that this is one of the small unresolved things that a life accumulates and that you eventually make your peace with.

"Tell him I have a drawer like that," I said. "Full of things I've been meaning to get to."

Sam relayed this. Karel listened to the translation and then looked at me and said something.

"He says a drawer is easier than a roof," Sam said. "He says you should fix the drawer."

He said it kindly, without any particular weight. Just as a fact. And yet it landed in the way that facts land when they are accurate — with the slight impact of recognition.

I wrote it down. Karel watched me do it and nodded once, with the expression of a man whose observation has been received, which satisfied him.

* * *

The bus stop lights came on at eight-fifteen, which was apparently Karel's signal, because he looked at them and then at his watch and then began, with the methodical care of someone who has learned to ration his movements, to gather himself to stand.

Sam and I stood immediately. Karel looked at us with the slight surprise of people who are not accustomed to having their standing assisted, and then accepted it in the way of people who have been around long enough to know that accepting help gracefully is its own form of dignity.

He was standing. He picked up his canvas bag. He picked up his walking stick. He looked at us for a moment.

Then he held out his hand.

He shook Sam's hand first, with the formal deliberateness of someone for whom a handshake is a considered gesture rather than a social reflex — looking at him directly, holding the shake for a moment longer than is usual, the way handshakes were conducted before they became perfunctory. Then he shook mine.

His hand was large and rough and very warm, the hand of someone who has worked with it for eighty years and it has served him well and he knows it. It held mine with a firmness that was not a demonstration of strength but of presence — the grip of someone who is entirely there, entirely in the handshake, not thinking about the next thing.

He said something. The app, which Sam was holding, translated it as: "Safe travels, friends. I hope you find what you are looking for."

Then he turned and walked slowly across the square in the direction of his daughter's apartment, with the walking stick and the canvas bag and the particular careful gait of someone managing a body that requires more attention than it used to.

We watched him go.

When he turned the corner of the narrow street and disappeared, Sam and I stood in the square without saying anything for a moment. The lamp post had come on. The tree made its small sounds in the evening breeze. The three benches sat in their established relationship with the square and the lamppost and each other.

"Right," Sam said, eventually.

"Yes," I said.

We walked back through the neighbourhood in the dark, which took longer than expected because we were going by feel

rather than direction, and felt longer still because neither of us was in any particular hurry to be somewhere else.

* * *

Dinner was at a restaurant that Felix had recommended — not his usual precise, fountain-pen-on-notepaper recommendation, but the more casual one of someone mentioning a place in passing, which I have come to trust more than the formal recommendation because the formal one is made with the awareness of being helpful and the casual one is made without thinking about it, which means it comes from somewhere deeper.

"Zdenka's," he had said, that morning, when I asked about dinner for two. "On the street behind the old post office. Don't order from the top of the menu. The top of the menu is for people who don't know yet."

We found Zdenka's — which was indeed behind what appeared to be a post office building that had been converted into something else, though the sign still had a postal horn on it, which I found appealing — and were greeted by a woman who was either Zdenka or someone who worked for Zdenka and had absorbed Zdenka's manner, which was brisk and warm in the combination that the best restaurant people achieve, where you feel simultaneously hurried and entirely welcome.

We were given menus. I looked at the top of the menu, remembered Felix's instruction, and looked at the bottom of the menu instead. The bottom of the menu was in smaller print, without the photographs that the top had, and was either the daily specials or the things that had always been there and didn't need explaining to the people who ordered them.

I chose something that the app translated as "braised something with slow something and the thing from the valley." This was either a translation problem or a deliberately impressionistic menu description. I decided to go with it.

Sam chose something the app translated more helpfully as "fish, local, with the sauce." He asked what sauce. The waitress said something. The app said: "The good sauce."

"That's not a description," I said.

"It's a recommendation," Sam said, and ordered it.

What arrived at my place was not, I want to be clear, what I had been imagining when I ordered. I had been imagining something hearty and dark, a braise in the tradition of the stew in Vrest or the duck in Drevska. What arrived was lighter — a portion of something that turned out to be a kind of game bird I did not recognise, prepared in a way that was delicate and considered, with a sauce that was the colour of autumn leaves and had in it the taste of something wild and something sweet simultaneously. Alongside it was something from a valley — presumably the valley mentioned in the menu — which was a grain of some kind, cooked to a texture that was neither rice nor barley but somewhere between them, with a nuttiness that was its own thing.

It was not what I had ordered, in the sense that what I had ordered bore almost no relationship to what had arrived.

It was extraordinary.

"This is not what I ordered," I said.

"Is it good?" Sam asked.

I ate another mouthful. The sauce had a depth that suggested someone had spent a considerable amount of time on it. The grain had the quality of something made with attention. The bird — whatever it was — had been treated with the kind of care that produces a result where the ingredient and the cooking are in complete agreement.

"It's possibly the best thing I've eaten on the trip," I said, which was a significant claim given the competition.

"Better than the duck?" Sam said, with the expression of someone who considers this a serious question.

I ate a third mouthful and considered honestly.

"Different category," I said finally. "The duck was perfect. This is—" I looked at the plate— "this is unexpected. Which might be better than perfect."

Sam tasted his fish with the good sauce, which was also excellent, and we ate in the comfortable silence of people eating food that deserves attention and are giving it the attention it deserves.

At some point during the main course I said: "Karel."

"Karel," Sam agreed.

"When I sit here I am also sitting with people who are not here."

"His father said it first," Sam said.

"And his father before that, probably," I said. "How many generations of people have sat on that bench?"

Sam turned his wine glass. "Enough that it means something to sit on it," he said. "Enough that Karel comes back every time he's in the city."

I thought about the courtyard in Drevska. The key passed from hand to hand by people who trusted each other, the chain of it going back further than anyone could remember. The wall in Colour Street, layer upon layer, each person adding to what the person before had left. The demolished building and its history compressed into a few centimetres of wall.

"Everything we've seen on this trip has been about that," I said. "About things that continue. Things that go on past the people who started them."

"The river," Sam said.

"The river," I agreed. "The bench. The courtyard. The painting over the painting over the painting."

"The notebook," Sam said, looking at me.

I looked back at him. "The notebook," I said.

The thing I was writing. The thing that had been growing in the green notebook since Vranov, from the first page written in Berta's sitting room. The thing that was forty-three pages now — forty-three pages of something that had started as a trip and become something else, something that would go on past the trip, past the return to the apartment and the crooked building and the ordinary Tuesday mornings. Something that would continue.

"I'm going to finish it," I said. Not as a resolution exactly. Just as a fact that had arrived at its final form.

"I know," Sam said.

"You always know," I said.

"Someone has to," he said, and picked up his wine.

* * *

We walked home through the old city — back through the neighbourhood behind the river, past the bench where Karel had been and was not now, past the square with its lamp post and its tree and its established arrangement of things that had been in this relationship for a long time and would continue to be, and then through the main streets of the old city, past the Starý Trh which was at its late-evening self, quieter now but still inhabited, and past the cathedral which was doing the lit-from-below thing, and then down the street to the Hotel Three Lights.

Felix was at the desk, because Felix was always at the desk, with his ledger and his pen, conducting the evening

administration of the hotel in the steady, unhurried way that suggested the administration was a pleasure rather than a duty.

He looked up when we came in.

"Good evening?" he said.

"Very," Sam said.

"We met a man named Karel," I said. "On a bench in the neighbourhood behind the river. He was from Horní Dolina."

Felix looked up properly. "Old man? Walking stick?"

"Yes."

Felix nodded slowly. "He comes every year or two," he said. "For the specialist. He always sits on that bench." He paused. "His father used to come. Same bench."

I looked at him. "You knew him?"

"I know the bench," Felix said. "And the kind of person who sits on it." He returned to his ledger. "Sleep well. Tomorrow is the festival."

He said this as though it were something we knew about, which we did not, and as though it were something to look forward to, which — given Felix's track record on recommendations — it almost certainly was.

"What festival?" I asked.

Felix looked up with the smile of someone who has been waiting for this question.

"Come down at nine," he said. "You'll see."

From the observations notebook, Dolka, Thursday evening:

Karel said: when I sit here I am also sitting with people who are not here. His father said it first.

*The wrong dish was the best thing I have eaten. This is a theme.
Tomorrow is apparently a festival. Felix said to come down at nine. On
current evidence, this will be worth it.*

Chapter Fourteen

The Night We Almost Went Home

In Which Three Weeks of Travel Accumulates Into One Honest Conversation and We Are Both, Eventually, Better For It

I want to be straightforward about the cold, because there is a temptation, in writing about a cold you had in a foreign city, to either dramatise it into something more cinematic than it was or to minimise it into a brief inconvenience. Neither would be accurate.

It was a cold. A real one, with all the usual features — the specific heaviness behind the eyes, the throat that had developed opinions about swallowing, the nose that had unilaterally declared independence from the rest of the face and was now pursuing its own agenda. It had arrived, as colds always arrive, without warning and without any particular respect for the timing, in the way that colds are entirely inconsiderate about timing, which is one of their less endearing qualities.

I noticed it properly when I woke on Friday morning — not the vague awareness of something coming, which I had felt the night before and dismissed as tiredness, but the full, frank, undeniable announcement of a cold that had arrived in the night and intended to stay.

I lay in the room at the Hotel Three Lights and looked at the ceiling and took stock.

It was Friday. The flight was at ten the following morning. There was a festival in the Starý Trh, which Felix had told us to come down for at nine, and which was apparently worth coming down for. Outside, I could already hear something — music, distant but real, beginning.

I was, by any honest measure, not well.

The question was what to do about this, which resolved itself into two options: stay in bed and miss the last full day, or get up and go and manage the cold alongside the day, which was not ideal but was the option that left the hotel.

I got up. I showered, which helped less than showers usually help. I dressed, which took slightly longer than usual because the cold had introduced a general reluctance to make decisions, including the decision of which jumper. I took two of the antacids — not because the cold required antacids, they were simply the only medication I had packed, which said something about my preparation — and went downstairs.

Felix looked at me when I came through the lobby.

"You look ill," he said.

"I have a cold," I said.

"Yes," Felix said. "I can see that." He paused. "Are you going out?"

"The festival," I said.

He looked at me with the specific expression of a man assessing whether what he is seeing is determination or stubbornness and arriving at the conclusion that the two are, in this case, indistinguishable. Then he disappeared behind the desk and returned with a small glass of something dark.

"Drink this," he said.

"What is it?"

"Something Irena makes," he said. "For exactly this."

I drank it. It tasted of something sharp and something sweet and something herbal and underneath all of it something that was probably the traditional fermented something from the shop, which appeared to be a staple of Moltravian home remedies. It did not cure the cold. It did, however, produce a warmth that spread from the throat outward and made the cold feel, temporarily, more manageable.

"Thank you," I said.

"Come back if you need more," Felix said. "The festival is good. But the bed is also good."

This was, I felt, the most balanced piece of advice I had received in three weeks.

* * *

The festival had been happening since early morning, apparently, in the way of festivals in cities that take them seriously — not the kind that materialises at noon when the infrastructure arrives, but the kind that begins when the city decides it begins, which was when the first musicians arrived in the Starý Trh at some point before dawn and the city responded by getting up.

By nine, when Sam and I came out of the hotel together — Sam fully well, carrying his camera with the alert energy of someone who has been in the mountains for three days and has come back with resources to spend — the square was already extraordinary.

It was not extraordinary in the way of the big city festivals I had been to at home, which are extraordinary in the way of things

that have been designed to be extraordinary — stages and lighting rigs and branded banners and the managed, corporate version of festivity. This was extraordinary in the older way, the way of things that happen because they always happen, because this is what this city does on this day and has done for longer than anyone currently present can personally verify.

There were musicians everywhere — not on one stage but distributed through the square, small groups of them in different corners and along the edges, each playing something different, the sounds overlapping at the centre of the square into something that should have been chaos and was instead a kind of layered music that you moved through rather than listened to from one position. There were stalls — food, drink, things being made and sold by people who made things. There were people in what appeared to be traditional dress, though traditional in Moltravia had a specific quality — less the museum version of tradition and more the living version, the kind that has been adapted and worn and adapted again until it fits the people actually wearing it.

There were children everywhere. This is the mark of a genuine festival rather than a performed one — the genuine ones have children in them, running and being lifted and dancing in the way children dance when they have not yet learned that dancing requires a reason or a particular skill.

I stood at the edge of all of this and tried to feel it.

This is the problem with being ill in the presence of something beautiful. The something beautiful is still beautiful — it does not diminish because you are not well. The sun was doing its October thing on the pale stone of the buildings, the music was layered and alive, the children were running. All of this was happening, fully, correctly, exactly as it should have been.

The gap was in me. The cold had installed itself between the world and my ability to receive it, a slight but persistent distance that made everything feel as though I were watching it through

glass rather than being in it. Not glass exactly — more like gauze, something thin enough to see through but enough to change the texture of what was seen.

I stood at the edge of the festival for an hour and tried to be there and managed only to be adjacent to it, which is not the same thing and which I found, after an hour, more exhausting than I had expected.

"Are you all right?" Sam asked, at some point during the second hour.

"I'm fine," I said, which had become the least accurate sentence in my vocabulary.

Sam looked at me with seven years of practice at reading me accurately. "You're not fine," he said. "You're ill and you're pushing through it and it's not working."

I looked at the festival. The music was particularly good at this moment — one of the groups had started something with a rhythm that seemed to physically reorganise the air around it, and several dozen people were dancing, including two elderly men who had the unselfconscious ease of people for whom dancing has never required justification.

"I don't want to miss it," I said.

"You're already missing it," Sam said, gently. "You're here but you're not here. Go back to the hotel. Sleep for a few hours. Come back at four when the light is good."

I looked at him. This was, I knew, the correct advice. It was also the advice of someone who would stay and experience the festival properly while I went back and did not, which was a small and entirely unreasonable thing to feel, and which I felt anyway.

"Come with me," I said, which was not what I had planned to say.

Sam looked at me for a moment. Then he capped his camera lens. "All right," he said.

"You don't have to—"

"I know," he said. "Come on."

We walked back to the hotel through the streets that were still full of festival — the sound following us, diminishing as we went, until we were in the quiet of the street that held the Hotel Three Lights and the festival was a murmur two streets away.

I had not asked him to come. He had come anyway. This is, I have come to think, one of the definitions of a friend — not someone who comes when you ask but someone who knows when to come without being asked.

* * *

We sat in Sam's room, which was better than mine for sitting in because of the chair — the armchair by the window that he had identified on the first day as the chair you read an entire book in without noticing the time. I sat in it. He sat on the bed. Outside the window, the October light was doing the Dolka thing on the rooftops.

I had a cup of tea — Felix had produced it without being asked, appearing at the door of Sam's room eight minutes after we came in with a tray and the expression of a man who sees everything and responds to what is needed — and I held it in both hands and felt the warmth of it and looked at the rooftops and did not speak for a while.

Sam did not speak either. He sat on the bed and waited, in the specific Sam way of waiting — not impatiently, not performing patience, simply being there, available, in no hurry for whatever was going to happen next. I had spent three weeks noticing this quality in him and being grateful for it. I had not told him this.

"I want to tell you something," I said. "The whole of it. Not the version I told Nela."

Sam looked at me. "Okay," he said.

I looked at the rooftops. I drank some tea.

And then I told him.

* * *

What I told him was this. I am going to try to reproduce it accurately, or as accurately as memory and honesty allow, because I think it matters and because the notebook — the observations notebook, which I had open on my knee — contains the version I wrote immediately after, which is the closest to the original.

I told him about the job — not the facts of it, which he knew, but the interior experience of it. The way it had felt, in the first year, like the right thing. I was good at it. I made other people's books better. I found problems in manuscripts that the authors had not seen and I fixed them with the particular satisfaction of a thing done correctly. There was real pleasure in it. I was not lying to myself about that.

But somewhere in the second year something had shifted. I had started to feel, in a way I could not initially name and could not tell anyone because I did not have the language for it yet, that the editing was not enough. Not that it was wrong — that it was incomplete. Like doing one part of a job and leaving the other part undone. The authors whose manuscripts I edited were doing both parts. They were finding the thing and making it. I was only making it, and only after someone else had found it, and this distinction — which had seemed unimportant in the first year — had become, by the third year, the central fact of my working life.

I told him about the evenings at the desk where the notebook was empty. Not because nothing was happening — things were happening, the job, the life, the ordinary ongoing

business of being a person — but because nothing I was doing was producing the need to write it down. The notebook records the things that feel significant enough to record, and if nothing feels significant enough to record, the notebook stays empty, and after a while the empty notebook is its own kind of evidence.

I told him about the specific morning, eight months ago, when I had sat at the desk with a manuscript I was editing — a travel book, as it happened, by someone who had spent six months driving through a continent and had written about it with a directness and energy that made the reading of it feel like movement — and I had found myself, midway through a paragraph about a city I had never been to, with my pen down and my hands in my lap and a feeling that I could not immediately identify and which turned out, when I identified it, to be grief. Not grief for a person. Grief for a version of myself that I had set aside at some point without properly deciding to, the way you set something on a shelf meaning to come back to it and somehow never do.

I had not told anyone this. Not my colleagues, not my friends, not Nela — I had told Nela the shape of it, the outline, the version that was true but not complete. I had not told Sam.

I told Sam.

He listened in the way he listened to things that mattered — with the whole of his attention, not the performed attention of someone waiting to respond, but the real attention of someone receiving. When I finished he was quiet for a moment.

Then he said: "Eight months ago."

"Around then."

"That's when you started cancelling things," he said. "Plans. Weekends. You started saying you were busy when you weren't."

I looked at him. "You noticed."

"Of course I noticed," he said, without reproach. Simply as a fact.

"I didn't know how to explain it," I said. "I didn't know what it was."

"I know," Sam said. "I waited."

I looked at him for a long moment. Seven years. He had known something was wrong for eight months and had waited, with the patience that was so entirely Sam, for me to find my way to saying it.

"Thank you," I said. "For waiting."

"Thank you for saying it," he said.

We sat with that for a moment. The festival was still audible, faintly, through the window — a rhythm, a melody, the sound of a city celebrating something.

"Can I tell you something?" Sam said.

Something in his tone made me put the tea down. "Yes," I said.

* * *

What Sam told me, I had not known. I want to be precise about this — I had known Sam for seven years, had been his friend through various things, had thought I knew the main facts of his life and most of the secondary ones. What he told me on that Friday afternoon in Dolka, sitting on a hotel bed while a festival happened two streets away, was not a main fact. It was something he had been carrying quietly, in the specific way that Sam carried things — without making it anyone else's problem, without drama, with a thoroughness of containment that was both admirable and, I now understood, costly.

His work — the design work, the graphic design that he had described to Tomáš in Drevska as his profession and which I had always understood as something he was good at and content with — had been, for the last year and a half, a source of a specific kind of misery that he had not shared with anyone. Not misery about the quality of the work. The work was good. He was, and remained, very good at it. The misery was about what the work was for.

He had been commissioned, for eighteen months, primarily by two clients — a marketing firm and a financial services company — who paid well and required a great deal and whose requirements had the specific quality of requirements that are very clear about what they want and entirely uninterested in whether what they want is good. Not unethical, not harmful — just empty. Work made not because it needed to exist but because a budget had been allocated and the budget required output. He had been producing this output with professional thoroughness and had felt, with increasing intensity, that the output was going nowhere — not into the world in any meaningful sense, not into the hands of people who needed it or would be changed by it, but simply into a filing system somewhere and eventually, probably, a hard drive that no one would look at again.

"I've been thinking about stopping," he said. "The clients. Not design — design. Just those clients. Starting again with something smaller. Something that—" he paused, and I recognised the pause, because it was the pause I had had at every point in the trip where I had tried to find the words for the thing I had been carrying— "something that goes somewhere," he said. "That lands on something real."

"When did you start thinking about this?" I asked.

"Before the trip," he said. "It's partly why I suggested it."

I looked at him. "Not just for me."

"Not just for you," he said. "For both of us. I thought—" he looked at the window, at the rooftops, at the Dolka sky— "I thought if we went somewhere different, without the clients and the briefs and the daily obligations of it, maybe something would become clear. About what to do next."

"Has it?"

He was quiet for a moment. Outside, a burst of music — something particularly alive, a moment in the festival that was reaching a peak somewhere.

"Yes," he said. "Nela, mostly. Watching her work. The way she talked about painting — the wall wanting something, the image finding itself. I'd forgotten that design could feel like that. I used to know. I'd forgotten."

"What are you going to do?" I asked.

"I'm going to tell the clients I can't take their next brief," he said. "And then I'm going to sit with the uncomfortable feeling that produces and see what I do with it."

I thought about the demolished building. The layers. Things that were underneath, still there, waiting to be uncovered.

"You should have told me," I said.

"You had your own version of it," he said. "I didn't want to add mine."

"That's not—" I stopped. Started again. "We're supposed to add them to each other. That's what this is."

Sam looked at me. Something shifted in his expression — not dramatically, not the way expressions shift in films, but the small, real shift of someone receiving something they needed.

"Yes," he said. "I know. I'm better at being the one who helps than the one who needs it."

"I know," I said. "I've been watching you do it for seven years."

"Annoying?" he said.

"Occasionally," I said. "Also one of the things I value most about you. But you're allowed to need things. You're a person. It's permitted."

Sam smiled — the small, genuine one. "Thank you," he said. "For the reminder."

"Any time," I said. "I mean that literally. Any time."

He nodded. We sat in the room as the afternoon moved around us, the light shifting on the rooftops in the Dolka way, the festival continuing its life two streets away. Neither of us said anything for a while, and the silence had the quality of a silence that has been earned — the silence after something has been said that needed saying, the particular peace of two people who have been more honest with each other than they usually manage and have found that the honesty, rather than changing things, has simply made what was always there more visible.

* * *

I slept for an hour. This was Sam's suggestion, delivered not as a command but as the obvious next step in the same matter-of-fact tone he used for most things, and I accepted it in the same spirit and lay on the bed in the room at the Hotel Three Lights and slept the deep, immediate sleep of someone whose body has been waiting for this and is not going to waste the opportunity.

When I woke the light had changed. It was half past three. The cold was still there — it was not the kind of cold that resolves in a nap, it was a two-or-three-day cold and I was going home tomorrow and it would travel with me — but the hour of sleep had put some distance between me and it, the way sleep always puts distance between you and the things that were too close.

I sat on the edge of the bed and looked at the window and felt, with the specific clarity that sometimes arrives after sleep in unfamiliar places, that the afternoon was the right shape and I was, for the moment, the right size for it.

I knocked on Sam's door. He was reading, naturally.

"Ready?" he said.

"Ready," I said.

* * *

The festival in the late afternoon was, as Sam had predicted and as I should have trusted, different from the festival in the morning — not better or worse in any absolute sense, but better for me at this hour, in this condition, in this particular stage of the trip.

The morning version had been full and loud and alive in the way of things at their height. The afternoon version had settled into something more sustained, the initial exuberance having burned down to a deeper, steadier warmth. The crowds had thinned slightly without the festival diminishing — those who remained were the ones who had been there all day and intended to stay until the end, and they had the quality of people who are not performing enjoyment but experiencing it, which is a different thing and produces a different atmosphere.

The light was doing what Sam had known it would do. The October afternoon sun, low and particular, was coming in at an angle that caught the pale stone of the buildings and the colours of the festival decorations and the faces of the people in the square and turned everything to something more saturated and more warm, the specific light that makes ordinary things look as though they have been given extra substance, as though the world has been briefly upgraded.

Sam photographed continuously — not frantically, not with the desperate energy of someone trying to capture everything, but with the quiet selectivity of someone who knows what he is looking for and waits for it to appear. I watched him work for a while and saw, in the way he moved through the square, the quality that Nela had put into words — the sense of someone for whom the thing being made and the maker are in genuine conversation, each informing the other.

I did not photograph anything. I had not taken a single photograph on the whole trip, which I had not noticed until this moment. I had the notebook. Sam had the camera. Between us we had covered it.

There was a group of musicians in the centre of the square — not the overlapping layers of the morning, but a single ensemble now, eight people, playing something that had the quality of the music Irena had played on the cello, the same deep minor-key seriousness of things that contain multiple feelings at once. People had gathered around them in a wide circle. Children were at the front, sitting cross-legged with the complete attention that children give to things that hold them. Behind the children, adults — standing, listening, some with their eyes closed.

I stood at the edge of the circle and listened.

The music did the thing that Irena's music had done — made the space around it more present, made the people in it more aware of being there. I was aware of the cold, and of the three weeks behind me, and of the conversation in the hotel room, and of Sam beside me, and of the flight tomorrow, and of the green notebook in my bag with its forty-three pages, and of the corner of my street in April where the light would be doing something I had never noticed. I was aware of all of it simultaneously, the way you are sometimes aware of your whole life at once — not anxiously, not with any particular urgency, just with the simple, clear awareness of a person who is, at this moment, entirely present in it.

I looked at Sam. He was watching the musicians with his camera lowered, not photographing. Just watching.

"This is it," I said.

He did not ask what I meant. He knew what I meant. "Yes," he said. "This is it."

We stood in the Starý Trh on a Friday afternoon in October, in the last hours of the last full day of the trip, while the music did its thing and the light did its thing and Dolka went on being exactly what it was, and neither of us said anything else for a while because there was nothing else to say that the moment was not already saying more eloquently.

* * *

Felix had dinner ready when we came back at seven — not the formal arrangement of the other night, just food on the kitchen table behind the desk, the way families eat rather than the way hosts eat. He had made something with eggs and vegetables that was simple and exactly right, the food of someone who knows that sometimes simplicity is the correct ambition.

Irena joined us, in the way she had joined things on the previous dinner — naturally, without ceremony, as though the joining were simply the next obvious thing. She asked how the festival had been. I told her about the afternoon musicians. She listened with the attention of a musician hearing about music.

"That would be the Zachová ensemble," she said. "They play the last set every year. They've been doing it for — thirty years, maybe more. The oldest member is seventy-four. He was in the original ensemble."

"They were extraordinary," I said.

"They're honest," she said. "That's different from extraordinary. Extraordinary is a quality. Honest is a

commitment. They've played that music so many times that they've gotten past the performance of it and into the thing itself."

I wrote this down on the paper Felix had left on the table for exactly this purpose, which told me that Irena said things worth writing down regularly and that Felix had long since accommodated this.

"Honest rather than extraordinary," Sam said. "That's what you're aiming for in the notebook."

He said it to me, across the table, simply — not as a challenge or an instruction, just as an observation that happened to be accurate.

"Yes," I said. "I think so."

Irena looked between us with the expression of someone who has observed two people who know each other well and is pleased by what she sees.

"Good," she said, and passed the bread.

—

From the observations notebook, Dolka, the last full day:

Sam has been carrying something too. He carries things quietly, in the Sam way, without making them anyone else's problem. This costs him.

I wish he had told me sooner. I understand why he didn't.

Irena said: honest is a commitment. Extraordinary is a quality. I am trying to commit to honest.

The cold is still here. So is everything else. Both are fine.

Chapter Fifteen

The Last Night

In Which the City Does One Final Thing We Did Not Expect and We Understand, at Last, What We Have Been Given

I want to tell you about the last night first, because I have been building to it and it deserves its proper place at the beginning of this chapter rather than buried in the middle of the departure logistics, which are not the point.

After dinner with Felix and Irena — the eggs, the vegetables, Irena's distinction between honest and extraordinary, Sam saying across the table that honest was what I was aiming for in the notebook — we had come back upstairs and I had packed in the way you pack on the last night of a long trip, which is the packing of someone who is almost ready to go home and not quite. The clothes folded with the slight excess of care that comes from the knowledge that this is the last time — the jumper that had been rolled and unrolled in various hotel rooms across three countries, the jacket that had been rained on in Vranka and dried on a radiator in the guesthouse there, the boots that had walked Drevska and Vrest and Dolka and a wrongly named town in the rain.

The kohlrabi I had left on the windowsill. They had served their purpose — the pickle, the brief comedy of carrying them across two countries in a paper bag, the look on Sam's face when

they appeared at the airport in Stravnik and he had said nothing, which was the correct response. They were not coming home. The windowsill would keep them.

I had packed the green notebook last, between the softest things, the way you pack fragile items — not because it was physically fragile, it was a robust thing, the old man had made it to last, but because it felt like the thing that needed the most care. Forty-three pages now. More, after tonight, because I had written for an hour after packing, about the conversation with Sam, about the festival musicians, about Irena's word honest and what it meant to commit to it.

I turned out the light at eleven. The room was dark and familiar in the way of rooms you have slept in long enough to know their dark — where the window was, where the desk was, the shape of the light from the street on the ceiling. I lay and listened to the last of the festival, which was still happening somewhere in the city, a distant murmur of music and people, the city using its Friday night in the way it always used its Friday nights, indifferent to the fact that I was leaving in the morning.

I fell asleep faster than I had fallen asleep on any night of the trip.

* * *

I woke at five. Of course I woke at five. I had been waking at five for three weeks in city after city and I was not going to stop now simply because it was the last morning. My body had decided that five was the correct hour and was committed to the position.

The cold was lighter. Not gone — it would not be gone for another two or three days, it was that kind of cold — but lighter in the way of things that have passed their peak and are now declining. The throat was better. The eyes were better. I felt, by the standard of the previous day, approximately eighty percent of myself, which was sufficient.

I dressed quietly, as I had dressed on the early mornings in Vrest and Drevska. I took the observations notebook — the first one, almost full — and the pen. I did not take the green notebook. The green notebook was packed and staying packed. The observations notebook was for this morning, for the last things.

I left the room.

The hotel was entirely quiet. Felix's desk was unoccupied for the first time I could remember — Felix apparently slept, which I had not quite believed before this moment. The lobby had the particular quality of hotel lobbies at five in the morning: all the warmth and welcome of the day still present in the objects and the light and the arrangement of things, but empty of the person who animated it, the way a stage looks between performances. The lamp on the small table was still on. The painting of Felix's great-grandmother who found everything funny looked at me from the wall with her expression of permanent amusement. I looked back at her for a moment.

"Goodbye," I said to her, quietly. She continued to find things funny. This seemed right.

I went out into the street.

* * *

Dolka at five in the morning on a Saturday after a festival had the specific quality of a city the morning after something — the streets not quite returned to themselves yet, the cobblestones of the Starý Trh scattered with the evidence of the previous day, the stalls dismantled and gone but the space they had occupied still carrying a memory of them, the way a room still holds the shape of a party after the guests have left.

There were people cleaning. Not many — three or four, with the large brushes and the quiet purposefulness of people doing the work that happens after other people have been celebrating. They

moved through the square with the easy efficiency of people who have done this before and will do it again, and the square was re-emerging under their attention, returning to its daily self.

I walked through it slowly, watching them work.

A city cleaned after a festival is a specific and underrated sight. The cleaning is not the opposite of the festival — it is the continuation of it, the part that makes the next festival possible. You cannot separate them. The musicians and the street cleaners are part of the same thing, working at different ends of it.

I wrote this in the notebook, standing in the square at five-fifteen in the morning, with the brush sounds of the cleaners and the distant sound of someone's radio somewhere and the vast pale sky beginning its long, slow change toward dawn.

Then I walked to Colour Street.

* * *

I had known I would come back. I had known it since the previous evening when I said goodbye to the woman in the window in the dark and felt that I had said goodbye too quickly — that it was a departure undertaken before I was ready, which is its own kind of mistake.

This time I was ready.

The street in the early morning was the street as I had first seen it — quiet, unpeopled, the paintings doing what they did in the absence of viewers, which was simply being there, carrying whatever they carried, available or not available depending on who was looking.

I walked slowly from one end to the other, looking at everything, going through the whole conversation of the street one last time. The abstract work. The figurative work. The old paintings under the new, visible at edges and corners where the

newer work had not quite covered them. The places where different eras touched — where someone had painted around or over or in response to what was already there, continuing the argument that had been going on since the first brushstroke on the first wall.

I stopped at the woman in the window.

I had seen her in daylight and in dark and in the early morning before dawn and now in this particular hour — not quite dark, not quite light, the specific blue-grey of five-thirty when the darkness has begun its retreat but the day has not yet arrived. She was the most herself in this light. Not more beautiful — beautiful was not quite the right category for her, she was more interesting than beautiful. More present. The partial face with its specific expression, the patient hand on the sill, the geometric pattern covering her right side. All of it exactly as it had been, exactly as it would be after I was gone.

I stood in front of her for a long time.

I thought about what she had given me over the course of the week. Not deliberately — she was a painting on a wall, she had not been giving me anything with intention. But she had been there every time I needed to look at something, and each time she had shown me something different, which was the thing about images that contain real feeling: they change not because they change but because you change, and the change between you produces something new each time.

The first time: partial loss, something covered over, the sadness of incompleteness.

The second time: the hand. Patient. Waiting for itself to be ready.

The third time: the expression. Not waiting for something external. Waiting inward. The patience directed at the self.

This time: something else. Something I had not seen before or had not been in the condition to see. The hand on the sill was not only waiting. It was resting. It had been on this sill for however many years since Nela painted it, and it had been covered and partially lost and waited through all of it, and it was still here, still resting, still present. Not despite the covering. Through it. The covering had not diminished it. The covering was part of it now.

I stood in the blue-grey light of Colour Street at five-thirty in the morning and understood this, and it was so simple and so complete that I did not write it down immediately, which was unusual for me.

I wrote it down later, on the plane, when I was ready to have it in words.

I said goodbye to the woman in the window in the way I had said it before — internally, quietly, without ceremony. She continued to rest her hand on the sill with the patience of something that has been here longer than I have and will be here after I am gone and finds this not diminishing but simply true.

I walked back to the hotel.

* * *

Sam was up when I came in, which surprised me slightly — Sam's mornings were usually more gradual than mine, the waking happening in stages, the full presence arriving with the coffee rather than before it. But he was dressed and sitting at the desk in his room with his own notebook — not the kind of notebook I kept, not the observations-and-everything notebook, but the small sketchbook he carried and which I had seen him use only occasionally, drawing things quickly with a small pencil in the way of someone capturing something before it goes.

He was drawing the room. The armchair by the window. The window itself, with the rooftops beyond. The lamp.

"The last morning," I said, from the doorway.

"The last morning," he agreed, not looking up.

I sat on the edge of the bed and watched him draw for a few minutes. He drew with the same quality he brought to photography — the stillness, the selection, the sense of someone who knows what he is looking at and is waiting for the right moment rather than chasing it.

"The room?" I asked.

"The light in the room," he said. "It's different at this hour."

He had been listening, then. The ordinary light. Anya and Piotr and their six weeks of documenting what life actually looked like. He had been listening and had carried it to this morning and was sitting with his sketchbook at six in the morning drawing the light in the room before it changed.

"Good?" I asked.

"Getting there," he said.

We had breakfast at seven-thirty. Felix was back at his desk — he appeared between six and seven every morning, apparently, in the way of people whose relationship with their work is seamless rather than separate, who do not have a commute between their life and their job because the two are the same thing. He had made the bread and the plum preserve and the serious coffee and had arranged them on the table in the room behind the desk with the care he brought to everything.

Irena was there too, already, which I had not expected. She had the morning quality of someone who was always a morning person and had never found this remarkable — clear-eyed and present in the way of people for whom morning is simply where they are most fully themselves.

She had something with her. A piece of paper, folded once, which she placed on the table beside my coffee cup without comment and which I looked at but did not immediately open.

"What is it?" I asked.

"Something I wrote this morning," she said. "For you. For the notebook. Or for whatever the notebook becomes."

I looked at her. She had the expression of someone who has done a thing and is not going to make a larger thing of it than it is.

I opened the paper.

It was music. A short melody, handwritten on a small staff in Irena's precise hand, the notes clear and spaced and annotated with a few markings that I could not fully read — I am not a musician, the language of written music is one I understand in principle and cannot speak — but which had the quality of something that had been thought about and decided and written down with the same care she brought to the cello.

Beneath the staff she had written, in English: *For the green notebook. A melody for whatever is trying to find its shape. Play it in your head when you are stuck. It will not solve anything but it will remind you that the thing exists even when you cannot hear it.*

I sat with the piece of paper for a moment.

I have the piece of paper on my desk now, beside the notebooks, as I write this. I cannot play it — I cannot read music well enough to hear it properly in my head, despite Irena's instruction. But I look at it when I am stuck, as she said to, and something about the fact of it — the handwritten notes, the care in the spacing, the sentence beneath — does the thing she described. Reminds me the thing exists even when I cannot hear it.

"Thank you," I said, which was entirely insufficient and entirely all there was to say.

"Write well," she said. "That's thanks enough."

* * *

The taxi came at eight-fifteen, called by Felix at eight with the precision of someone for whom the relationship between a time and the actions required to meet it is a matter of mild personal honour.

We brought our bags down. The lobby had the quality it had in the early morning — all its warmth, Felix present now and fully himself behind the desk. He came out from behind the desk when we were ready, which was also entirely Felix — not waiting for us to come to him, coming to us.

He shook Sam's hand first. The handshake of someone who considers it a real thing — present in it, looking at him directly, holding it the appropriate length. Then mine.

He looked at us both for a moment with the assessing attention he had used when we arrived — the look that saw what was there rather than what was presented.

"You came here looking like people on a trip," he said. "You are leaving looking like people who have been somewhere and know it."

He had said something similar when we returned from Vranov. This time it was different — more complete, more final, the assessment of a journey rather than a leg of it.

"Because of this place," I said. "Partly."

"Because of you," he said, which was not false modesty — it was Felix being accurate, as he was always accurate. "The place was here. You were the ones paying attention."

He said this simply, without flourish, and then stepped back and indicated the waiting taxi in the way of someone whose point has been made and who has nothing to add to it.

I wrote it on the pavement outside, immediately, because I knew it would not stay accurately in memory if I left it.

Sam watched me write it. "What did he say?" he asked.

I showed him.

Sam read it. He nodded once. "Yes," he said. "That's it."

We got in the taxi.

* * *

Dolka went past the taxi windows in the morning light — the old city, the wider streets, the industrial approach. The same route in reverse as the one that had brought us from the bus station three weeks ago, or near enough. The same city seen differently, which was now a thing I understood rather than simply experienced.

I looked at it going past and felt the specific feeling of the last Drevska train — the thing being full — but with an additional quality that I had not had on that train, which was the feeling of having seen it through. Not just the city — the whole of it. Three weeks of it. All of it.

The driver was quiet. The morning was clear. The taxi took us efficiently and without drama to the airport, which was doing the Saturday morning thing of flights going everywhere and people beginning journeys that were just beginning for them the way ours was ending.

We checked in. We went through security, during which no one questioned my antacids, which had by now been depleted to three tablets and presented no ambiguity as to their nature or

purpose. We found Gate 19, which was at a reasonable distance from security — not the extreme distance of Gate 14 in Stravnik, three weeks ago, but a manageable walk that we did at the unhurried pace of people who have time and are using it.

We found seats. Sam took out his book. I took out the observations notebook.

I turned to the first entry.

Gate 14. Waiting. It is beginning.

I read from there to the last entry I had written in Dolka that morning, before I went to Colour Street. I read all of it — every entry, every city, every person, everything I had noticed and written down and carried forward from place to place in this small notebook that was now nearly full, the pages dense with handwriting that got slightly looser as the weeks went on, which was either the pen running more freely or the hand relaxing or both.

It took forty minutes.

When I finished I sat for a while with the closed notebook in my lap and looked at the departures board, which showed our flight on time, boarding in twenty-five minutes.

Three weeks. Three countries. Tomáš and Mrs Vachová and the courtyard and the key. Vrest and the beige apartment and the flower man and the old woman with the pigeons. Dolka and Nela and Felix and Irena and the demolished building and the rooftop and Colour Street and the woman in the window. Vranov and Oskar and the wrong town and Ludmila's soup. The market and the honey woman and the ten-hour notebooks. Karel on his bench. The festival musicians and the quality of the afternoon light. Sam saying *I could see you getting smaller.* Irena saying *honest is a commitment.* Felix saying *the place was here. You were the ones paying attention.*

All of it in this notebook.

All of it carrying forward.

"Boarding," Sam said, beside me.

The gate was opening. The familiar movement of people beginning.

"Ready?" Sam said.

I looked at the notebook in my lap. I looked at the gate. I thought about the apartment and the desk and the green notebook with its forty-three pages, waiting. I thought about the corner of my street in April, which I did not know yet but which was there, waiting — the light doing something I had never noticed, patient and present, exactly as it had always been.

"Yes," I said. "Let's go."

* * *

The flight home was four hours and twenty minutes, which I have mentioned before and which I mention again because the symmetry of it matters to me — the same duration as the flight out, the journey in perfect balance, the same length of sky between the leaving and the returning.

I did not watch a film. I did not listen to a podcast. I did not grip the armrest during turbulence, of which there was a small amount somewhere over the mountains, which I noticed and accepted and moved on from in the way I had not quite managed on the way out.

I wrote. In the observations notebook, in the last pages — the ones I had been saving without quite knowing I was saving them, the blank pages at the back that had been empty since Stravnik — I wrote about the woman in the window's hand. Not the version I had been circling around all week, the incomplete

version I had been approaching and retreating from. The full version. The thing about resting rather than waiting. The thing about the covering being part of it now. The thing about being still present through everything that had been placed over you, not despite it but through it.

It took the whole notebook. The last page ended in the middle of a sentence, which I finished in the margin, turned sideways, in smaller writing, because there was nowhere else to go and the sentence needed its ending.

Sam glanced over at one point and saw the margin writing.

"Running out of room?" he said.

"Just for this one," I said. "The green one has plenty."

He returned to his book. Outside, the mountains appeared below us, snow-capped and enormous, indifferent as ever. We passed over them and they gave way to the lower landscape of home, and then the city appeared, small and dense and familiar, going about its Saturday.

The wheels touched down.

The engines reversed.

The world slowed.

Someone near the back began to clap, and a few others joined in, and then it stopped, and then there was the ordinary sound of a plane at rest — the mechanical cooling and settling, the seatbelt signs clicking off, the first rustle of people beginning to gather themselves.

Sam and I sat for a moment while the other passengers stood and opened overhead bins and conducted the small bustling business of arrival.

"Well," I said.

"Well," Sam said.

It was not an inadequate response. It was, in fact, the only possible response — the same word that had served at every beginning and every ending of the trip, the word that meant: here we are, this is where we are, this is what there is, and it is sufficient.

We stood. We got our bags. We joined the queue shuffling toward the door.

I went through the door and down the jet bridge and into the terminal, which smelled of the universal airport smell — fuel and coffee and the particular industrial warmth of enclosed public spaces — and felt, for a moment, the gap between the world I was re-entering and the world I was leaving, the brief disorientation of the returned traveller that passes in minutes and leaves something behind when it goes.

Something behind is not nothing.

Something behind is, in fact, everything.

—

Last entry, observations notebook, volume one. Written in the margin, sideways, at thirty thousand feet:

The hand was not waiting for something to arrive. It was resting through everything that had already come. Still present. Still here.

The notebook is full. This seems right. The green one is waiting.

Chapter Sixteen

Going Back

In Which the Journey Home Turns Out to Be a Different Journey Entirely

I am writing this chapter from the other side of it — from the apartment, from the desk, from the ordinary Tuesday morning that the trip has made slightly extraordinary by returning me to it changed. I am writing it six days after landing, which is long enough to have the distance to see it whole and not so long that the details have softened into pleasantness. The details are still sharp. I want to keep them sharp.

This is what going back was.

* * *

The taxi to the airport came at eight-fifteen, as I described at the end of the previous chapter, and Dolka went past the windows in the way that Dolka went past windows — the old city, the wider streets, the industrial edge, the plain opening up — and I watched it all go with the specific attention of someone who knows they are looking for the last time and wants to take it properly.

Felix had stood at the door of the Hotel Three Lights and watched the taxi until it turned the corner. I had looked back and seen him there — the jacket, the upright posture, the hand raised

once in a gesture that was not quite a wave and not quite a salute but was entirely Felix, a gesture that meant: you have been here and I have seen you and this is the acknowledgment of that. Then the taxi turned and he was gone.

I thought about what he had said on the pavement, which I had written down immediately and which was in the notebook: *The place was here. You were the ones paying attention.* I had been turning this over since he said it. I was still finding things in it.

Sam, beside me in the taxi, was looking out his own window. He had the sketchbook on his knee — the one he had been drawing in that morning at six, the light in the room. He was not drawing now, just holding it, with the particular quality of someone in transit between one thing and another.

"Are you all right?" I asked.

"Yes," he said. "Just—" He looked at the city going past. "I keep thinking about what I'm going to do when I get back."

"The clients," I said.

"The clients," he said. "And the other thing. What comes after."

"The same as me," I said. "Sit with the uncomfortable feeling and see what you do with it."

He looked at me. "Your words or mine?"

"Yours," I said. "From yesterday. I wrote them down."

He smiled — the small, genuine one. "Of course you did."

The taxi reached the airport. We got out. The trip, in the practical sense of it — the moving through places with bags — was nearly over.

* * *

Felix invited us to dinner.

He did it in the way he did everything — directly, without ceremony, as a statement that was also an offer, which you could technically decline but which carried in it the clear implication that declining would be a mistake. He was closing the ledger at six-thirty when we came back through the lobby, and he looked up and said: "Come to dinner tonight. My wife is cooking. She cooks better than anywhere you'll eat otherwise."

I thought about the duck at U Tří Mostů. I thought about Ludmila's soup. I thought about the trout in Vranov and the stew in Vrest and the things this trip had done to my understanding of what food could be.

"We'd be honoured," Sam said.

Felix looked at him. "Don't be honoured. Just come. Seven o'clock. Up the stairs, third floor."

He returned to his ledger. We went to change.

* * *

Felix's apartment was on the third floor of the hotel, which was also his home, which was a fact that I found immediately right — the idea of Felix living inside the thing he ran, present in it completely rather than arriving and leaving, as inseparable from the Hotel Three Lights as the deep red walls and the table lamp and the painting of his great-grandmother who found everything funny.

His wife's name was Irena. She was perhaps forty, with the particular quality of people who are genuinely interested in other people — not as a social performance but as a real and continuing curiosity, the quality of someone for whom other people are endlessly interesting and who shows this not by asking a lot of

questions but by listening in a way that makes you feel entirely attended to. She was also, as Felix had said, an extraordinary cook.

There were two friends there as well — a man named David who taught mathematics at the local school and who had the specific energy of someone who finds their subject genuinely exciting and cannot fully understand why others do not, and a woman named Petra, who was not the ceramicist from the makers' market in Dolka but a different Petra, a translator who worked between four languages and who said, when asked what that was like, that it was like living in four houses simultaneously, each one slightly different in its layout, and that she had long since stopped remembering which house she was in at any given moment, which she found liberating rather than disorienting.

We sat at a round table in a room lined with books — not arranged for effect, not the decorative books of people who want to appear to have read things, but the working books of people who actually read, organised by a system that was partly logical and partly personal and occasionally abandoned altogether in favour of simply putting things where there was room. On the wall opposite was a painting — one of Nela's, I recognised the style immediately, a cityscape in three colours that was Dolka without being a picture of Dolka, the essence of it rather than the image.

"You know Nela," I said to Felix.

"Since she arrived here eight years ago," he said, pouring wine. "She came with two bags and a box of paints and stayed."

"She told us she stayed for the light."

"She stayed for the light first," Felix said. "Then she found the other things. The light was the reason that got her here. Everything else was the reason she didn't leave."

He said this simply, not as wisdom, just as a fact about someone he knew well. But I wrote it in the observations notebook later, because it seemed true about more than Nela.

Irena's cooking was everything Felix had promised and something more, which was the quality of food made for people you wanted to feed rather than for people you were obliged to. There was a soup of roasted peppers and something smoky that had a depth I associated by now with this part of the world — the depth of cooking that does not hurry. There was a main course of lamb with preserved lemon and herbs that I could not name, and a flatbread that arrived with it warm from the oven and which David ate three pieces of while maintaining the expression of a man who knows he is eating more bread than is advisable and has decided that advice is for other evenings.

The conversation at the table was the kind that happens when people who are different in various ways find, unexpectedly, that they share something more important than their differences. We talked about travel and about staying, which were the two sides of the same question and which everyone at the table had thought about. David had grown up in Dolka and left for university and come back and taught mathematics for fifteen years and found, he said, that Dolka was more interesting the more carefully he looked at it, which was a thing he had not expected to find and which had surprised him enough that he had stayed to keep looking. Petra had come from elsewhere and stayed, like Nela, and had the translator's relationship with belonging — comfortable in many places, completely at home in none of them, which she had made her peace with in a way that seemed, from the outside, like a form of freedom.

Felix and Irena had met in this city and built their life in this building and had, between them, the settled ease of people who had made choices deliberately and lived with them fully. Not without difficulty — they mentioned the difficult years in the way that people who have come through something mention it, lightly and without drama — but with the specific peace of people who know what they have.

"What will you do when you go back?" Irena asked me, at some point in the evening when the wine had been poured a second time and the conversation had become the kind that happens when formality has dissolved and what is left is simply people talking.

I thought about the green notebook in my bag upstairs. The first page, written in Berta's sitting room in Vranov. The farmer's words at the top of the second page. The beginning of something that did not have a name yet.

"Write," I said. It was the first time I had said it as a statement rather than a wish.

Irena looked at me with the attending quality of her attention. "What will you write?"

"This," I said, which surprised me by being true.

She smiled. "Then you should pay attention to everything," she said. "Even the things that seem small. Especially the things that seem small."

"I've been doing that," I said. "I have a notebook."

"Two notebooks," Sam said, from across the table.

"Two notebooks," I agreed.

Felix looked at Sam with the slight sideways attention of someone who has observed something and found it confirming. "You planned the trip," he said to Sam. It was not a question.

"I suggested it," Sam said.

"Same thing."

Sam smiled and said nothing, which was the truest possible response.

After dinner Irena played.

I say this simply because it happened simply — she stood up at some point, without announcement, and went to the corner of the room where there was an instrument I had not noticed, a cello, and she sat with it and began to play.

I want to try to describe what she played because I think it deserves an attempt, though I want to be honest that music is the hardest thing to put into words, which may be why it exists in the first place — to say the things that words cannot manage.

What she played was slow, and was in a minor key, and had the quality of something very old — not old in a museum way, old in the way of things that have been played and heard and passed down because they contain something true, something that people recognised in them across the years and needed to keep. It was not sad, exactly, though there was sadness in it. It was the kind of music that contains sadness the way autumn contains sadness — not as the whole of itself but as an element, alongside other things, and the combination of the elements being more true than any of them alone.

It did something to the room. I can only say it like that — it did something to the room, changed the quality of the air in it, made the people in it more present to each other and to themselves. David stopped eating bread. Petra put down her wine. Felix sat with his hands in his lap and looked at his wife with the expression of a man who has heard this many times and still finds it, every time, necessary.

I looked at Sam. He was looking at the ceiling, eyes bright, which was Sam being moved and not quite managing to hide it, which he rarely failed to hide and which told me something about what the music was doing.

She played for perhaps twenty minutes. When she finished there was a silence that lasted long enough to be its own thing —

not the absence of sound but the presence of what the music had left behind.

Then David said, in a voice slightly different from his normal voice: "She always does that."

"Does what?" Sam asked.

"Makes the room into something else." He looked at Irena. "Every time."

Irena put the cello back in its corner with the same lack of ceremony with which she had picked it up. "It's just the music," she said. "The music does it. I'm the person who happens to be holding it."

I wrote this down. She saw me do it and said nothing, which was, I was beginning to understand, what people did when they were comfortable with being recorded — they let it happen, because they had said the true thing and the true thing did not need protecting.

* * *

We said goodnight to Felix and Irena and David and Petra at eleven, with the warmth of people who have spent an evening together that none of them had planned and which had become, in the way of unplanned evenings, better than any planned one would have managed.

In the corridor outside the apartment, walking back down the stairs, Sam said: "I didn't expect that."

"No," I said.

"Felix inviting us to dinner."

"No."

"Irena."

"No."

We were quiet on the stairs.

"The best things," I said. "Again."

"The best things," Sam said. "Always."

* * *

I woke at five-thirty on the last morning. The flight was at ten. The alarm was set for seven. I lay in the dark for approximately three minutes and then got dressed quietly and took the observations notebook and went out.

Dolka at five-thirty in the morning was the city at its most private. Not the early morning of the market towns, which had a purposefulness to them even before dawn — the delivery vans, the stall preparations, the bakers who had been up since three. Dolka at this hour was simply asleep, or as asleep as cities ever are, the streets empty and the windows dark and the only sounds the abstract sounds of a city's infrastructure conducting itself without an audience.

I walked with no particular direction and no map, in the way I had been walking since Drevska, since the morning in Vrest, since Tomáš had said put the map away and follow me. The city in the dark was the city without its surface — the daytime colours gone, the buildings reduced to their shapes, the sky above the rooftops a deep blue that was lightening almost imperceptibly at the eastern edge, the slow approach of dawn happening at its own pace, indifferent to whether anyone was watching.

I walked through the Starý Trh, which was empty and enormous without its market and its people — just the cobblestones and the buildings and the guitarist's steps, silent, and the cathedral at the far end lit from below and more serious in the dark than in the day. I walked along the river, which was doing its eternal, indifferent thing, and I thought about all the rivers on

the trip — the river at Drevska that had broken the light into strips, the invisible river beside the path in Vranov, the Vrest river where the heron had stood on its post with complete commitment — and how each of them had been the same kind of thing and entirely different, which was true of most things if you looked carefully enough.

I walked to Colour Street.

In the dark, before dawn, the paintings were different. The colours were gone — reduced to shapes and tones, the whole elaborate, layered argument of the street simplified by the absence of light into something more essential. I walked slowly, looking at the shapes of things I had seen in colour, and they were still themselves, still legible, just quieter.

I stopped at the woman in the window.

In the dark, she was almost invisible — a presence rather than a painting, a shape against the wall that you would not know was a woman unless you already knew. The hand on the sill was still there, the patient hand, the waiting hand. I could just make it out.

I stood in front of her for the last time and said goodbye in the way you say goodbye to things that cannot hear you, which is internally and without any particular ceremony, just the acknowledgment of having been here and having seen this and carrying it away.

Then I walked back through the old city as the sky lightened and Dolka began, incrementally, to wake — a light here, a door there, the first delivery van of the morning moving through a side street with the focused efficiency of the early hour — and I felt the specific feeling that I had felt on the last morning in Drevska and that I now understood was simply the feeling of being properly somewhere and knowing you are about to leave it.

Not sadness, exactly. Something more complex and more accurate than sadness. The feeling of a thing being full.

* * *

At the airport, waiting for the flight at a gate that was — naturally, inevitably — at the very end of the terminal, I opened the observations notebook and read it from the beginning.

I had not done this before. I had been writing in it continuously since Stravnik, adding things as they happened, but I had not gone back to the beginning and read it through. I did this now, in the uncomfortable chair at Gate 31, with the departures board showing our flight and the terminal doing the morning airport thing around me — the coffees and the newspapers and the rolling suitcases and the children who were either asleep or inexplicably awake — and I read everything.

The first entry: *Gate 14. Waiting. It is beginning.*

The sky above the clouds. The mountains. Drevska from the air — the river, the bridges, the castle.

Mrs Vachová and her requirements. The bakery on Kamenná. Tomáš at the mushroom stall. The courtyard with the ivy turning copper. The key. The cellar café.

The train leaving Drevska. *Three days was not enough.*

Vrest. The beige apartment. The argument that was not about the walls. The early morning walk — the flower man, the old woman and the pigeons, the man in the plastic chair who invited a stranger into his courtyard.

Sam at the kitchen table: *you seem lighter.*

Dolka. Felix. Colour Street. The woman in the window. Nela with paint on her hands. The demolished building and its layers. The rooftop and the enormous sky. The bowl that came out wrong.

The river. Nela saying: *the best writing is the kind that hasn't decided yet what it is.*

Sam saying: *I could see you getting smaller.*

Vranov. Oskar and his potholes. The wrong town. Ludmila's soup. The forty-five minutes of the lost phone. Sam's face afterward.

The market. The honey woman. The ten-hour notebooks. The farmer and the kohlrabi. *When you grow something yourself you know it from the beginning.*

The green notebook, opened. The first page written.

Felix saying: *now you look like people who have been somewhere.*

The woman in the window's hand. The cello. Irena saying: *pay attention to the small things. Especially the small things.*

I read all of it. It took forty minutes. Sam sat beside me and read his book and left me to it, in the way he had left me to things throughout the trip — present, available, not intervening.

When I finished I closed the notebook and sat with it in my lap and looked at the departures board, where our flight was showing as boarding in twenty minutes.

I had been gone for three weeks. I had been to three countries. I had eaten the best duck of my life and the best soup and the best bread and a mustard that deserved its own chapter. I had been in a courtyard that belonged to no one and everyone, in a demolished building whose walls showed every version of itself, in a street where a woman waited patiently in paint for something she knew how to wait for. I had met Tomáš and Mrs Vachová and Nela and Felix and Irena and Ludmila and the honey woman and the man who made notebooks one at a time and the farmer who knew things from their beginnings. I had missed a bus and got on

the wrong minibus and arrived in the wrong town and found it to be the best day of the trip.

I had started writing again.

This is the thing I want to say, at the end of this particular part of the account, before the boarding and the flight and the landing and the return to the ordinary. Not that the trip changed everything — it did not change everything, the job was still the job and the apartment was still the apartment and the routine would reassemble itself, as routines do, within days of my return. Not that I came back transformed, which would be too large a claim and probably untrue.

What I want to say is this: I came back with the green notebook, which had seven pages in it. I came back with the observations notebook, which was almost full. I came back lighter, as Sam had said, and I came back knowing — with the specific, grounded knowledge of someone who has found evidence rather than just hope — that the thing I had stopped doing was not gone. It had been underneath. Like the layers in the demolished building. Like the woman in the window under the geometric pattern. Still there, waiting, patient, with its hand on the sill.

I had not talked myself out of it on the train from Drevska or on the bus with Oskar or in the beige apartment or at any of the other junctions where I had talked myself out of things before. I had written instead. And writing was how I would keep not talking myself out of it, one page at a time, for as long as it took to find out what it was.

"Boarding," Sam said, beside me.

I looked up. The gate was opening. People were beginning the familiar surge.

"Ready?" Sam said.

I put the notebook in my bag. I picked up the bag. I thought about whether I was ready to go back and decided the question was the wrong question, because going back was not the opposite of going forward. Going back was just the next part of the same thing.

"Yes," I said. "Let's go."

* * *

The flight home was four hours and twenty minutes, the mirror of the flight out, and I spent it differently from how I had spent the first one.

I did not watch a Christmas dog film. I did not listen to eleven minutes of a podcast I had not downloaded properly. I did not grip the armrest during turbulence, or at least I gripped it less, and with less conviction, as though the turbulence had become less alarming now that I had spent three weeks in conditions where the plan regularly failed and the failure regularly produced something better than the plan.

I wrote. Not in the green notebook — that was for the other thing, the thing being grown from the beginning. In the observations notebook, in the last few remaining pages, I wrote about the last morning in Dolka, the dark city, the woman in the window, the feeling of a thing being full.

Sam read his book. He finished it somewhere over the mountains, which appeared below us again, snow-capped and enormous and exactly as they had been on the way out, entirely indifferent to the fact that we were different people from the ones who had passed over them three weeks ago.

"Good?" I asked, when he closed it.

"Very."

"What was it about?"

He thought about it in the Sam way. "A man who pays attention," he said. "To a place he already knows. And finds it inexhaustible."

I looked at him. He looked at me. We had known each other for seven years and had not, until three weeks ago, gone anywhere together properly, and the three weeks had produced something that the seven years had not quite managed, which was not that we were different friends — we were the same friends — but that we knew it more fully now, had tested it in the way that things reveal their quality under conditions that matter.

"Thank you," I said. "For suggesting the trip."

"Thank you for coming," he said.

Outside, the mountains gave way to foothills, and the foothills to plains, and the plains to the more familiar landscape of home — the roads and the towns and the industrial approach to the airport, universal and unbeautiful and, this time, not unwelcome. The city appeared below, and it was small, as cities always are from above, and it was full of people going about their Tuesday in the complete and reasonable ignorance of the fact that I had been somewhere and was coming back altered.

The wheels touched down. The engines reversed. The world slowed.

Nobody clapped. This was, I felt, the appropriate response.

* * *

I took a taxi from the airport. The driver did not speak much, which I appreciated. The city went past the windows in the way cities go past taxi windows after long trips — familiar and slightly strange simultaneously, the way things look when you have been away long enough that the ordinary has become slightly remarkable again.

The apartment building was still crooked. The stairs still creaked on the third step. The apartment was the way I had left it — maps and guidebooks on the desk, the list that had grown to four pages, the coffee cup that had gone cold the morning I left and which I had washed before leaving and which was, therefore, clean, which was better than I might have expected.

I put the bag down. I stood in the middle of the room.

It was quiet and familiar and mine and it was, now, slightly smaller than I remembered — not in square footage, which had not changed, but in the particular way of spaces that have been left behind. You go somewhere and come back and the space you left has not grown but you have, and the fit is temporarily different. It adjusts. I knew it would adjust.

I took the green notebook out of the bag and put it on the desk. I put the observations notebook beside it. I put the small print from Nela — the woman in the window, the face and the hand and the geometric pattern at the edge — against the wall, leaning, to be hung properly later.

I stood and looked at the desk.

The notebooks. Nela's print. The maps and the guidebooks and the four-page list. The cold coffee cup, washed, waiting.

I sat down.

I opened the green notebook to the eighth page, where I had stopped in Vranov.

I picked up a pen.

I wrote the next sentence.

From the observations notebook, last entry, Dolka airport:

*Going back is not the opposite of going forward. It is the next part of
the same thing.*

*This notebook is almost full. The green one is just beginning. Both seem
right.*

Epilogue

Six Months Later

It is April. The city outside my window is doing the thing cities do in April — conducting spring with the slightly surprised energy of something that did not quite believe winter would end and is now making up for lost time. There are trees along the street below that were bare in October when I left and which are now in the first extravagant green of the season, the green that lasts only a few weeks before it deepens and becomes simply the colour of leaves rather than the colour of new leaves, which are two different colours and the second is the better one.

I am at my desk. On the desk are two notebooks — one almost full, one with forty-three pages written in it now, which is thirty-six more than it had when I came home in October. On the wall in front of me are Nela's prints — the woman in the window on the left, the river in three colours on the right. Between them, pinned to the wall with a single pin, is a square of paper tablecloth, slightly stained, with handwriting on it that is mine and which says: *The people are what happens when you show up and pay attention.* Sam said this. I wrote it down on a paper tablecloth in Vranov because I did not have the notebook to hand. It has been on my wall since October.

I still work in publishing. I still edit other people's books, which I am good at and which I have not stopped finding meaningful, because making other people's work clearer and better is a genuine thing to do and I had been wrong, before the trip, to find it insufficient. What I had found insufficient was doing only that — the absence of the other thing, the own thing, which has a different quality from the editing even when the editing is good. I know this now the way I know things I have found out rather than been told. It is a different kind of knowing.

The green notebook is the other thing. I will not tell you what it is yet because it is not finished and I have learned, from forty-three pages of it, that describing a thing before it is finished changes what it becomes, the way opening an oven too early changes the bread. It will be done when it is done. It will be what it needs to be. I am trying to trust this.

* * *

I went to the bakery on Kamenná street in my mind this morning, which is something I do occasionally — not with any particular nostalgia, just with the specific sensory recall that certain places leave behind. The žemle. The seeds on top. The woman who recognised us on the third visit. The faint sweetness underneath that I never identified and no longer need to.

Mrs Vachová sent a message in January. Not an email — a postcard, handwritten, in her precise and unambiguous hand. It said: *The city is different in winter. The bakery is the same. Come in spring.* I have the postcard on my desk beside the notebooks. I am considering spring.

Tomáš I think of often, in the way you think of people who said something true to you at the right moment. He is in Drevska, I imagine, at the market on Thursdays, at the café most mornings, at his allotment in the afternoons, paying attention to his one thing properly. I hope his city is doing well by him. I think it is. Some things you can tell.

Nela sent photographs of the wall she had painted — the building that the owner had finally agreed to give her. It is large and complex and I cannot fully make it out from the photographs but there is something in the upper left corner that looks, from this distance and this angle, like a hand on a sill. I have not asked her about it. Some things are better as possibilities.

Felix wrote once, briefly, to say that David had finally reported the pothole on the road outside the school to the relevant

authority — not for the first time, apparently, and not expecting results, but because some things required continued resistance. I wrote back to say that this seemed exactly right and that I hoped the pothole eventually got fixed while also understanding that the fixing was not entirely the point.

Sam I see on Thursdays, usually, at a café near his studio that makes coffee with the same seriousness as Tomáš's place in Drevska, which is the minimum standard I now apply to coffee and which has simplified my life by reducing the number of cafés I consider acceptable, though Sam says this is snobbery and I say it is the application of what I learned and we have not resolved this and probably will not.

He is well. He printed the photograph of the heron — the one from the river path in Vrest, standing on its post with total commitment — and it is on the wall of his studio. He says it is there to remind him that sometimes the right thing is to be completely still and wait for the fish to come to you. I say that sometimes you have to go and find the fish. We have not resolved this either. I think we are both right. I think that is rather the point.

* * *

The trip was three weeks. I have now been home for six months, which is eight times longer than the trip, and the trip has not faded in the way I was afraid it would fade — has not become simply a collection of good memories softening at the edges into pleasantness, the way travel sometimes does when you are back long enough. It has not faded because I have not let it. The notebooks. The prints. The paper tablecloth. The postcard.

And the writing. Which keeps the trip alive in a way that memory alone does not, because writing makes you look at things again rather than simply remembering them, and looking at them again you find things you missed the first time, and finding things you missed gives you something the trip itself did not quite give

you, which is the understanding of it. Not all the understanding — I am not sure you ever get all of it. But enough. Enough to know what it was for, and what it changed, and what to do next.

I know what it was for. I know what it changed. I am doing what to do next.

That is, I think, sufficient.

* * *

There is one more thing I want to tell you, which happened last week and which I have been saving because it seems like the right place to end.

I was walking home from work — a Tuesday, nothing particular about it, the city going about its business in the ordinary way of cities on ordinary days — and I turned a corner and the light was doing something to the buildings that I had not seen before, a low April light at the end of the afternoon, catching the old stone of the building on the corner at an angle that turned it a colour between gold and amber. The same colour the buildings had been in Dolka. Not identical — this was a different city, a different stone, a different latitude — but the same quality of it, the same warmth, the same sense of light doing something deliberate with what it was given.

I stopped.

I stood on the pavement in the April evening and looked at the building and it was, in that specific light, at that specific angle, extraordinary. I had walked past this building hundreds of times. I had never properly seen it.

I took out the observations notebook — I carry it still, I will always carry it, it is in a different volume now but it is the same notebook in the way that things are the same when their purpose continues — and I wrote: *The light is doing something on the

corner of my street that I have never noticed before. I do not know how long it has been doing this. I suspect a long time.*

I put the notebook away. I stood for another moment with the light on the building.

Then I walked home.

— *End* —

From the observations notebook, volume two, April:

*The light is doing something on the corner of my street that I have
never noticed before.*

I do not know how long it has been doing this. I suspect a long time.

Acknowledgements

A book about paying attention could not have been written without a great many people who were worth paying attention to.

To my family, whose support has never wavered and whose patience with a writer in their midst has been, on more occasions than I care to count, nothing short of remarkable: I owe you more than these pages can hold, and I know it.

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To the places that gave themselves up slowly, that required patience and wrong turns and extra days and the willingness to put the map away: thank you for being more interesting than anything I could have planned.

And to the readers who have picked up this book and given it their time: a writer asks for nothing greater. There is no adequate way to thank someone for the gift of being read, but I want to try. This book was written for you — for anyone who has ever felt the gap between the life they are living and the life they suspect they might be capable of, and who needed, perhaps, the permission of someone else's story to close it.

With gratitude,

Dolat Khan

About the Author

Dolat Khan is a writer from Quetta, Balochistan, with a deep conviction that the most important things in life are found in the details other people walk past. His writing is drawn to the ordinary made extraordinary — the conversation that changes something, the meal that is better than it had any right to be, the city that gets under your skin before you have had time to defend yourself against it.

Two Bags, No Plan is his second book. Where his debut novel *Before I Learned to Live* explored the interior landscape of love and loss, this book turns outward — to the road, to the stranger, to the particular freedom of being somewhere no one knows your name — while remaining, at its heart, a story about the same essential questions: who we are, what we have been missing, and what it takes to find it.

He believes that paying attention is a discipline, that the best things are usually eight minutes past the edge of where you have already been, and that the wrong town in the rain can, under the right circumstances, be the best day of your life.

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